



Built to Change: Cities of Choice 4.0

Global City Ranking

Full report

MAY 2026

CENTER FOR
**The Future
of Cities**



Table of contents



Section 1 - Our approach and key insights



Section 2 - Top 20 cities by dimensions



Section 3 - Ranking by groups



Section 4 - Key forward-looking themes



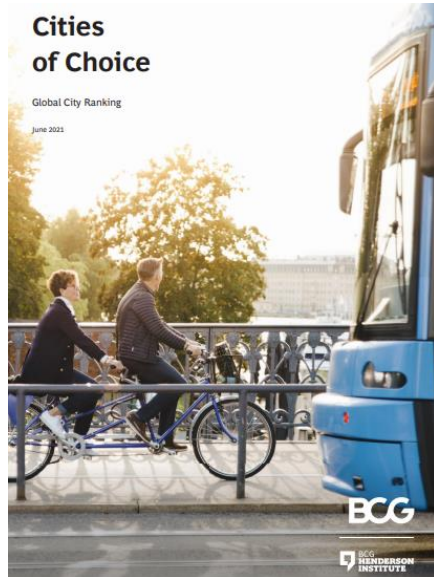
Section 5 - Appendix: ranking methodology



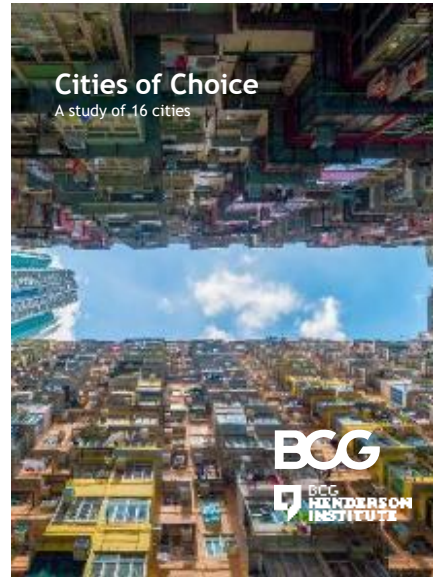
Section 1

Our approach and key insights

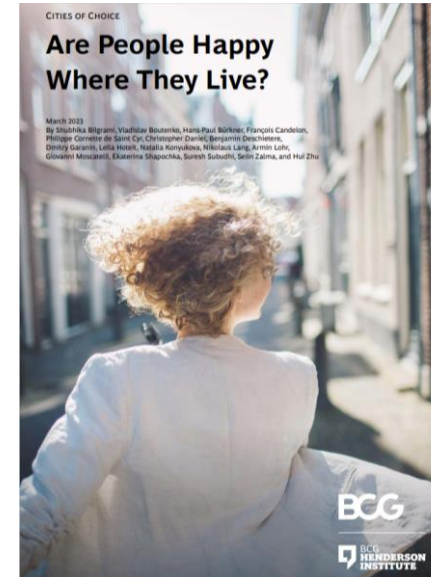
Three editions of *Cities of Choice* have been published, and a fourth edition, *Built to Change*, was launched at World Urban Forum 13 in Baku in May



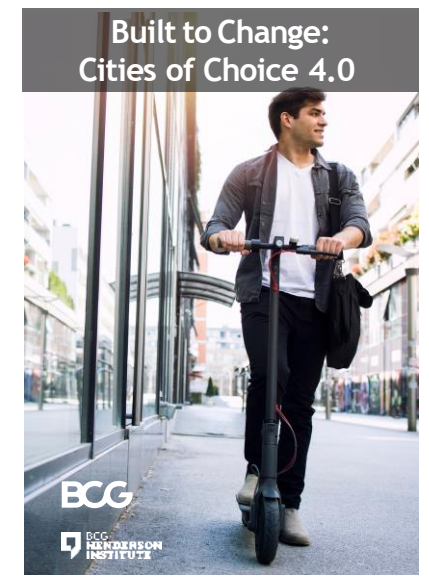
2019-2020



2020-2021



2022-2023



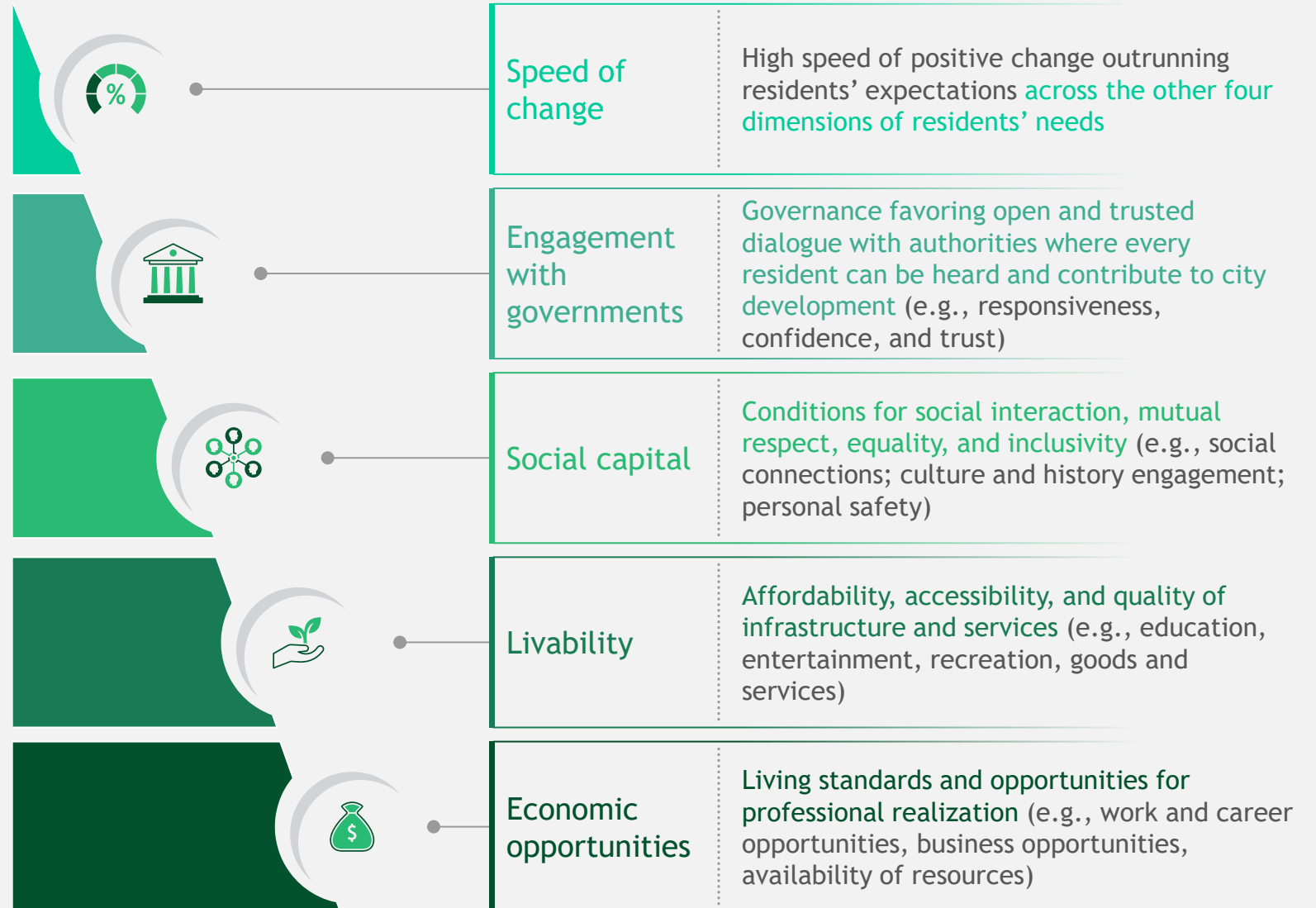
2025-2026

Deep dives

- Housing affordability
- Longevity in the city
- Online adepts
- New AI and robotics wave and cities' labor market
- Connected cities

BCG's *Cities of Choice* 4.0 assesses cities across five dimensions of resident value proposition

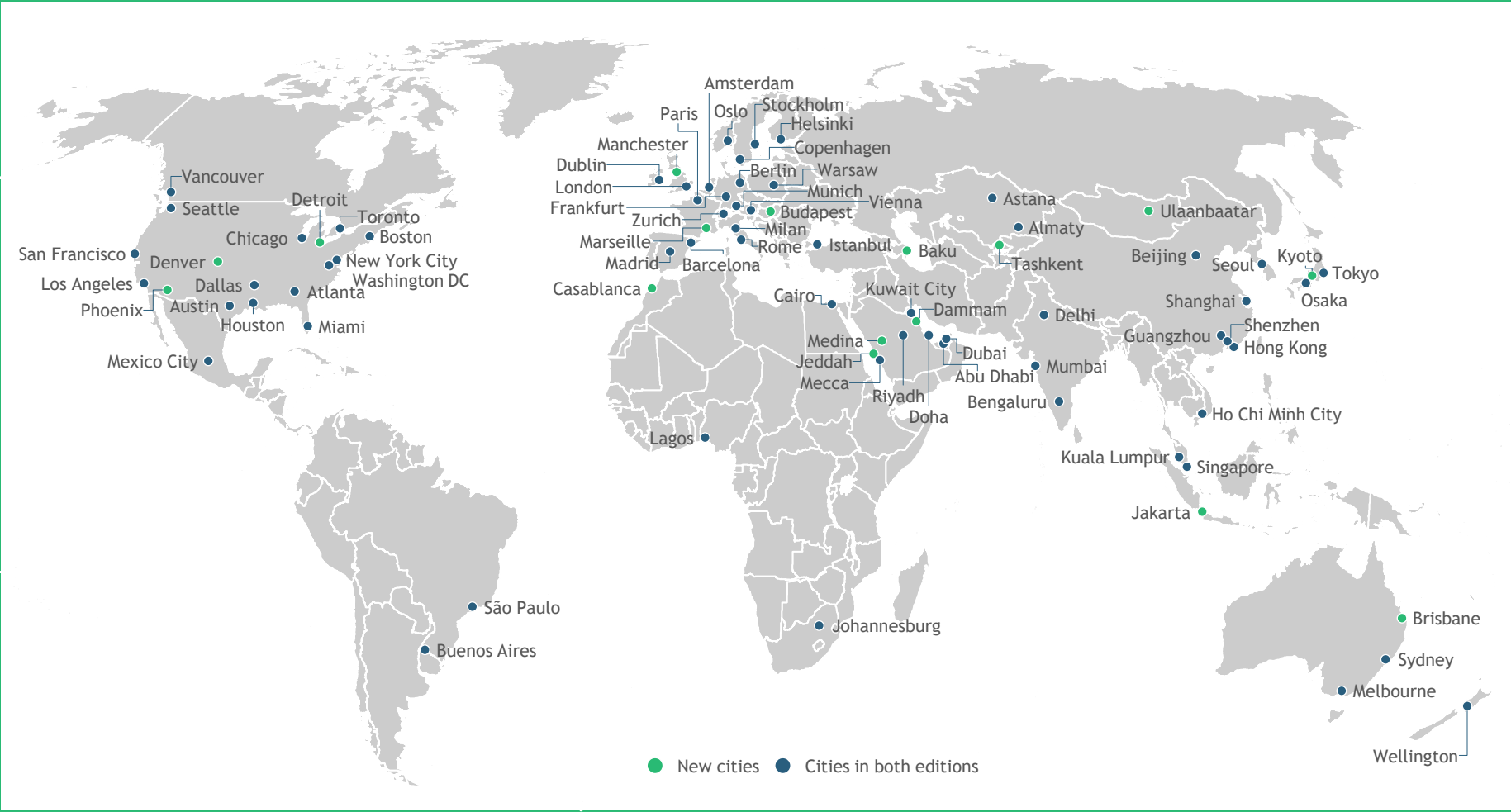
- 80 cities
- 200+ indicators
- 80% objective data
- 20% of data from survey of 24,000 residents
- 10 years longitudinal data
- 5+ million data points



This edition also assesses 26 elements across five dimensions

 Economic opportunities	 Livability	 Social capital	 Engagement with governments	 Speed of change
Opportunities for work, career, and earnings	Housing	Social connections	Ability to influence events	Speed of change in economic opportunities
Equality income	Mobility	Inclusivity and equality	Government services	Speed of change in livability
Opportunities for business	Medical care	Identity with culture and history	Business environment	Speed of change in social capital
Availability of personal loans	Education and development	Safety		Speed of change in engagement with governments
	Public spaces			
	Consumption of goods and services			
	Entertainment and recreation			
	Ecology			
	Cleanliness and hygiene			
	Comfortable climate			
	Resilience to emergency situations			

Cities of Choice 4.0 covers 80 cities



80 global cities included in the ranking, compared with 79 in the last edition (2023)

Key insight: Speed of change is becoming a winning formula for the future



1. Urban competition has shifted from infrastructure to lived outcomes

- Success is no longer measured by assets (roads, airports, utilities) but by what they **deliver to residents**
- Cities compete on **time saved, friction reduced, and quality of everyday life**
- Focus has moved from technical performance to **resident-level value creation**



2. Value today means surplus time, richer experiences, and investable prosperity

- **Mobility = surplus time** enabled by smart transport and seamless digital services
- **Comfort = depth and variety of life** (culture, community, learning, nature, opportunity)
- **Prosperity = investable surplus**, not just salaries but also real take-home life value after costs

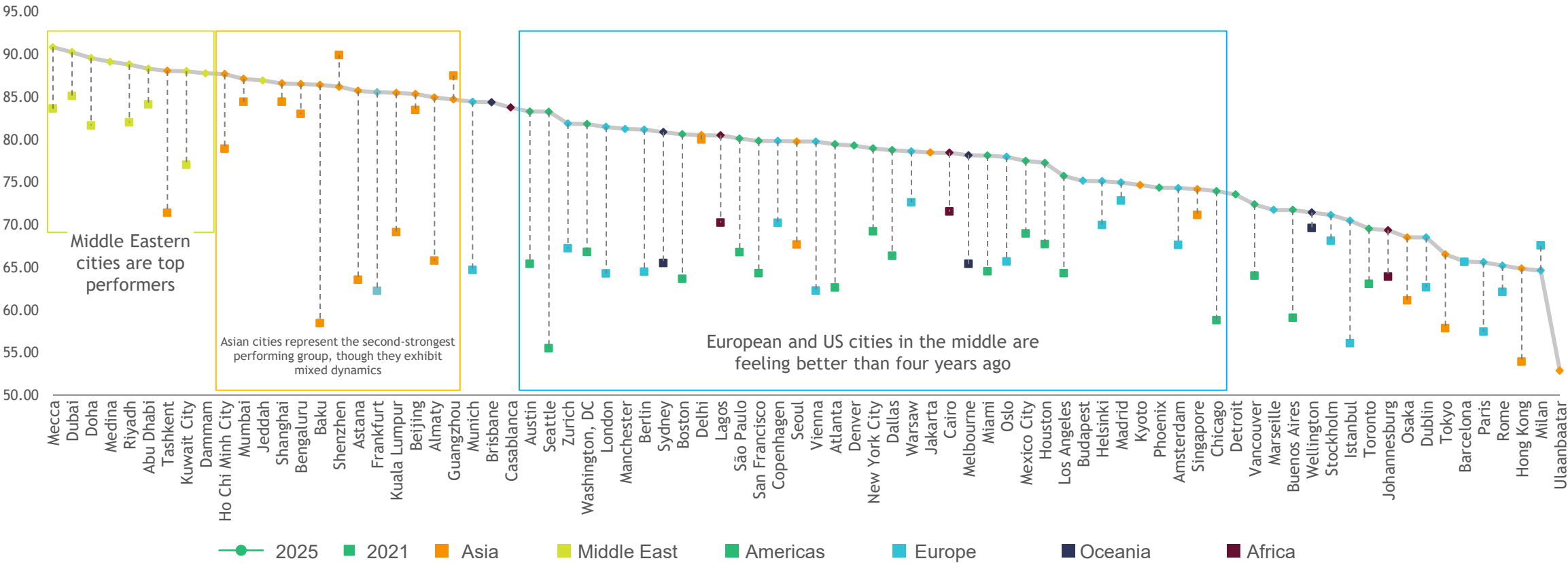


3. Speed of change is the new source of sustainable advantage

- Residents compare cities in real time; **expectations evolve quickly**
- Faster learning and adaptation drives **stronger resident advocacy**
- **High-advocacy cities** win by consistently improving outcomes—and proving they can do so again

Advocacy¹ rises fast in most cities

Leaders remained leaders with increased score. The leading reasons are high speed of change, cultural traditions. Significant increase in advocacy in European cities (potentially post-COVID effect) and, in particular, in Baku, Seattle, Frankfurt, Astana, Munich, Almaty, Austin, and Vienna. Slight drop in Guangzhou, Shenzhen, and Milan

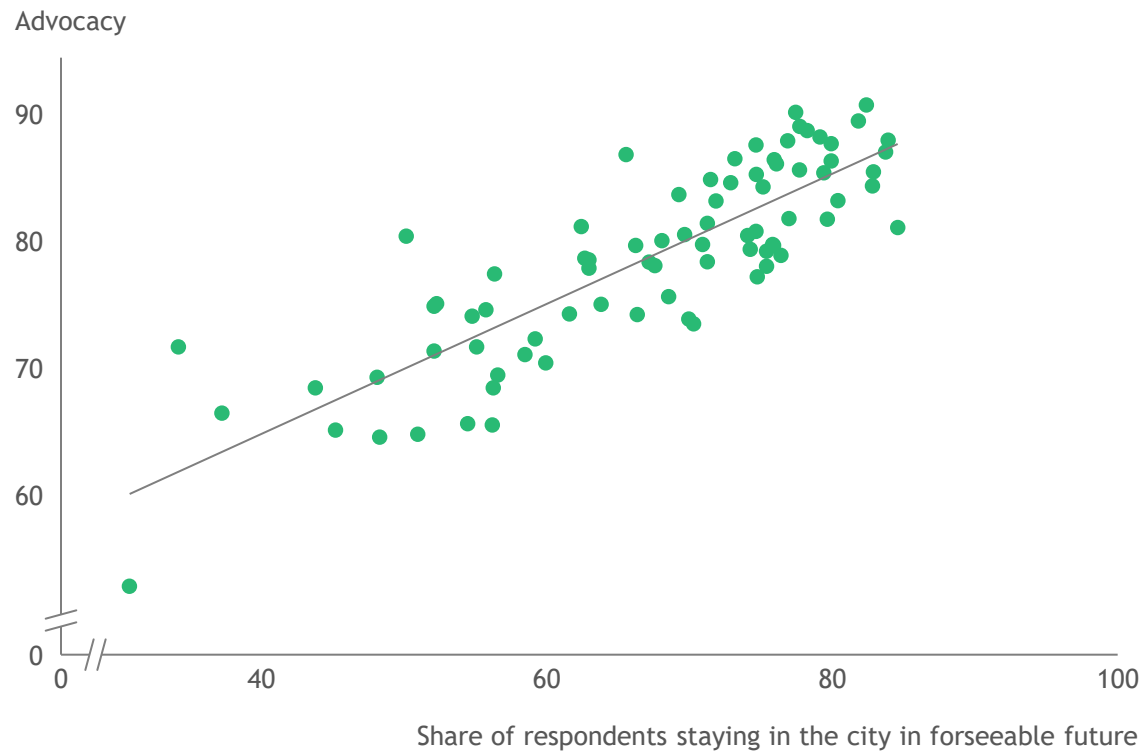


1. Resident advocacy measured with five questions: 1) Are you satisfied to live in [City]? 2) How likely are you to recommend [City] to a friend from another city as a place to live and work? 3) Have you recommended or criticized [City] as a place to live and work in the last 12 months? 4) Do you see your children living in [City] 20 years from now? 5) Do you believe [City] will prosper in the future?

A high advocacy score indicates residents’ commitment to a city

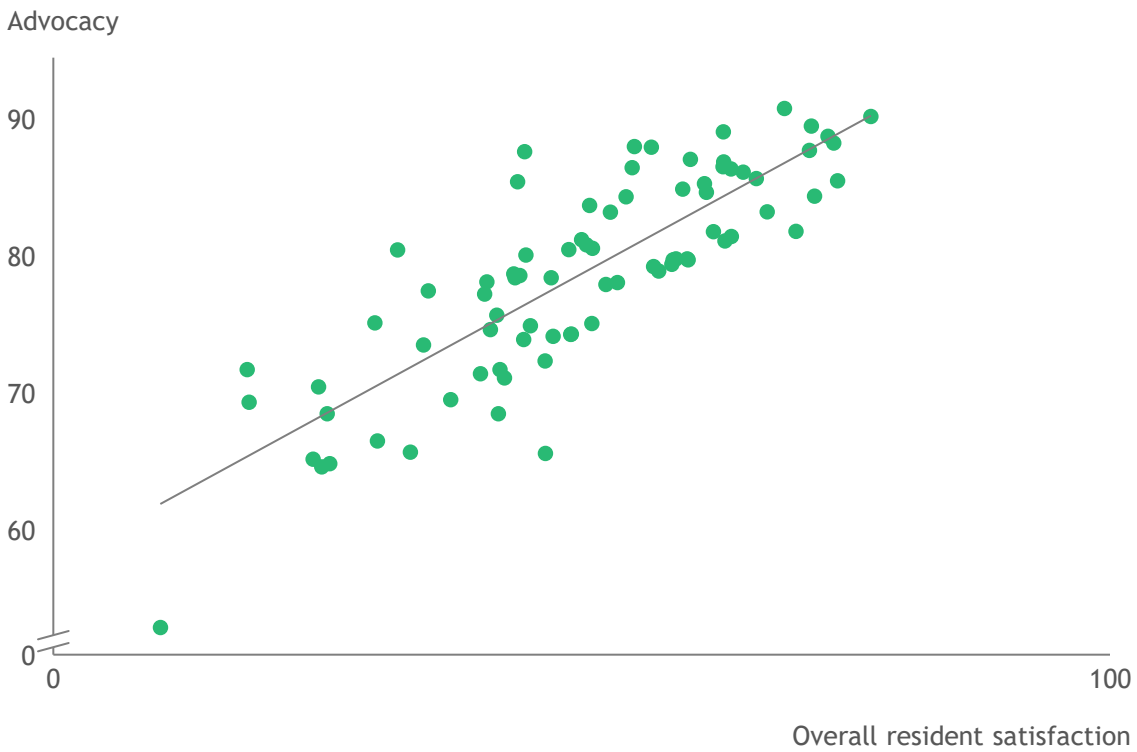
Cities with higher advocacy also see a greater share of residents planning to stay in the foreseeable future

Advocacy is not just an attitude—it reflects genuine commitment and confidence in a city’s long-term prospects, which is a strong foundation for economic and social prosperity.



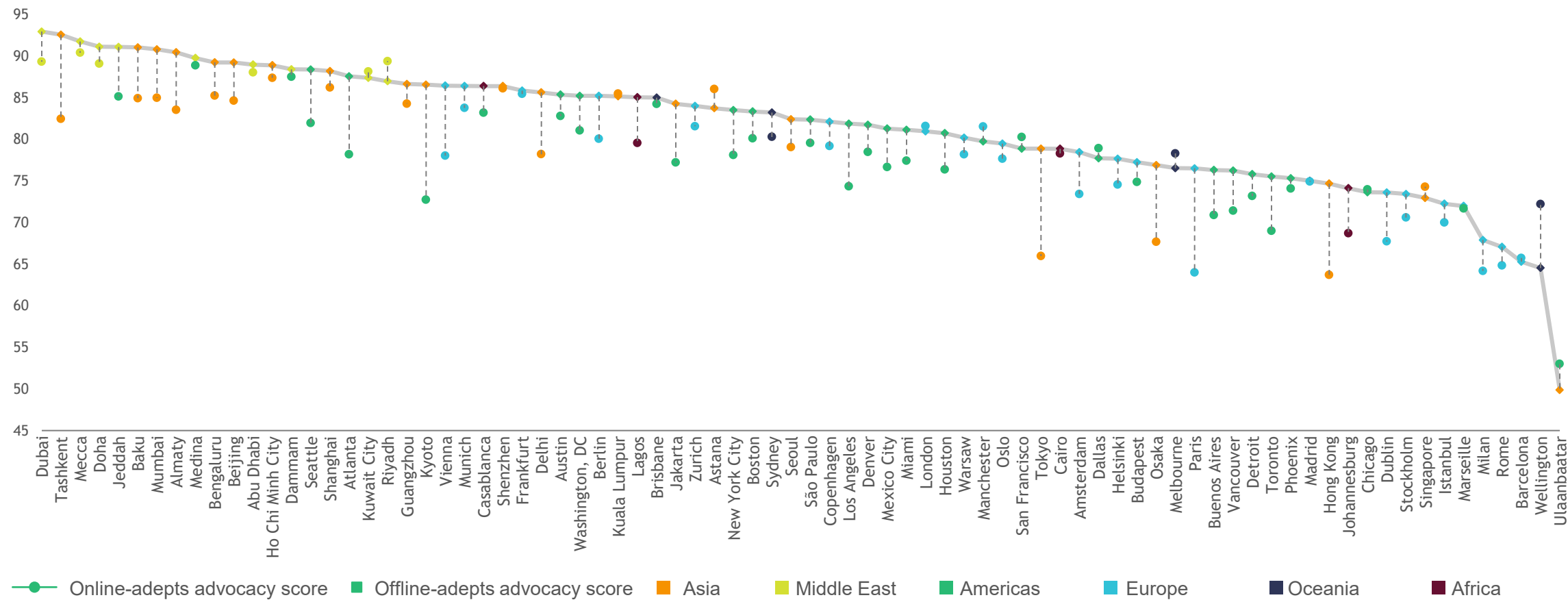
Higher advocacy aligns closely with higher overall resident satisfaction

Cities that score well on advocacy are those delivering consistently positive everyday experiences; advocacy captures both emotional attachment and quality-of-life outcomes.



1. Share of respondents staying in the city in foreseeable future: measured through share of respondents who selected “No, I plan to stay in [City] in the foreseeable future” to question, “Would you seriously consider relocation to another city / country?” 2. Overall resident satisfaction measured by average score of all opinion-based survey questions.

Online adepts¹ outperform other residents in advocacy across more than 70 cities



1. Residents who perform at least four of the following activities entirely online, with no more than two activities entirely offline. Activities include groceries, shopping, health care, fitness, entertainment (films, series, theatre, sports), banking and personal finance (paying bills, sending money, applying for loans, etc.), city government services (utilities, applying for permits and IDs, reporting city issues, voting, etc.).

11

An aerial photograph of a city at dusk. The foreground features a large Ferris wheel and a fairground with various rides. The middle ground is filled with dense residential and commercial buildings. The background shows a hazy city skyline under a twilight sky.

Section 2

Top 20 cities by dimension

Executive summary (I/III)

Ranking results by dimension



Overall

- The West leads in economic and livability fundamentals; **ME, China, and Central Asia drive the fastest change**
- **Advocacy and citizen engagement rise across most cities**, led by the ME and Asia; Europe and the US show moderate recovery from post-COVID sentiment lows



Speed of change

- **Middle Eastern, Chinese, and Central Asian cities**, led by Tashkent, show the **fastest transformation** over the past decade, especially in livability and economic opportunities
- **Europe's pace remains slower**, though Zurich and German cities advance through improvements in social capital and engagement with governments
- **Top 10 in speed of change in engagement with governments** are UAE and KSA cities



Economic opportunities

- **Top 15 led by European and US cities and Dubai**; Doha drops on weaker ecosystems and business momentum, while Europe gains; **Central Asia improves on reforms sentiment**
- **Clear income-equality tradeoff**: US cities earn more but are more unequal; EU cities are more equal but have lower income
- **Not all cities with strong business ecosystems translate them into higher incomes**; even efficient performers can lose their income edge if business conditions stagnate
- **Business environment** is driven by emergence of new coworking spaces (4.5x on average since 2021) and business incubators
- Europe (except Istanbul) gained on new indicators: **venture capital investment, airport connectivity, and economic land use score** confirming strong fundamentals but also early-stage entrepreneur activity increased
- Sentiment on **work and business opportunity availability** improved across cities, notably in Central Asia

Executive summary (II/III)

Ranking results by dimension



Livability

Overall

- Europe retains leadership (London, Zurich, Oslo); Shanghai and Central Asian cities rapidly close the gap
- Developing cities get strongest gains in livability, and if trend continues, talent flow will be redirected strongly to developing cities in search for better living conditions
- Housing affordability and mobility pressures intensify globally; education and health care gains support Europe's lead and Asia's catch-up

Housing: largest challenge across continents

- Higher per square meter prices (+25% in Europe and North America)
- Increased mortgage rates (doubled in Europe and North America, +40% globally)
- Housing drives happiness and already now 62 cities out of 80 develop city-level housing affordability programs

Mobility: situation worsens despite talks about “new mobility”

- Despite public transport initiatives, time to commute has increased by 6% across all cities and growing number of cars (by 7.5% from 2023) is the main contribution
- However, 15-minute city and public transport promotion initiatives start paying off and their adepts are improving (Vienna, Paris)

Outdoor: conditions deteriorate despite physical improvements and high importance for residents

- Air quality deteriorating: over 90% of cities show NO₂ levels higher than WHO guidelines; in 80% cities in ME and Asia, the highest PM2.5 and PM10
- Europe and Canada lead globally in public and green spaces, with Europe holding 10 of the top 15 spots; ME lags in green zones; Riyadh, Tashkent, and Warsaw showed strong gains in access to public spaces
- Despite continuous effort in public and green spaces, time outside decreased by 9.2%, while weight of public spaces in residents' needs is high in all cities

Initial traction on health span and longevity capital

- Cities across all groups promote healthy lifestyles (55 cities) and prevention programs; high participation in wellness programs (56%) and telehealth access (80+%); in 80 cities, residents had checkups this year
- Most cities introduced healthy lifestyle programs for older adults (92% participation in wellness programs among elderlies) to be socially and health-wise active and build longevity capital

Consumption

- US and European cities lead in offline retail density, while ME and Asia are very much behind. At the same time, they are leaders in ordering goods online, while US and European cities are outsiders. Accessibility of grocery stores: the first 30 are in Asia, ME, and LA

Executive summary (III/III)

Ranking results by dimension



Social capital

- European cities rebound post-COVID, while Asian and Middle Eastern cities continue to lead on social connectedness and resilience
- Inclusivity improves globally, with major gains in developing cities (Almaty, Cairo, Riyadh) and stronger accessibility across transport and employment
- In social capital, cities are “departing” from countries and forming their own “social capital”



Engagement with governments

- Western cities still lead, but the Middle East is catching up quickly; Dubai enters top 10, while some Western cities (Rome, Milan, Budapest) decline
- Technology penetration drives improvement: +20% feel able to influence decisions; 3x better at solving problems online; 2x more participation apps
- Online adepts demonstrate stronger advocacy than general population; apparently work from home and online convenience create sufficient comfort for people to praise their cities
- Significant improvement in ability to influence events:
 - +20% increase in residents reporting that they feel able to influence decisions in their city
 - 3x improvement in ability to solve the most common city problems using online tools
 - 2x improvement in the availability of dedicated mobile apps that enable citizens to influence city development

Results by dimension for 80 cities—top 20 cities

 Speed of change		 Economic opportunities		 Livability		 Social capital		 Engagement with governments	
City	Total dimension score	City	Total dimension score	City	Total dimension score	City	Total dimension score	City	Total dimension score
Shenzhen	92	London	81	Zurich	74	Beijing	78	Frankfurt	80
Riyadh	91	Zurich	80	London	74	London	72	Zurich	79
Tashkent	88	Paris	80	Oslo	73	Berlin	70	Munich	77
Doha	87	Atlanta	79	Frankfurt	72	Shanghai	70	Austin	77
Guangzhou	85	Dubai	77	Vienna	72	Copenhagen	70	San Francisco	75
Shanghai	83	Amsterdam	76	Washington, DC	71	Vienna	67	Riyadh	75
Mecca	81	Frankfurt	75	Copenhagen	70	Shenzhen	65	London	74
Beijing	81	San Francisco	75	Sydney	69	Doha	64	Atlanta	73
Jeddah	80	Munich	73	Berlin	69	Sydney	64	Dubai	72
Mumbai	80	Washington, DC	72	Munich	68	Amsterdam	63	Washington, DC	71
Dammam	79	Austin	71	Vancouver	64	Stockholm	62	Abu Dhabi	70
Medina	77	Seattle	71	Stockholm	64	Dubai	62	Singapore	70
Astana	77	Dublin	71	Seattle	64	Paris	61	Miami	69
Abu Dhabi	73	Oslo	70	Shanghai	63	Seoul	61	Denver	69
Bengaluru	72	New York City	70	Brisbane	62	Munich	60	New York City	67
Almaty	71	Boston	69	Austin	62	New York City	60	Seoul	67
Jakarta	67	Seoul	68	Denver	61	Helsinki	59	Berlin	67
Delhi	64	Copenhagen	66	Dubai	61	Zurich	59	Mecca	66
Kuwait City	64	Denver	66	Melbourne	61	Madrid	59	Copenhagen	66
Baku	64	Madrid	66	San Francisco	61	Manchester	58	Dammam	66

Speed of change, 2014-2024—top 20 cities

Rank	City	Total dimension score	SoC in economic opportunities	SoC in livability	SoC in social capital	SoC in engagement with governments
1	Shenzhen	92	86	100	100	90
2	Riyadh	91	84	100	81	100
3	Tashkent	88	97	51	84	95
4	Doha	87	82	88	100	84
5	Guangzhou	85	78	80	100	86
6	Shanghai	83	78	73	99	84
7	Mecca	81	77	67	76	96
8	Beijing	81	63	99	100	84
9	Jeddah	80	73	82	74	92
10	Mumbai	80	66	100	87	82
11	Dammam	79	67	72	79	96
12	Medina	77	68	68	76	91
13	Astana	77	67	83	92	76
14	Abu Dhabi	73	65	83	61	87
15	Bengaluru	72	63	78	83	75
16	Almaty	71	57	99	86	65
17	Jakarta	67	60	76	69	70
18	Delhi	64	51	74	75	70
19	Kuwait City	64	37	90	76	77
20	Baku	64	49	83	68	70



Note: SoC = speed of change.

Key outcomes

- Top 10 is dominated by ME and Chinese cities, reflecting the fast pace of the comprehensive changes the cities have been pursuing
- Although the speed of change is slow in Europe in general, Zurich and German cities gained significantly due to improvements in social capital and engagement with governments

SoC in economic opportunities

- Middle East and US cities are leading with Tashkent on top
- Top 10 cities witnessed real annual income growth of average 3%, negative growth in unemployment rates of on average 5%
- The biggest declines in score happened to Canadian cities, where real wages decreased and inequality slightly increased

SoC in livability

- Asia and ME are leading as before, Lagos gained significantly due to new metro opening and relatively better performance in housing
- In North America, cities' scores declined because of significant jump in mortgage rates and impact on household income growth

SoC in social capital

- Biggest gains are with German cities along with Central Asian and ME due to improvements in reported safety and tolerance in the society
- At the same time, Europe and United States report in increased growth of crime and murder

SoC in engagement with governments

- Top 10 is dominated by KSA and UAE cities due to their improved sentiment toward the government services and trust in authorities
- The sentiment is confirmed by the growth in the E-Government Development Index (EGDI)

Economic opportunities—top 20 cities

City	Total dimension score	Opportunities for work and income	Business opportunities	Equality of income	Availability of personal loans
London	81	81	97	68	60
Zurich	80	89	72	70	77
Paris	80	95	76	70	61
Atlanta	79	89	95	30	56
Dubai	77	82	86	45	77
Amsterdam	76	74	82	83	69
Frankfurt	75	63	75	81	100
San Francisco	75	81	100	29	50
Munich	73	63	67	88	94
Washington	72	88	79	45	39
Austin	71	88	67	33	58
Seattle	71	86	74	38	53
Dublin	71	80	65	51	75
Oslo	70	81	49	61	78
New York City	70	79	93	20	41
Boston	69	82	86	31	40
Seoul	68	69	58	75	77
Copenhagen	66	70	53	51	86
Denver	66	74	78	36	49
Madrid	66	64	59	73	73

Note: Ranks are compiled using 2024 data, thus, might not reflect the latest trends and media focus.

1. Surveys: I see opportunities for self-realization and opportunities for work. 2. Survey: I see many opportunities to open my business. 3. Total early-stage Entrepreneurial Activity Rate.

Key outcomes

- Overall: Top 15 led by European and US cities and Dubai; income inequality clear gap for most cities leading economic opportunity

Opportunities for work, career, and income

- US still leads, with three European leaders (Paris, Zurich, and Oslo); Dubai joins top 10
- Sentiment¹ improves compared to COVID levels, but overall scores still decline in Asia, parts of Europe and North America

Business opportunities for residents

- Clear lead of North America and Europe, vs. more diversified mix previously
- Europe (except Istanbul) gained on new indicators: VC investment, airport connectivity, and economic land-use score, confirming strong fundamentals but also overall sentiment and TEA increased
- Sentiment on work and business opportunity availability improved across cities, notably in Central Asia

Equality of income

- Europe leads; German cities show strong gains
- US cities improved but still rank more unequal; bottom 15 remains dominated by US and Chinese cities

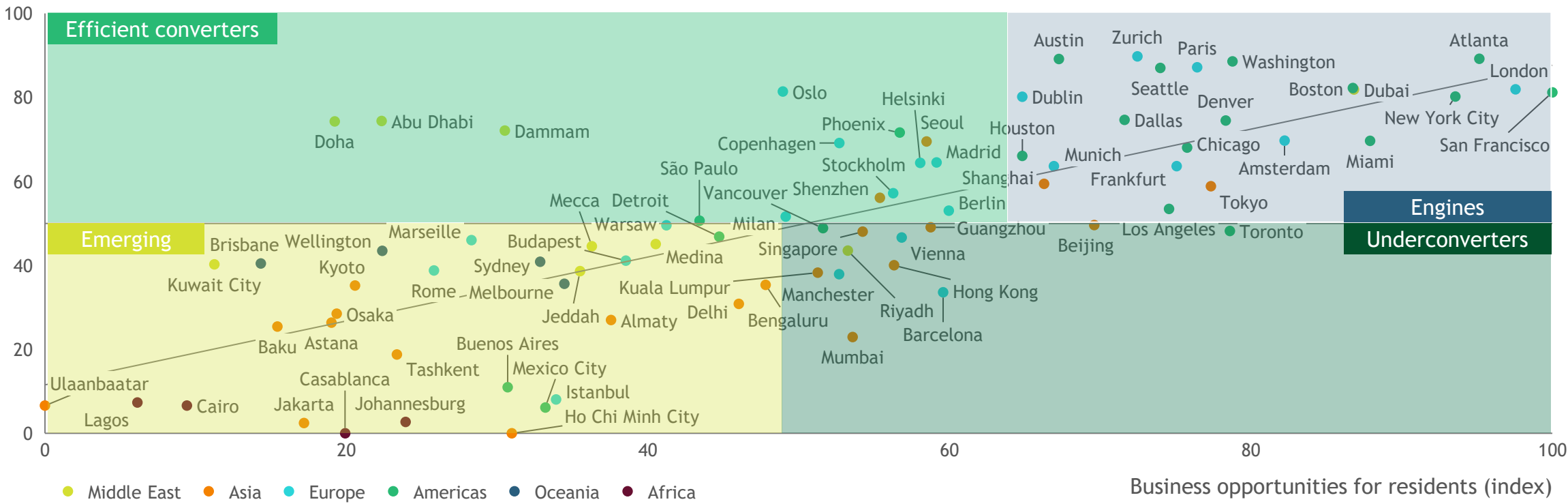
Availability of personal loans

- Top 10 remains dominated by German and Chinese cities
- Sentiment¹ improved despite rising borrowing costs, especially in Central Asia



Economic opportunities | Efficient converters adjust their business opportunities and turn them into incomes

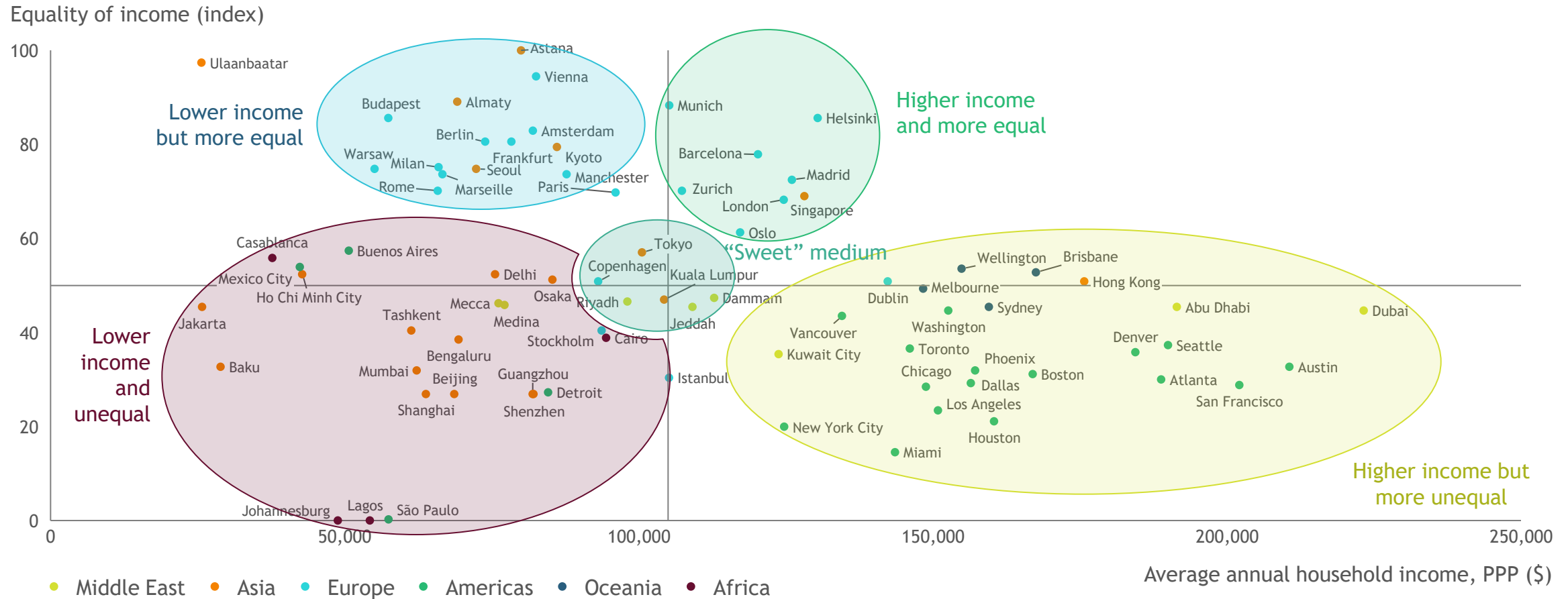
Opportunities for work, career, and income (index)



Note: Opportunities for work and income index measures unemployment; real HH income; food share; GDP (PPP)/worker; surveys (opportunities, self-realization); WFH split/infrastructure; internet speed; business opportunities index measures business opportunities survey; TEA rate; services in GDP%; number of startups; coworking situations, new patents, VC investment; AI-vulnerability survey; land use; retail vacancy, airport connectivity.



Economic opportunities | US cities earn more but have higher inequality, while European cities are more equal but earn less—an income-equality paradox



Note: PPP = purchasing power parity.



Livability—top 20 cities

City	Total dimension score	Housing	Mobility	Health care	Education	Consumption of goods and services	Public spaces	Entertainment and recreation	Ecology	Comfortable climate	Cleanliness and hygiene	Resilience to emergency situations
Zurich	74	66	80	87	58	52	100	82	64	51	96	62
London	74	65	71	69	100	97	79	100	61	49	61	58
Oslo	73	67	100	94	72	56	88	60	92	34	45	77
Frankfurt	72	81	92	100	70	73	74	68	57	39	73	78
Vienna	72	59	98	66	64	65	85	75	82	41	67	72
Washington	71	86	61	51	70	99	61	100	59	44	64	91
Copenhagen	70	60	87	78	79	80	61	76	89	41	67	55
Sydney	69	63	57	57	51	65	68	55	79	97	71	75
Berlin	69	51	95	97	83	60	69	73	66	53	59	70
Munich	68	71	97	100	87	65	46	58	63	44	77	84
Vancouver	64	44	62	26	59	78	74	46	100	49	55	74
Stockholm	64	42	78	30	50	60	100	48	83	36	53	74
Seattle	64	81	71	60	68	80	33	65	91	50	60	62
Shanghai	63	47	67	82	71	74	74	51	30	42	72	78
Brisbane	62	71	55	62	55	39	64	49	70	70	77	78
Austin	62	94	49	38	66	54	67	55	77	52	65	49
Denver	61	87	50	58	66	56	54	61	63	52	62	77
Dubai	61	89	47	85	21	78	60	50	32	33	86	86
Melbourne	61	56	38	56	62	49	73	58	83	70	42	81
San Francisco	61	72	53	55	64	65	25	89	89	89	63	53

Key outcomes

- As in legacy editions, Europe leads livability, with London and Zurich at the top; Washington has maintained its position, but NYC and San Francisco have lost their historical leadership; Chinese cities catching up very fast, with leader Shanghai in 14th place
- Housing:** Total relative decline of all cities, prices per square meter and mortgage rocket, US cities continue to lead due to historically large space per person
- Mobility:** Post-COVID mobility intensified; overall time to commute has increased also showing growing number of cars
- Health care:** German cities lead, while US cities are mostly at the end of the list
- Education:** Dimension was significantly expanded by including after-school activities and higher education, benefiting European cities and the cities with tradition of after-school programs
- Consumption:** US and European cities lead in offline big format retail density, while ME and Asia lead online delivery and next-door format
- Public spaces:** Europe and Canada lead globally, with Europe holding 10 of the top 15 spots; ME lags in green zones but Riyadh showed strong gains
- Entertainment:** Stable with traditional leaders: US and Europe
- Ecology:** NAMR, Europe, and AUS are on top as before; in ME, sustainability commitment improved; half of cities report less than one-third of HH waste recycled; air quality deteriorating compared with COVID time
- Cleanliness:** Zurich on top as before; Asian cities improved due to public toilet revolution
- Resilience:** Washington DC on top with Dubai following; all NA cities improved due to the gains in intensive care beds and emergency personnel



Social capital—top 20 cities

City	Total dimension score	Social connections	Identity with culture	Inclusivity	Safety
Beijing	78	77	100	55	85
London	72	64	100	70	45
Berlin	70	59	100	75	31
Shanghai	70	85	69	48	97
Copenhagen	70	67	63	83	59
Vienna	67	51	74	82	45
Shenzhen	65	79	48	51	100
Doha	64	71	52	55	92
Sydney	64	60	57	80	49
Amsterdam	63	47	59	91	33
Stockholm	62	12	53	92	50
Dubai	62	95	59	26	100
Paris	61	17	100	56	35
Seoul	61	31	85	53	68
Munich	60	61	39	78	58
New York City	60	49	100	44	42
Helsinki	59	41	41	83	59
Zurich	59	61	43	75	57
Madrid	59	39	71	62	46
Manchester	58	61	32	79	57

Key outcomes

- **Overall ranking:** In 2023, the top 10 were dominated by Asian and ME cities (the highest Western city, New York, ranked 13th); this year, 5 of the top 10 are European, driven largely by stronger survey results, as residents' subjective views improved significantly post-COVID
- **Social connections:** Asian and ME cities remain as leaders
- **Identity with culture:** Residents today feel more proud of their cities' history and culture, with notable increases in Zurich, German cities, and Jeddah; however, many European cities saw declines, including Barcelona, Stockholm, and Amsterdam
- **Inclusivity:** Cities are becoming more inclusive in both infrastructure (public transport use rose from 76% to 81%) and practices (employment of people with disabilities grew from 36% to 38%)
- **Safety:** As historically, the safest cities are in the Middle East and Asia, while the least safe are in North and South America



Engagement with governments—top 20 cities

City	Total dimension score	Ability to influence events	Government services	Business environment
Frankfurt	80	90	75	77
Zurich	79	73	81	84
Munich	77	71	75	83
Austin	77	83	59	86
San Francisco	75	75	52	94
Riyadh	75	65	100	65
London	74	83	72	68
Atlanta	73	82	47	88
Dubai	72	47	100	69
Washington	71	88	53	74
Abu Dhabi	70	62	85	63
Singapore	70	68	69	72
Miami	69	73	38	87
Denver	69	76	48	80
New York City	67	77	70	58
Seoul	67	87	84	40
Berlin	67	56	82	61
Mecca	66	49	89	62
Copenhagen	66	56	76	65
Dammam	66	57	86	57

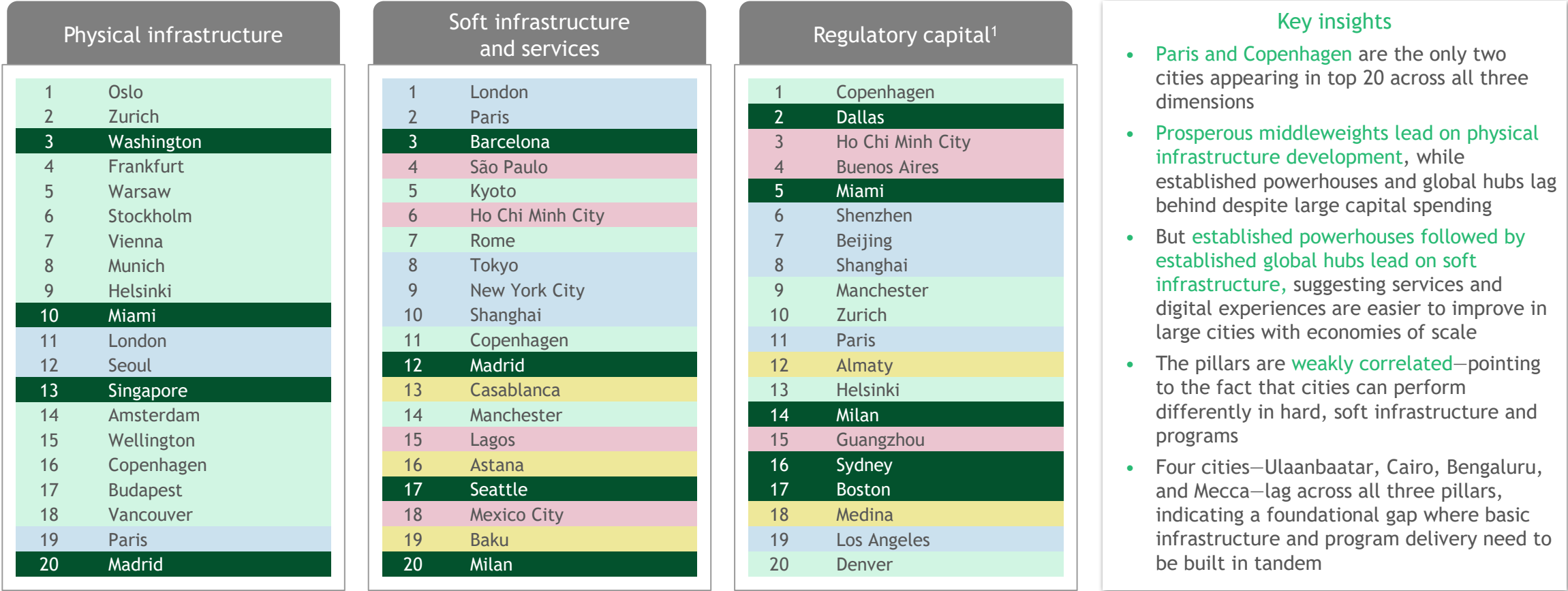
Key outcomes

Technology penetration drives significant improvement in **ability to influence events and government services**:

- +20% increase in residents reporting that they feel able to influence decisions in their city
- 3x improvement in ability to solve the most common city problems using online tools
- 2x improvement in the availability of dedicated mobile apps that enable citizens to influence city development
- Many developing cities have improved their rankings: Riyadh (EGDI improved from 0.49 to 0.92) and Dubai entered the top 10; São Paulo and Almaty are in the top 25
- Western cities still lead, **but ME is catching up quickly** with Dubai in top 10, and some cities from the West are becoming laggards, e.g., Rome, Milan, Budapest
- **Business environment** is driven by emergence of new coworking spaces (4.5x on average since 2021) and business incubators

Prosperous middleweights lead on infrastructure, while established powerhouses lag despite large investments but lead on soft infrastructure

Comparison by group



Established powerhouses Developing megacities Established global hubs Prosperous middleweights Developing middleweights

1. Regulatory capital includes programs and policies.
 Note: Calculation methodology used three new subindices calculated by regrouping the physical infrastructure, soft infrastructure, and regulatory capital-related indicators across all dimensions.

Section 3

Ranking by groups



In addition to ranking by dimension, cities are grouped by socioeconomic profiles to ensure comparability

1 Established powerhouses	2 Developing megacities	3 Established global hubs	4 Prosperous middleweights	5 Developing middleweights
1 Cities with more than \$25,000 GDP per capita 2 Urban area population >10M people	1 Cities with less than \$25,000 GDP per capita 2 Urban area population >10M people	1 Cities with more than \$25,000 GDP per capita 2 Urban area population 4M-10M people	1 Cities with more than \$25,000 GDP per capita 2 Urban area population <4M people	1 Cities with less than \$25,000 GDP per capita 2 Urban area population <4M people
Beijing London Los Angeles New York City Osaka Paris Seoul Shanghai Shenzhen Tokyo	Bengaluru Buenos Aires Cairo Delhi Guangzhou Ho Chi Minh City Istanbul Jakarta Johannesburg Lagos Mexico City Mumbai São Paulo	Atlanta Barcelona Berlin Boston Chicago Dallas Detroit Dubai Hong Kong Houston Jeddah Kuala Lumpur Madrid Melbourne Miami Milan Phoenix Riyadh San Francisco Seattle Singapore Sydney Toronto Washington	Abu Dhabi Amsterdam Austin Brisbane Budapest Copenhagen Denver Doha Dublin Frankfurt Helsinki Kuwait City Kyoto Manchester Marseille Munich Oslo Rome Stockholm Vancouver Vienna Warsaw Wellington Zurich	Almaty Astana Baku Casablanca¹ Dammam Mecca Medina Tashkent Ulaanbaatar

1. Casablanca has urban population of 4.5M. Note: There is no other city between 4M-10M with less than \$25,000 GDP per capita in our sample.
Source: Oxford Economics; World Bank; various official government websites.

Executive summary

Ranking results by group

 Overall	• Livability and economic opportunities remain the strongest global performance drivers • Speed of change differentiates high-performing cities—especially in China and ME—highlighting agility as a growing success factor
 Established powerhouses	• London leads globally with balanced excellence across dimensions, though lacking in speed of change • Chinese cities (Shanghai, Beijing, Shenzhen) outperform on social capital, speed of change, and advocacy, but lag in livability fundamentals • US and European peers show strong economic opportunities but face limits in social capital and speed of change
 Developing megacities	• The group is characterized by mostly below-average scores across dimensions but notably high advocacy, reflecting strong citizen engagement despite structural weaknesses • Guangzhou tops the group for excelling in all dimensions, companied with high advocacy • High speed of change score seen in India and Southeast Asia, though still constrained by fundamentals
 Established global hubs	• Group characterized by maturity and stability, with strong advocacy but modest speed of change • Berlin leads as the most balanced performer; Dubai, Washington, and San Francisco follow closely • US and ME cities excel in economic opportunities and engagement with governments
 Prosperous middleweights	• Zurich, Frankfurt, and Munich top the group, excelling in economic opportunities and engagement with governments • European cities dominate, though some laggards (e.g., Marseille, Rome) pull down group averages • Doha stands out with the highest speed of change, signaling emerging regional momentum
 Developing middleweights	• The group overall has strong advocacy and speed of change but with lacking capability—high citizen alignment and change intent without current supporting economic or social foundations • Dammam leads the group with balanced performance across all dimensions

Ranking by group: established powerhouses¹

Cities with more than \$25,000 GDP per capita and urban area population of over 10M

City	Overall rating	Advocacy score	Economic opportunities	Livability	Social capital	Engagement with governments	Speed of change
London							
Shanghai							
Beijing							
Shenzhen							
Seoul							
New York City							
Paris							
Los Angeles							
Tokyo							
Osaka							

1. Named “megacenters” in the 2023 ranking and consisted of 14 cities, including all the cities listed in this group.

Note on subdimensions: Economic opportunities: opportunities for work, career, and income, opportunities for business, equality of income, availability of personal loans. Livability: ability to influence events, government services, business environment, cleanliness and hygiene, comfortable climate, consumption of goods and services, ecology, education and development, entertainment and recreation, health care, housing, mobility, public spaces, resilience to emergency situations. Social capital: inclusivity and equality, identity with culture and history, safety, social connections. Speed of change: speed of change in economic opportunities, speed of change in engagement with governments, speed of change in livability, speed of change in social capital.

Key outcomes

- Across all groups, livability and economic opportunities are the strongest drivers of overall performance, followed by engagement with governments
- London ranks first, combining strong economic opportunities with high livability—the only city performing well across both; it has the highest scores in education, consumption, and entertainment
- Chinese cities win due to high speed of change, social capital, and very high advocacy, but still lag on fundamentals
- Paris is strong on culture and consumption, but weaker housing, mobility, and hygiene limit its livability
- Within the US, NYC leads over LA in economic opportunities, stemming from better performance in the innovation ecosystem, workforce efficiency, business development, and sentiment about economic and business opportunities
- Structural difference within the group comes from Japanese cities, which score low across all pillars, pulling down the group average

Ranking by group: developing megacities

Cities with less than \$25,000 GDP per capita and urban area population of over 10M

City	Overall rating	Advocacy score	Economic opportunities	Livability	Social capital	Engagement with governments	Speed of change
Guangzhou							
Mumbai							
Delhi							
Bengaluru							
São Paulo							
Ho Chi Minh							
Jakarta							
Cairo							
Mexico City							
Istanbul							
Buenos Aires							
Lagos							
Johannesburg							

Note on subdimensions: Economic opportunities: opportunities for work, career, and income, opportunities for business, equality of income, availability of personal loans. Livability: ability to influence events, government services, business environment, cleanliness and hygiene, comfortable climate, consumption of goods and services, ecology, education and development, entertainment and recreation, health care, housing, mobility, public spaces, resilience to emergency situations. Social capital: inclusivity and equality, identity with culture and history, safety, social connections. Speed of change: speed of change in economic opportunities, speed of change in engagement with governments, speed of change in livability, speed of change in social capital.

Key outcomes

- The group is characterized by mostly below-average scores across dimensions, but notably high advocacy, reflecting strong citizen engagement despite structural weaknesses, especially noticeable in Ho Chi Minh City and Lagos
- Guangzhou leads the group as the most balanced city, combining the above-average fundamentals with high speed of change and high advocacy
- The group's overall low performance in livability stems from weak infrastructure fundamentals, except Guangzhou, which leads in cleanliness and public spaces
- Istanbul scores low due to weak livability performance across 5 out of 11 subdimensions and also weak in opportunities for work, career, and income coming from high unemployment rates and low sentiment

Ranking by group: established global hubs

Cities with more than \$25,000 GDP per capita and urban area population of 4M to 10M

City	Overall rating	Advocacy score	Economic opportunities	Livability	Social capital	Engagement with governments	Speed of change
Berlin							
Dubai							
Washington							
San Francisco							
Atlanta							
Riyadh							
Seattle							
Boston							
Sydney							
Miami							
Madrid							
Singapore							
Chicago							
Jeddah							
Phoenix							
Melbourne							
Barcelona							
Dallas							
Toronto							
Houston							
Kuala Lumpur							
Milan							
Detroit							
Hong Kong							

Note on subdimensions: Economic opportunities: opportunities for work, career, and income, opportunities for business, equality of income, availability of personal loans. Livability: ability to influence events, government services, business environment, cleanliness and hygiene, comfortable climate, consumption of goods and services, ecology, education and development, entertainment and recreation, health care, housing, mobility, public spaces, resilience to emergency situations. Social capital: inclusivity and equality, identity with culture and history, safety, social connections. Speed of change: speed of change in economic opportunities, speed of change in engagement with governments, speed of change in livability, speed of change in social capital.

Key outcomes

- Overall, the group is mature with mostly above-average scores but, at the same time, with limited improvement over time
- Advocacy is strong across all cities, but results differ mainly in economic opportunities and livability; social capital is the main weak area
- Berlin is #1 as the city with the most balanced performance across the dimensions, with Dubai, Washington, and San Francisco closely following
- Saudi cities move fastest, showing high speed of change and advocacy, but still lag on fundamentals
- US cities lead in economic opportunities along with Dubai but are weak in social capital; Washington is in top 3 as an anchor for a broader metro area

Ranking by group: prosperous middleweights

Cities with more than \$25,000 GDP per capita and urban area population of less than 4M

City	Overall rating	Advocacy score	Economic opportunities	Livability	Social capital	Engagement with governments	Speed of change
Zurich							
Frankfurt							
Munich							
Copenhagen							
Vienna							
Austin							
Oslo							
Amsterdam							
Denver							
Doha							
Abu Dhabi							
Helsinki							
Manchester							
Brisbane							
Stockholm							
Dublin							
Vancouver							
Warsaw							
Wellington							
Kuwait City							
Marseille							
Kyoto							
Budapest							
Rome							

Note on subdimensions: Economic opportunities: opportunities for work, career, and income, opportunities for business, equality of income, availability of personal loans. Livability: ability to influence events, government services, business environment, cleanliness and hygiene, comfortable climate, consumption of goods and services, ecology, education and development, entertainment and recreation, health care, housing, mobility, public spaces, resilience to emergency situations. Social capital: inclusivity and equality, identity with culture and history, safety, social connections. Speed of change: speed of change in economic opportunities, speed of change in engagement with governments, speed of change in livability, speed of change in social capital.

Key outcomes

- European cities lead, but ME is catching up quickly with Doha in the Top 10 and some cities from the West are becoming laggards, e.g., Marseille, Budapest, Rome
- Overall, this group of cities performs lower in social capital and speed of change, except for Doha, which is strong in both dimensions (64 in social capital and 87 in speed of change)
- Zurich, Frankfurt, and Munich perform well across all dimensions, leading in economic opportunities and engagement with governments
- Abu Dhabi almost enters the top 10, with high scores in speed of change and advocacy, signaling high potential

Ranking by group: developing middleweights

Cities with under \$25,000 GDP per capita and urban area population under 4M

City	Overall rating	Advocacy score	Economic opportunities	Livability	Social capital	Engagement with governments	Speed of change
Dammam							
Almaty							
Mecca							
Astana							
Medina							
Baku							
Tashkent							
Casablanca							
Ulaanbaatar							

Note on subdimensions. Economic opportunities: opportunities for work, career, and income, opportunities for business, equality of income, availability of personal loans. Livability: ability to influence events, government services, business environment, cleanliness and hygiene, comfortable climate, consumption of goods and services, ecology, education and development, entertainment and recreation, health care, housing, mobility, public spaces, resilience to emergency situations. Social capital: inclusivity and equality, identity with culture and history, safety, social connections. Speed of change: speed of change in economic opportunities, speed of change in engagement with governments, speed of change in livability, speed of change in social capital.

Key outcomes

- Overall, this group is about a high pace of change and low capacity, except Ulaanbaatar, where fundamentals and speed of change are low along with advocacy
- The group is advocacy-rich but with lacking capability—high citizen alignment and change intent without current supporting economic or social foundations
- Tashkent leads in speed of change (89)—a top 5 performer across the full 80-city ranking—reflecting rapid gains in economic opportunities and engagement with governments
- Almaty performs average or above average in most livability subdimensions, except ecology and resilience, where it clearly lags behind



Section 4

Key forward-looking themes

Deep dives on key forward-looking themes...

Work and lifestyle	① Companies continuing to adapt to distributed work, norms forming around hybrid work
	② People do more of their daily activities online and spend more time at home
	③ New wave of automation driven by the rise of AI impacting creative work in cities
Safety and well-being	④ People increasingly value wealth of personal time
	⑤ Cities need to adapt to aging urban population and longevity and health tailwinds
	⑥ Resilience and safety concerns are growing in the cities
	⑦ Housing markets becoming more unaffordable
Urban structure	⑧ Objective reality in cities and subjective perceptions of residents do not always match
	⑨ Congestion and long commute times are rising steadily in large cities
	⑩ “Connected city” (15-minute city index) delivers superior resident value
Economic mobility	⑪ Downtowns strained since the pandemic due to remote and hybrid working
	⑫ Cities will benefit more from the growing travel economy and benefit from business travelers extending work trips for leisure
	⑬ Affluent executives are semi-permanently on the move for enhanced economic opportunity and livability

...providing additional insights on cities' positioning

	Highest share of online adepts - Mumbai
	City with the highest resident advocacy - Mecca
	The most optimistic city about GenAI - Shenzhen
	Leaders in amount of time that residents spent at leisure locations - Dubai and Abu Dhabi
	Cities where people meet with their friends most frequently - Tashkent and Ho Chi Min City
	Best cities to prepare for longevity - Zurich and Beijing
	Best cities to move to for retirement to ensure longevity - San Francisco and Sydney
	Leaders in perceived safety - Riyadh and Mecca
	The most “connected” ¹ city - Amsterdam
	City with the largest number of destinations - Istanbul
	City with the highest inbound visitor spending - Dubai
	Cities that will gain the most from business visitors expanding their stay for leisure - Dubai and Tokyo

1. A city with high accessibility of amenities via walking or PT.

Theme 1

Hybrid and distributed work

Companies continuing to adapt to distributed work, norms forming around hybrid work

Hybrid work has become the new normal, with collaboration increasingly distributed and digital

Our global survey of 25,000+ residents across 83 cities shows that hybrid is no longer an experiment—it is part of everyday work, shaping where, with whom, and how people collaborate



Where people work

51%

of respondents work from home at least 1-2 days per week

25%

of respondents work from home at least 2-3 days per week

Top ranked cities: Atlanta, Miami, Kyoto, Osaka, Seoul, Berlin

Hybrid schedules are now the norm rather than the exception



Whom they work with

47%

of respondents' colleagues are based in other cities

Top ranked cities: Frankfurt, Oslo, Berlin, Tashkent, Phoenix

Collaboration networks are increasingly distributed and global



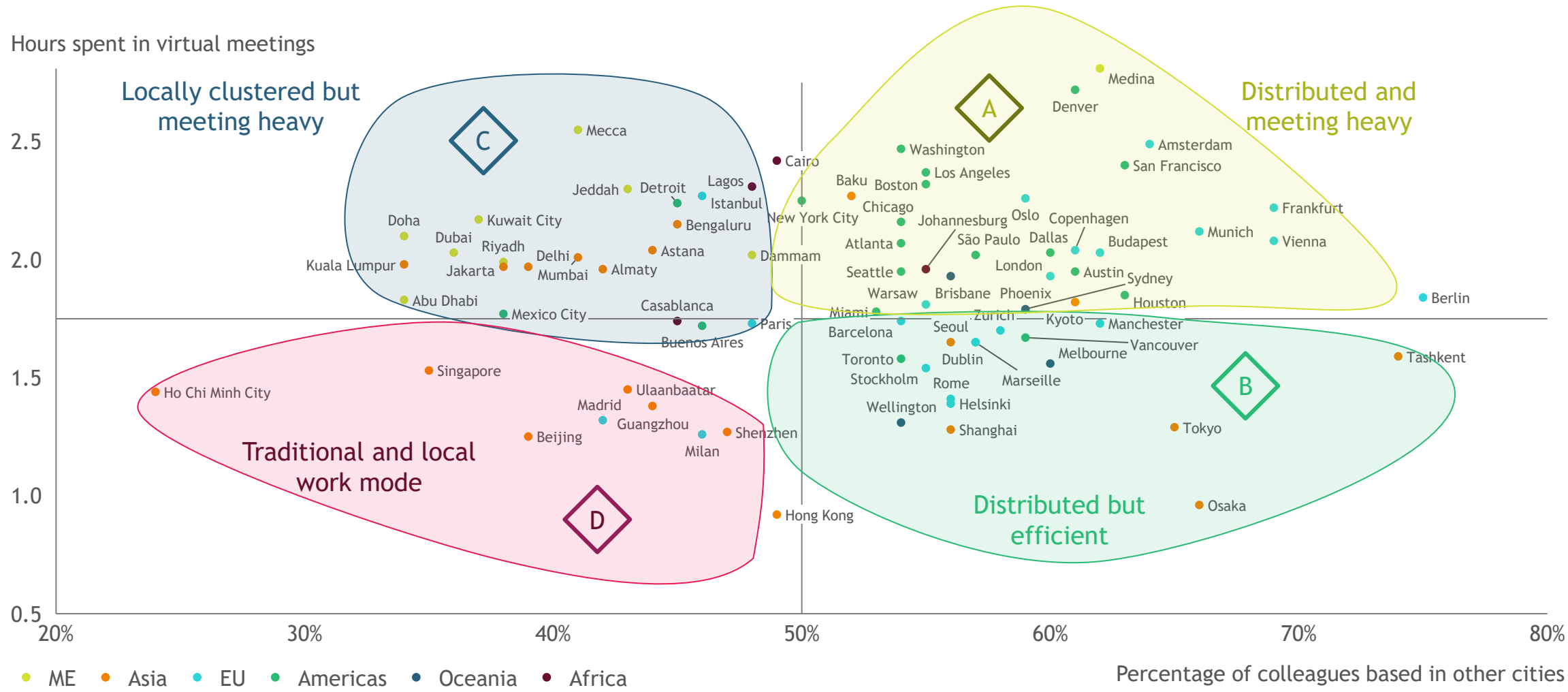
How they work

Employees spend, on average, 1.9 hours per day in virtual meetings when in the office

Top ranked cities: Medina, Baku, Cairo, Astana, Jeddah, Mecca

Digital tools and virtual collaboration are embedded in daily routines

The global survey reveals four archetypes of hybrid work



Note: The graph reflects responses from respondents with above-average income.

Cities reveal distinct collaboration patterns with different implications for hybrid work

				
	Distributed and meeting heavy	Distributed but efficient	Locally clustered but meeting heavy	Traditional and local work mode
Description	Teams are widely distributed across locations , and employees spend significant time in virtual meetings to stay connected	Distributed teams operate effectively with relatively little time spent in virtual meetings	Teams are primarily based in the same location , but employees still spend long hours in virtual meetings	Collaboration remains predominantly local , with limited use of virtual meetings
Implication	Cities should invest in top-tier digital infrastructure and foster international connectivity to remain competitive hubs for global work	These cities indicate mature hybrid practices ; other organizations can learn from these cities as benchmarks for efficient hybrid work	These cities are often large urban centers with heavy traffic , and improving commuting efficiency would significantly enhance their overall productivity	Cities need to prepare for a gradual shift toward hybrid work models by strengthening digital infrastructure and expanding coworking spaces
Examples	Frankfurt, Washington, Amsterdam	Sydney, Barcelona, Seattle	Cairo, São Paulo, Jeddah	Hong Kong, Osaka, Shanghai

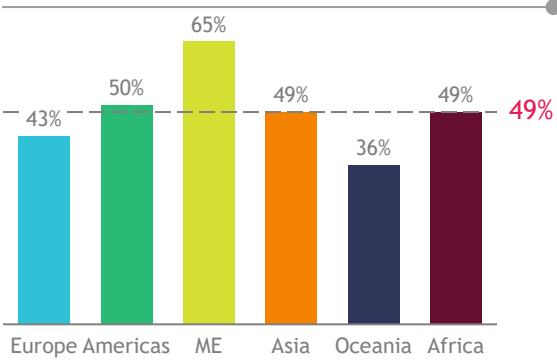
Theme 2

Life online

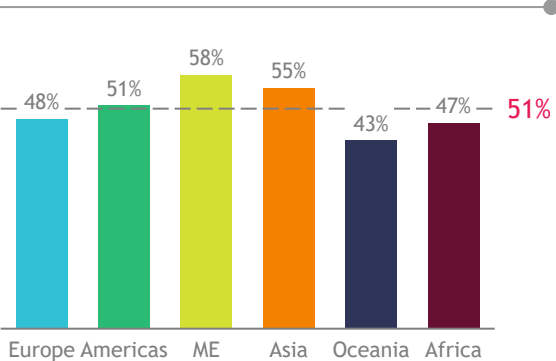
People do more of their daily activities online and spend more time at home

Penetration of online channels in daily activities varies across regions and types of activity

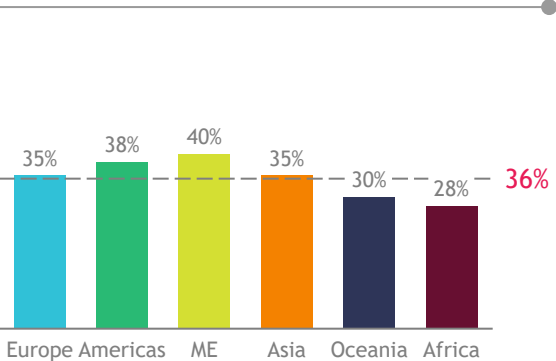
Residents who prefer to buy groceries through online channels¹ (%)



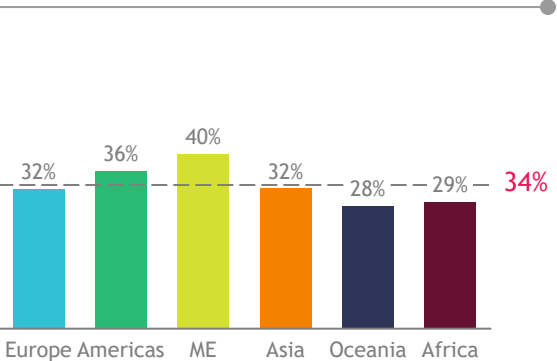
Residents who prefer to do shopping through online channels (%)



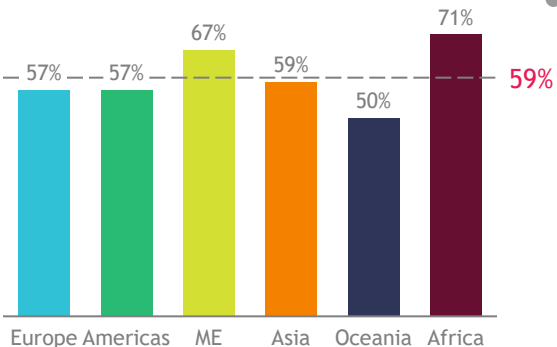
Residents who prefer to get medical services through online channels (%)



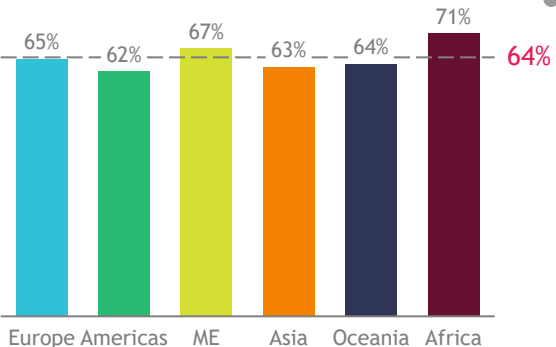
Residents preferring online fitness channels (%)



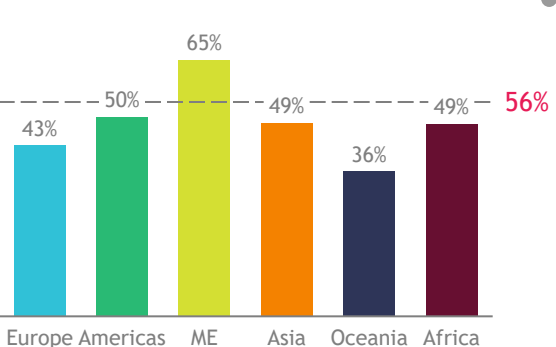
Residents preferring online entertainment channels (%)



Residents who prefer to receive banking services through online channels (%)



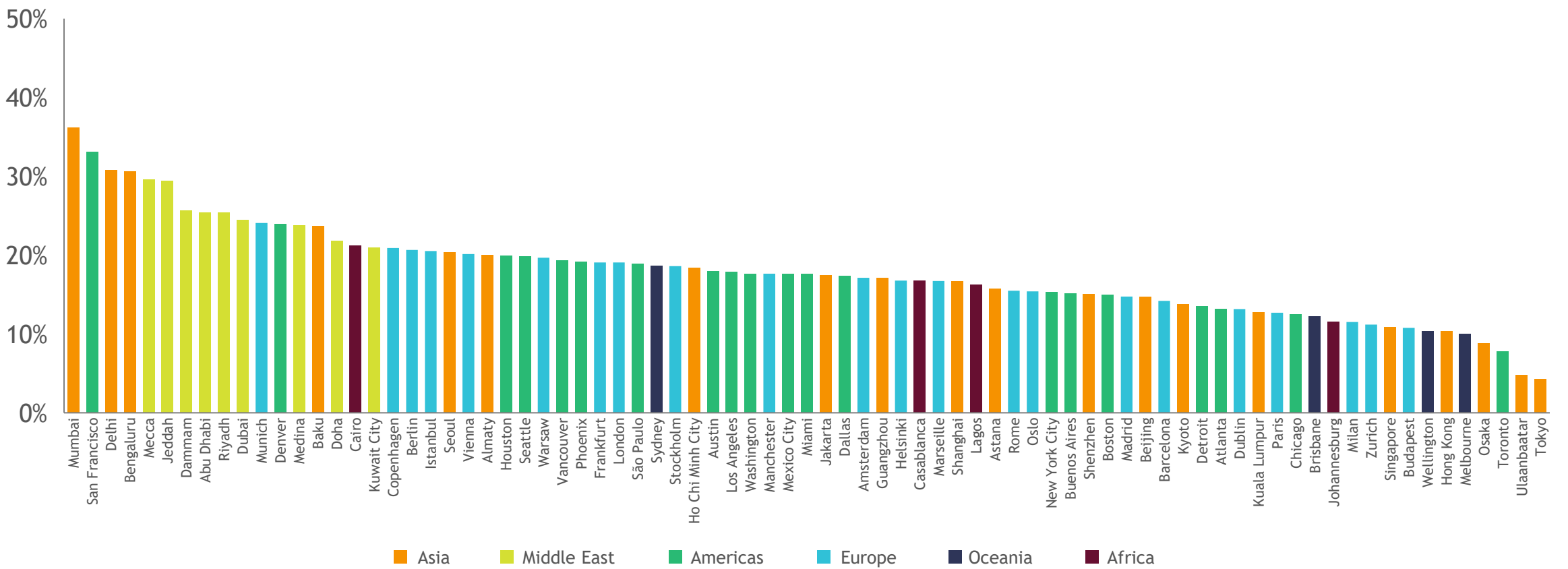
Residents who prefer to get government services through online channels (%)



1. Those who use online channels in 50% of cases are counted with a coefficient of 0.5.

Nineteen percent of online adepts¹ perform daily chores² mostly online, with Middle Eastern cities showing a higher share of such individuals than other cities

People who perform daily chores mostly online (%)

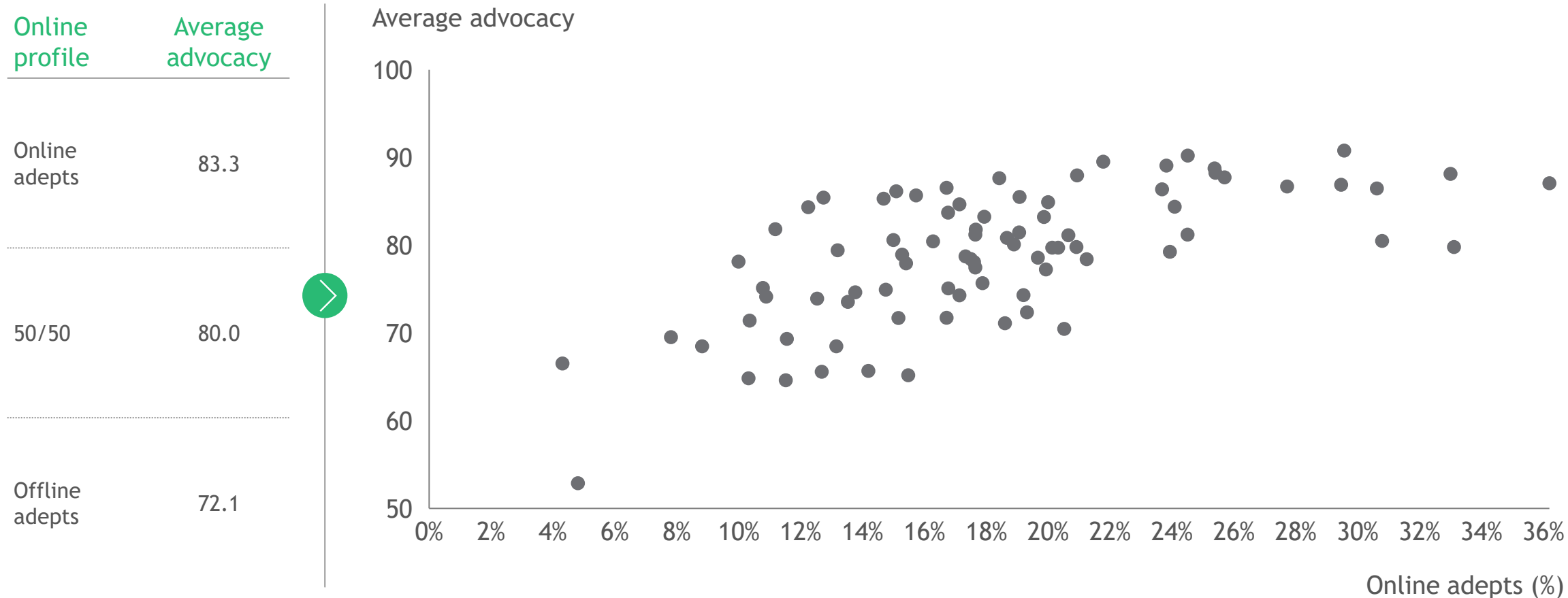


1. Perform at least four activities entirely online, with no more than two activities entirely offline.
2. Includes groceries, shopping, health care, fitness, entertainment (films, series, theatre, sports), banking and personal finance (paying bills, sending money, applying for loans, etc.), city government services (utilities, applying for permits and IDs, reporting city issues, voting, etc.).

Copyright © 2026 by Boston Consulting Group. All rights reserved.

42

Penetration of online services correlates with advocacy—cities with a higher share of online adepts demonstrate stronger advocacy



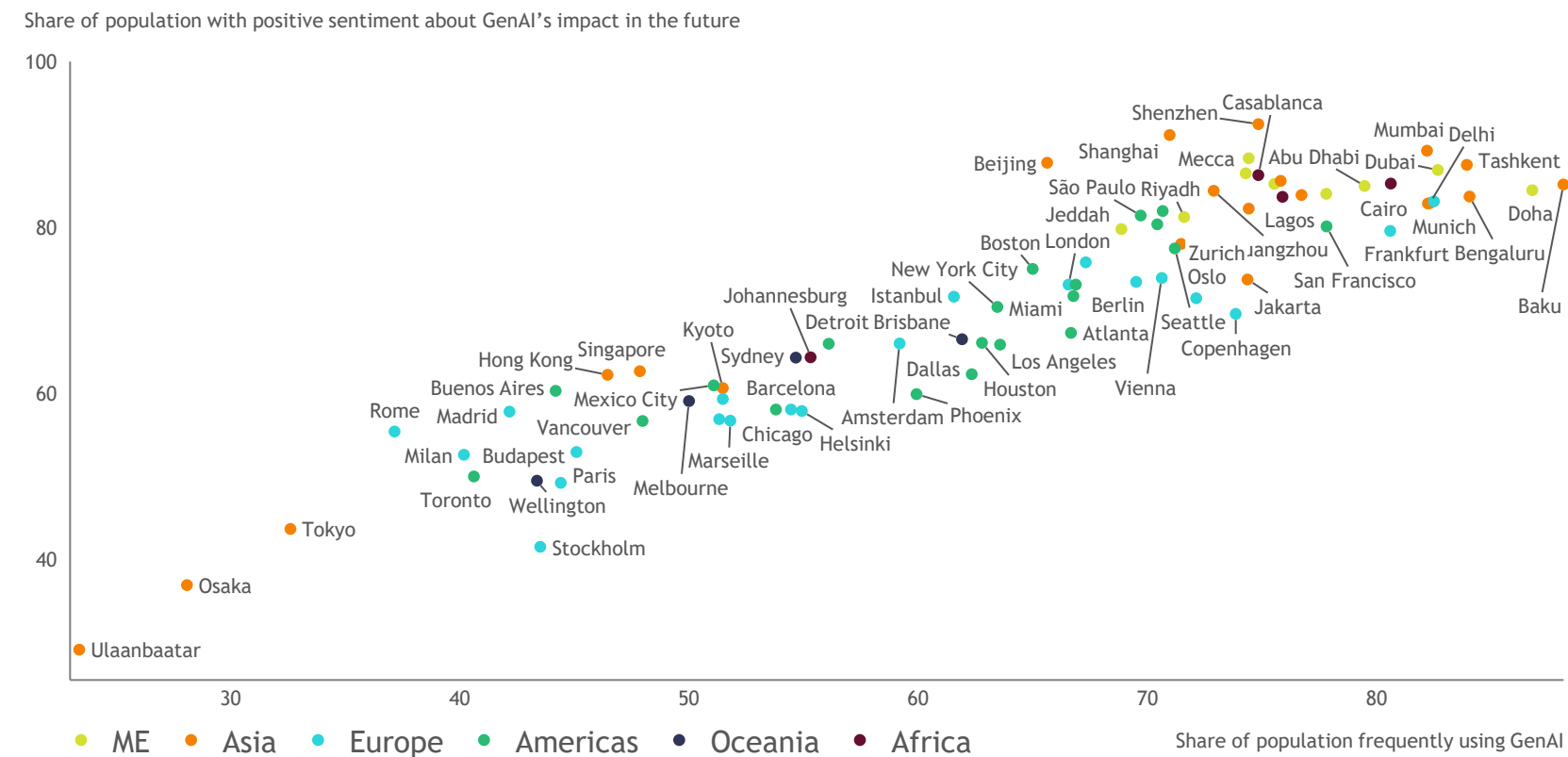
Theme 3

GenAI and the creative class

New wave of automation driven by the rise of AI and robotics impacting creative and knowledge work that tends to be concentrated in cities

Across cities, the higher frequency of GenAI usage is clearly linked with higher optimism about GenAI's impact on life

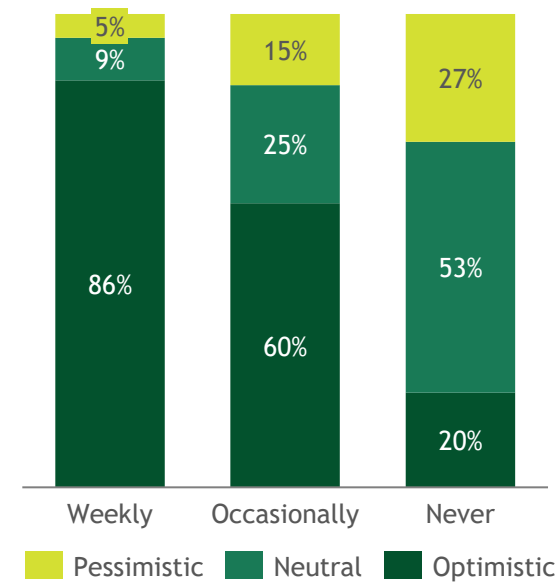
Middle East, much of Asia, and Africa cluster in the high-adoption and high-optimism quadrant, while most American and European cities sit midpack on usage, with comparatively moderate optimism



Sentiment improves with GenAI usage

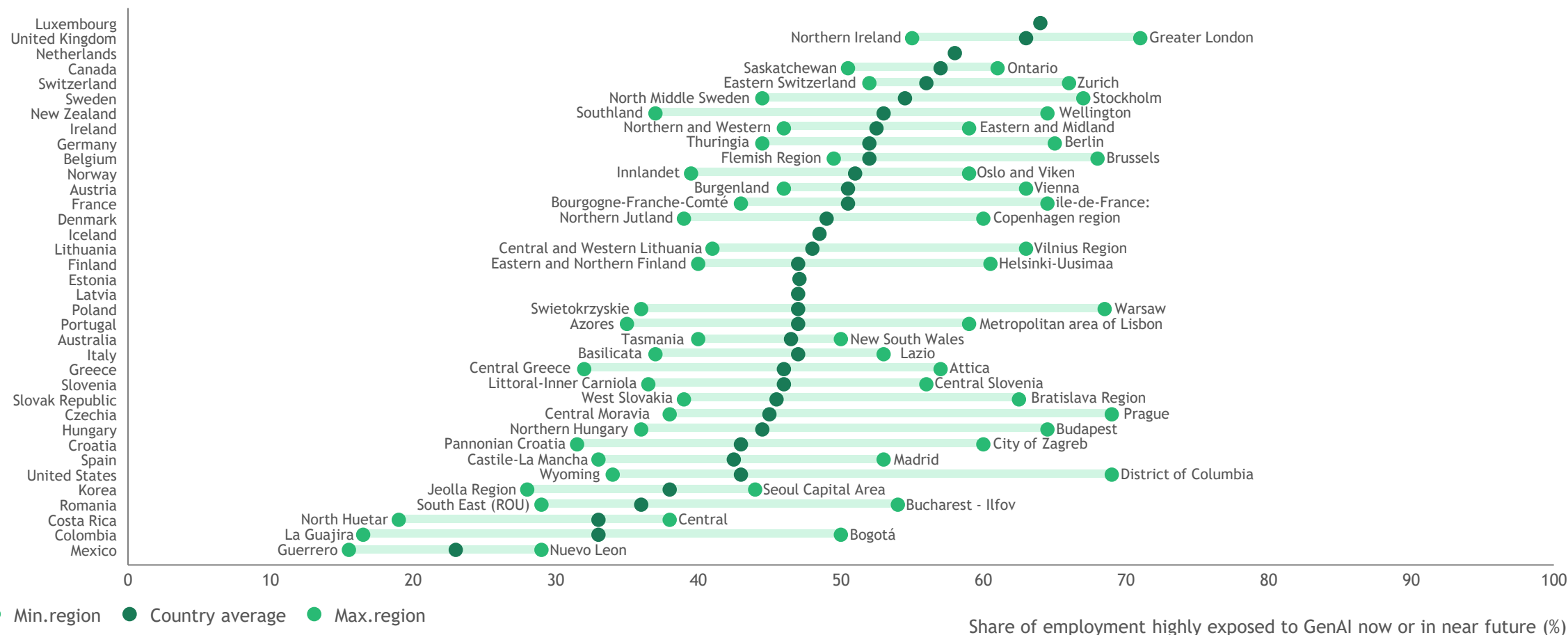
Weekly users are the most optimistic about GenAI's impact, while nonusers are the most pessimistic

Sentiment to GenAI by frequency of usage



However, the labor market's exposure to GenAI could range from 16% to 77% across regions

Share of employment highly exposed to GenAI now or in the near future, latest available year



Source: Job Creation and Local Economic Development, 2024.

The creative class is core to cities' existence

“Places that succeed in attracting and retaining creative class people prosper; those that fail don’t.”
— Richard Florida, *The Rise of the Creative Class* (2002)



Cities thrive on creativity...

- ◆ Cities depend on creative talent to drive innovation, fuel economic growth, and inspire urban renewal
- ◆ Creative people transform declining urban areas into vibrant neighborhoods, bringing economic and cultural revival
- ◆ Without creativity, cities lose their competitive edge, becoming economically stagnant and culturally depleted



...and creativity flourishes in cities

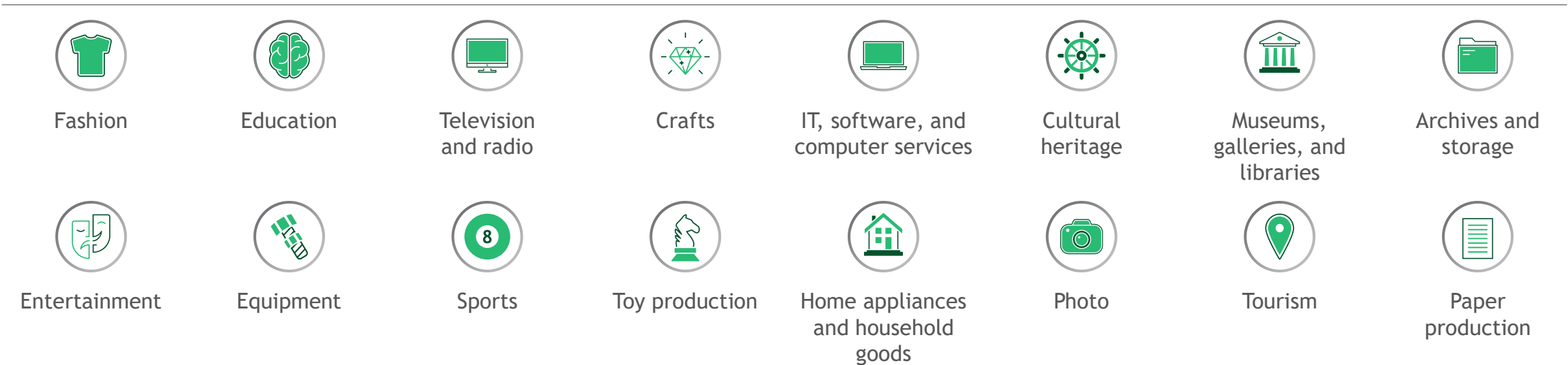
- ◆ Urban areas provide the density, connectivity, and collaborative networks essential for creative innovation
- ◆ Cities offer inspiration, resources, and opportunities that empower creative professionals to achieve their highest potential
- ◆ Creative ideas flourish in dynamic urban environments where cultural exchange and diversity of thought are abundant

There is no single approach—most cities recognize two groups: 7 industries as creative and 16 more are present in various classifications

The most characteristic types of creative industries (present in most classifications)

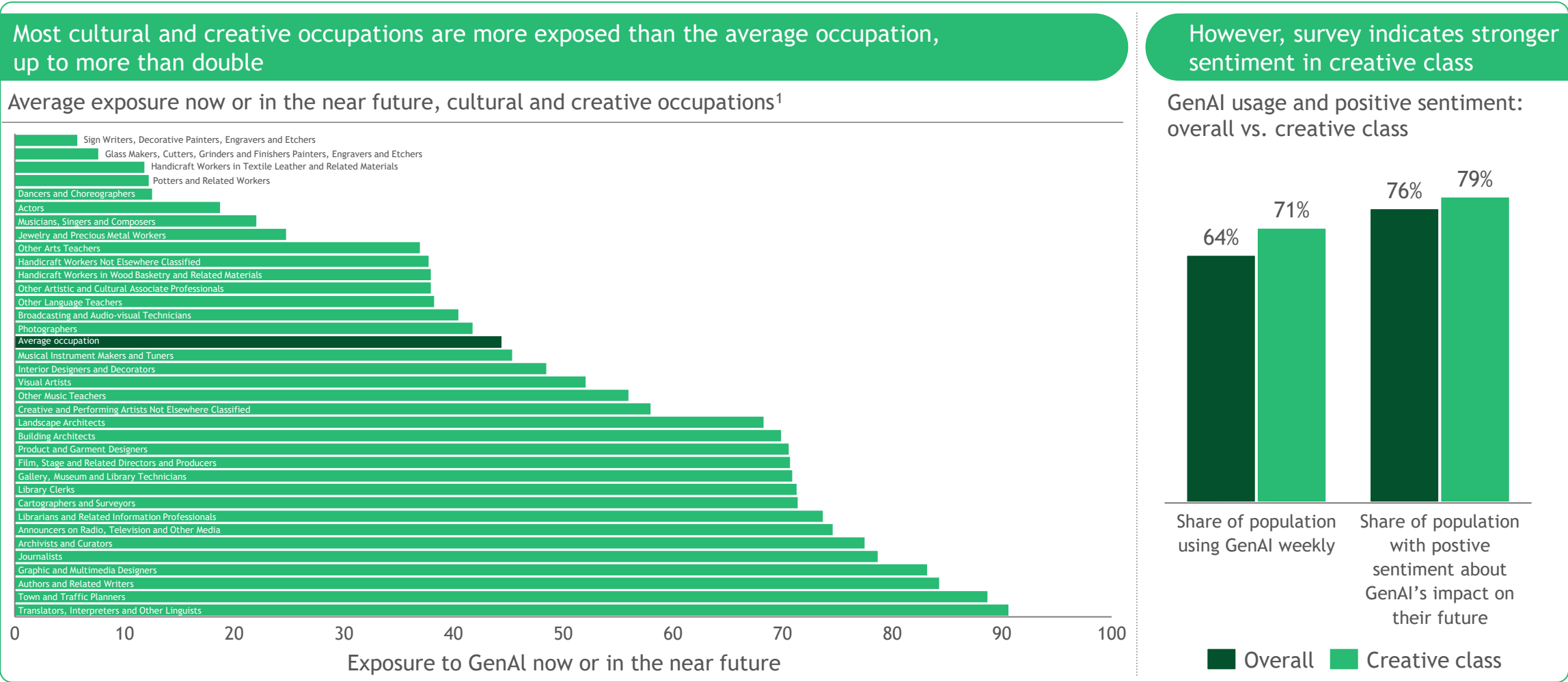


Creative industries, according to some classifications



¹. Includes literary works, books, and the press.
Source: ESSnet Culture; Guide to Eurostat Culture Statistics; UNESCO Framework for Cultural Statistics handbook No. 1; BCG analysis.

Both groups are most significantly exposed to and most optimistic about the perspective



1. Cultural and creative occupations are defined in ISCO at the 4-digit level according to the Eurostat definition used by the OECD.
Source: (Eloundou et al., 2023^[47], (OECD, 2022^[53]), Cities of Choice Survey, 2025.

Cities worldwide are implementing proactive strategies to mitigate AI-driven job displacement in the creative industry

Mitigation measure	Description	City examples
 Regulation and policy for protecting creative rights	Laws and guidelines protecting creators' rights and ensuring fair AI usage	• Paris (2025): National consultation developing frameworks to license creative content for AI, ensuring creators receive fair compensation and credit • Seoul (2025): Basic Act on AI mandating clear labeling of AI-generated content, protecting creators from unauthorized use
 Union negotiations to ensure human authorship and control	Union agreements ensuring human creators maintain credit and control	• Los Angeles (2023): Writers Guild (WGA) secured contractual protections that AI-generated material cannot reduce writers' credits or compensation • Los Angeles (2023): SAG-AFTRA ensured actors' informed consent and compensation for use of digital replicas or AI-generated likenesses
 Training and upskilling	Specialized programs helping creatives integrate AI into workflows	• Tokyo (2023-2024): Industry-supported training programs encouraging manga and anime artists to adopt hybrid creative-AI workflows
 Public funding and strategic investment	Public investments supporting creative industries adapting to AI changes	• London (2025): £10 million public investment in creative sectors (fashion, film, gaming), funding human-led innovation and skills training • Seoul (2024): AI Innovation Hub ("AI Tech City") providing resources, financial support, and facilities to help creative businesses leverage AI effectively

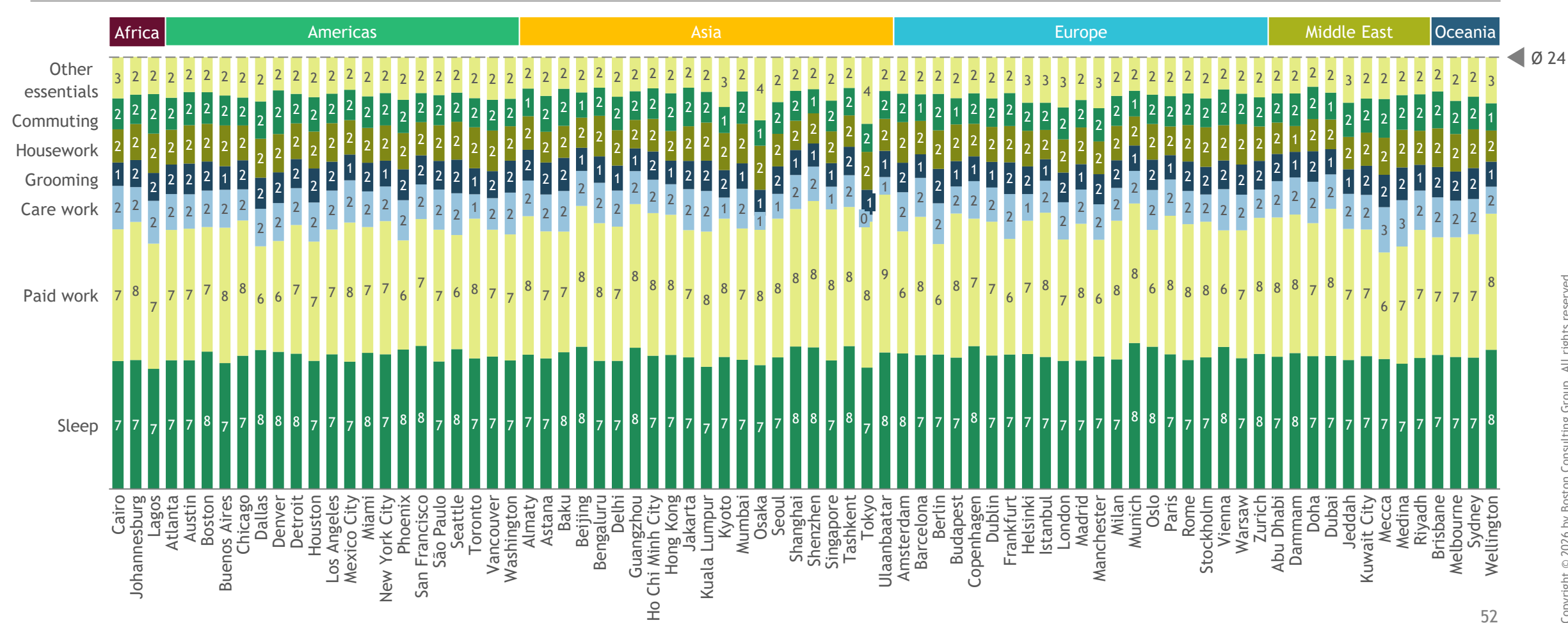
Theme 4

Leisure time and work-life balance

People (especially young people) increasingly value leisure time and work-life balance

Among employed people, work dominates the day, especially in Asia and the Middle East, and crowds out personal or domestic time

Survey: How much time per day do you spend on the following activities? (sum=24 hours)
 Sample: Employed respondents, n=120-300 per city



Work intensity peaks during midcareer years in over 50 cities, while in about 20 cities, residents aged 55 and older work the most, on average

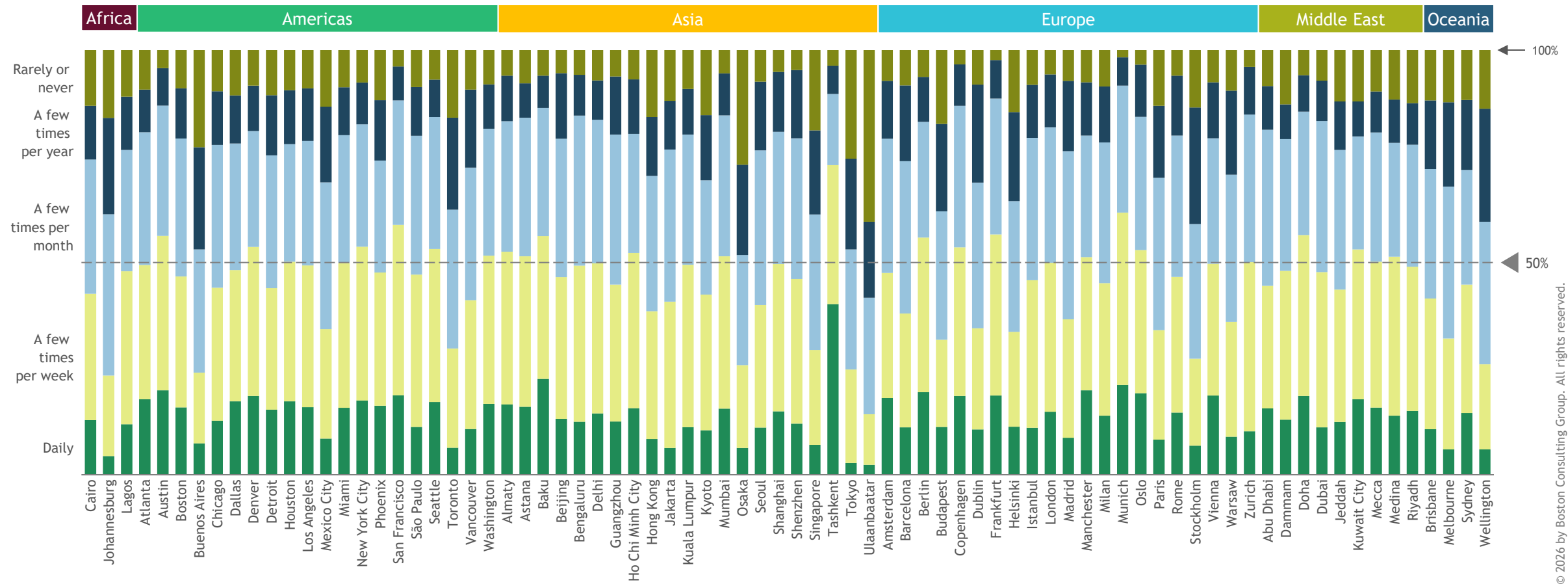
Average daily hours spent on paid work by employed peoples by age group



Survey: How much time per day do you spend on paid work?
Sample: Employed respondents, n=120-300 per city.

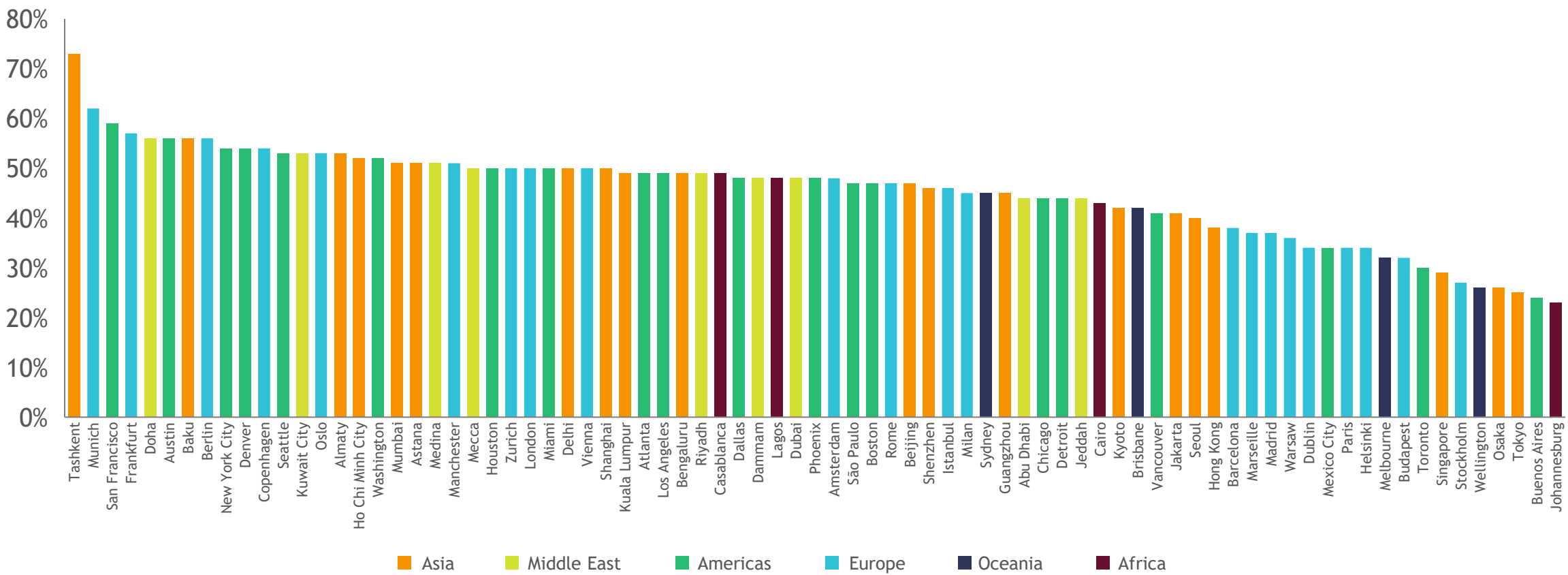
Only in 29 cities do more than half of the respondents visit leisure locations at least a few times a week

Survey: How frequently do you visit the following social and leisure locations within your city (restaurants, cafes, markets, bars, parks, entertainment)?
Sample: All respondents, n=~300 per city



All Central Asian and German cities are in top 20

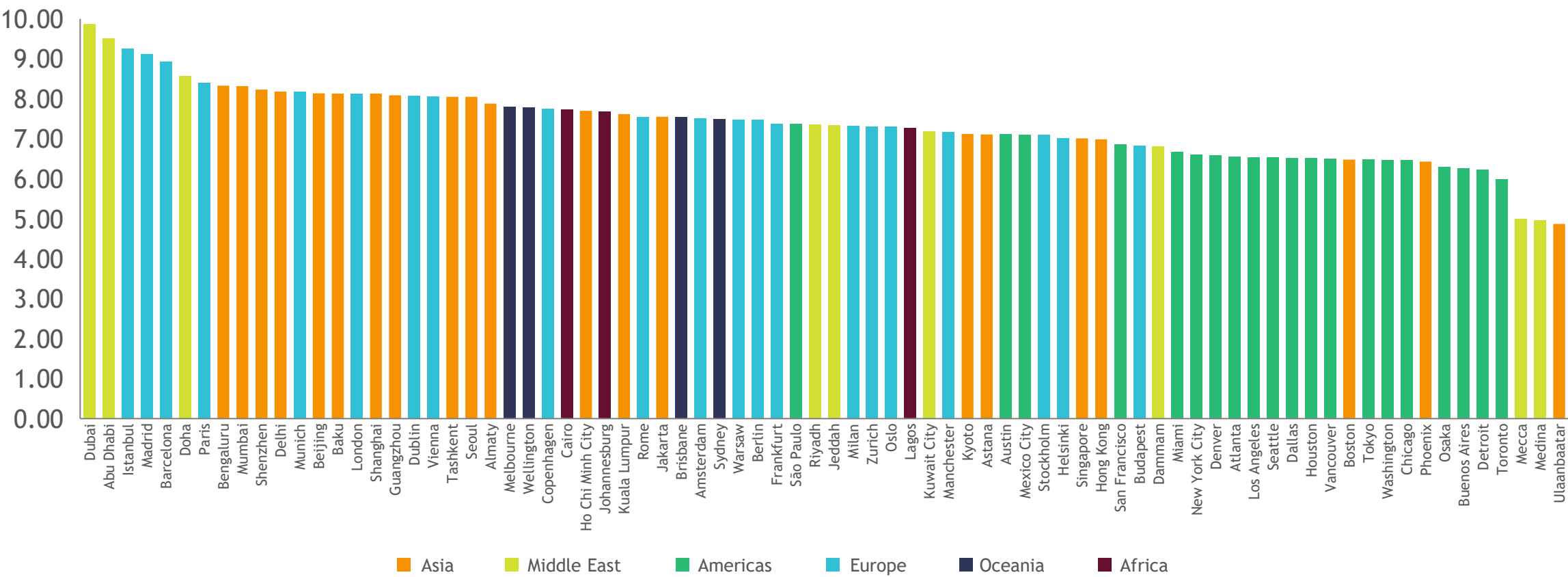
People who visit leisure locations at least several times a week (%)



Survey: How frequently do you visit the following social and leisure locations within your city (restaurants, cafes, markets, bars, parks, entertainment)?
Sample: All respondents, n=~300 per city.

UAE, European, and Asian cities lead in time spent at leisure locations, while North American cities significantly underperform despite the high frequency

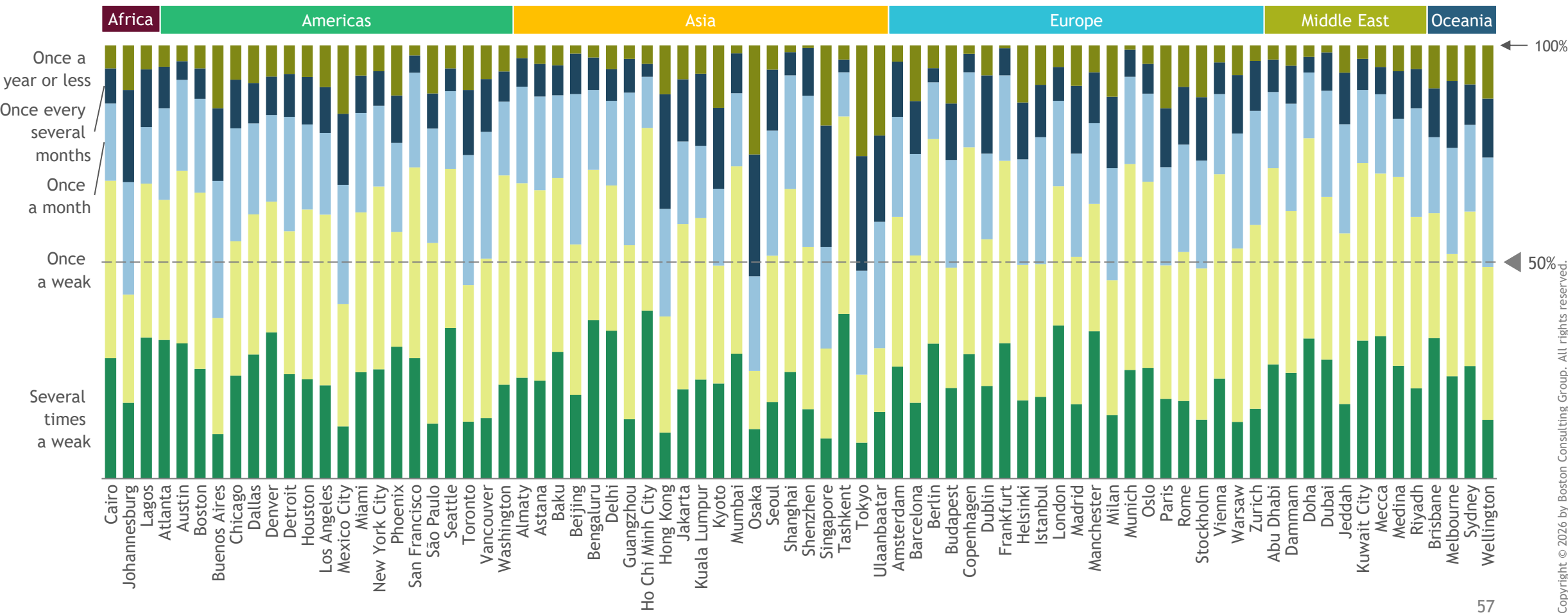
Time spent at leisure locations (hours/week)



Note: Assumptions made on the length of time (minutes) spent at each location (restaurants, cafes, markets, bars, parks and entertainment) and regarding the exact frequency number regarding the “few times per week/month/year.”

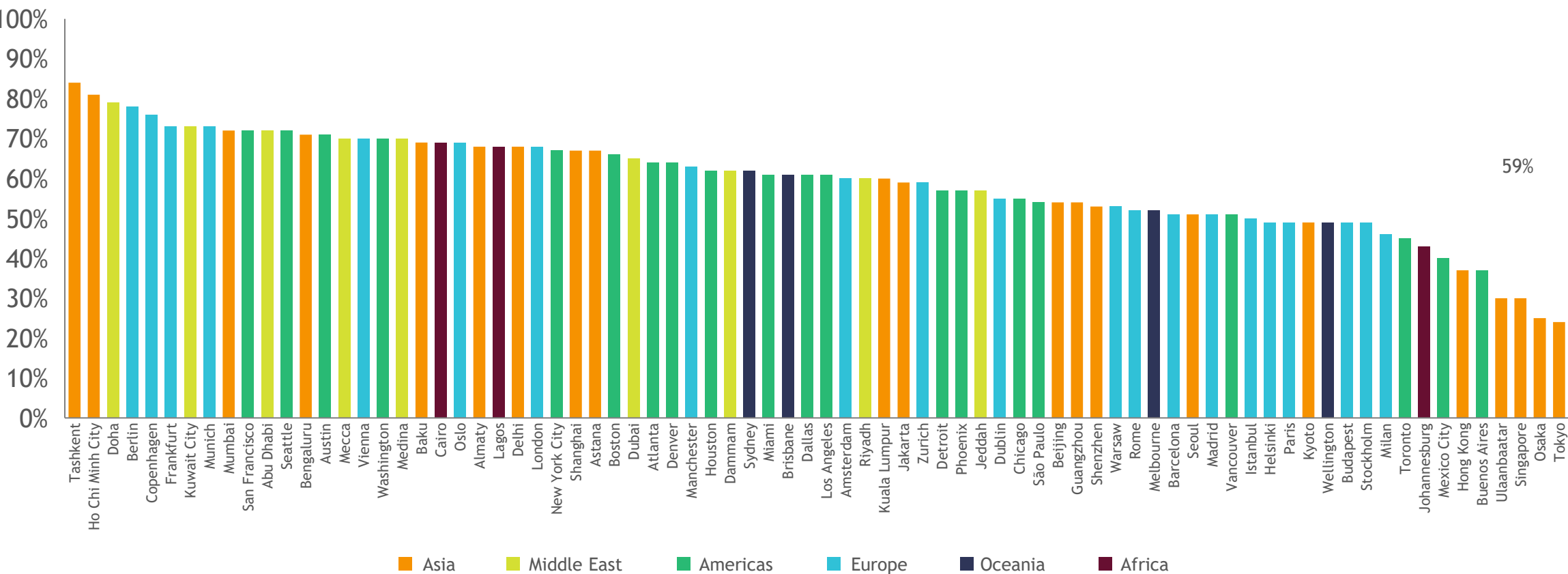
In about 80% of cities, over half of the respondents meet friends or colleagues outside work at least once a week

Survey: How often do you meet with your friends or colleagues outside work or study?
Sample: All respondents, n=~300 per city



Tashkent and Ho Chi Minh City lead in this category

Residents meeting friends outside of work at least once a week (%)



Survey: How often do you meet with your friends or colleagues outside work or study?
Sample: All respondents, n=300 per city.

On average, respondents aged 18 to 34 meet with friends more frequently, except in smaller ME cities, where older age groups are more socially active

Residents meeting friends outside of work at least once a week (%)



Survey: How often do you meet with your friends or colleagues outside work or study?
Sample: All respondents, n=~300 per city.

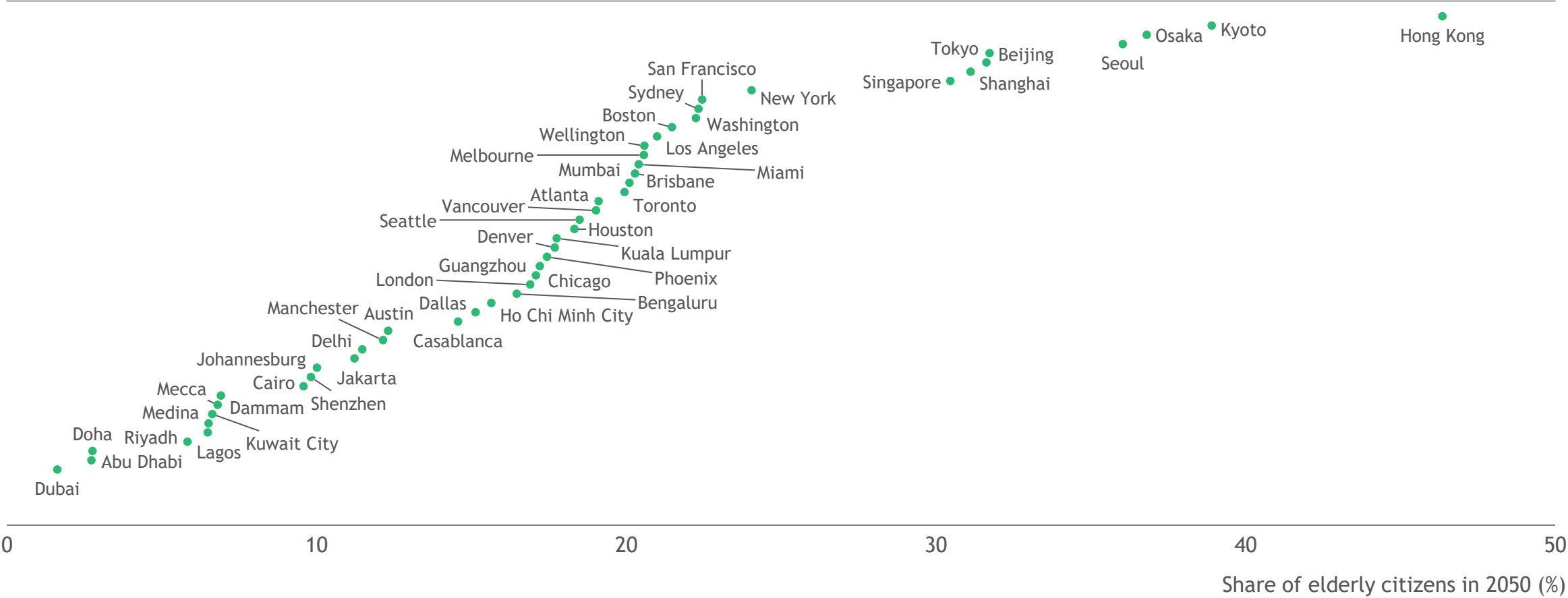
Theme 5

Longevity and healthy aging

Ultralow fertility levels and longevity and health tailwinds are leading to high proportions of elderly people

The share of the population aged 65 and older is set to rise in many cities and may grow even more due to policies and quality of health care

Share of 65+ population of total population across cities (2050)



Note: Elderly population assumed at 65+ years old across cities. Projections made assuming cities maintain current policies and regulations.
Source: BCG analysis; Oxford Economics.

Longevity and healthy aging are mandatory for a city's long-term success because needs are rising for current and future residents



Longevity and healthy aging are about more than simply living longer—they are about ensuring quality of life as people age. For cities, supporting healthy aging is critical to reducing social and health care burdens and preparing younger populations to sustain long-term well-being. Cities need to support two life strategies:



Invest early to build health capital *Longevity index (35-60 years old)*

- Longevity starts well before old age—habits formed at a younger age shape well-being later in life
- A city's **long-term livability** depends on how it equips younger residents with tools and environments to age healthily
- By fostering healthy lifestyles early, cities create a culture of wellness that benefits individuals and society across generations



We look at **which city is best in longevity** for people 35-60 years old, since cities play a critical role in providing infrastructure for longevity



Preserve health capital for lifelong well-being *Healthy aging index (60+ years old)*

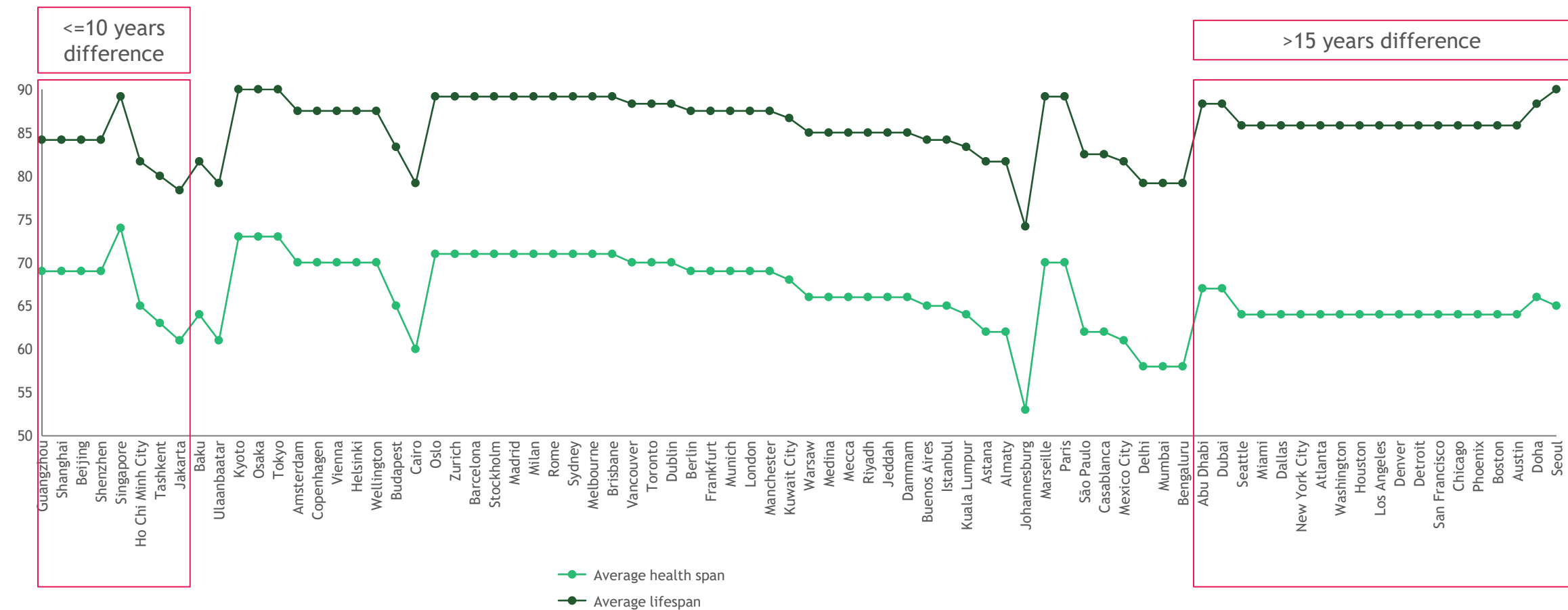
- A longer life isn't always a healthier one—the goal is to **extend health spans**, not just lifespans
- By 2050, 22% of the global population will be 60 years old or older—that's **one in every five people**
- **Supporting healthy aging** reduces the strain on health care systems and social services, while enabling older adults to remain active contributors to society



We look at **which city is best for healthy aging** in terms of living an active life and receiving decent care, focusing on people 60+ years of age

A large gap between lifespan and health span may signal that cities lack the required infrastructure and services for people to live longer, healthier lives

Seoul and Doha, as well as US and Indian cities, have the biggest gap between life and healthy life expectancy, whereas many Asian cities have the smallest difference



Note: Life expectancy and healthy life expectancy are country-level data.

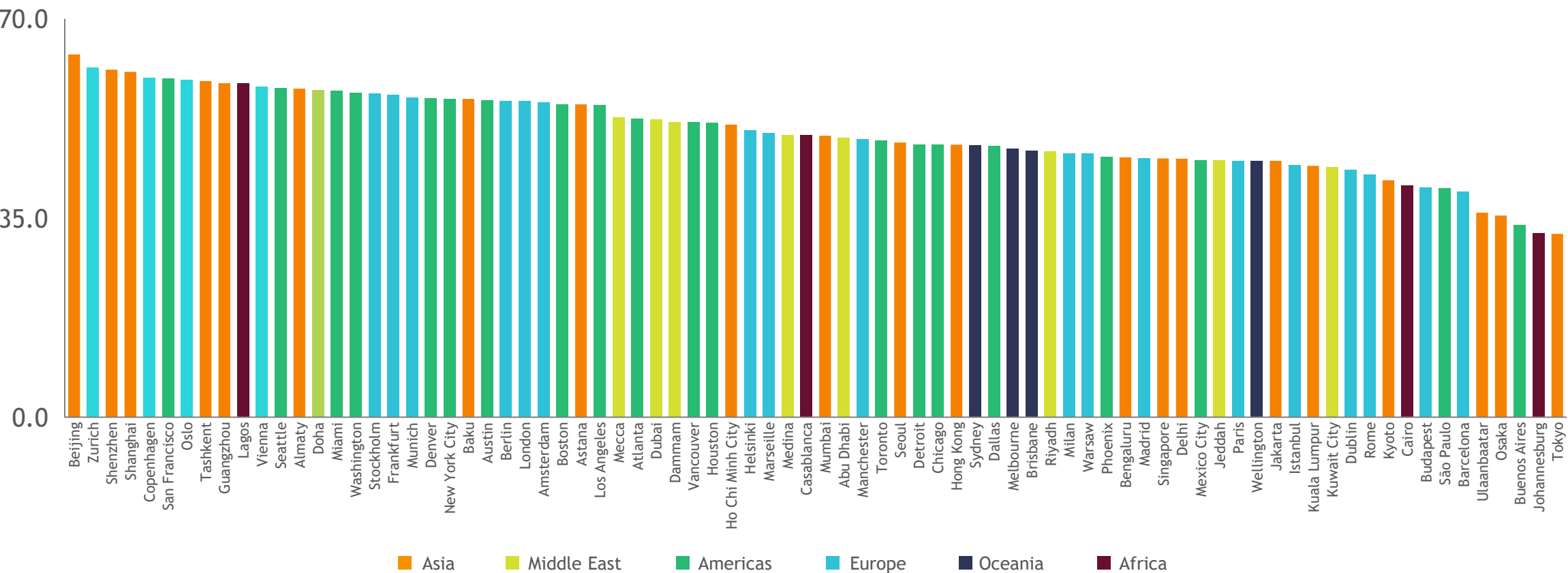
This report measures seven of eight core healthy habits¹ that build health capital early for people 35 to 60 years old and two longevity indicators

 Core dimensions that build health capital early		 Longevity indicators measured in <i>Cities of Choice 4.0</i>	
Healthy habits	 Exercise regularly	1	Share of population that practices sports regularly
	 Positive social connections	2	Share of middle-aged population that has participated in healthy lifestyle programs at least once in the past year
	 Restorative sleep	3	Share of population that uses walk/run as primary choice when going somewhere
	 Manage negative stress	4	Number of fitness centers and swimming pools per 100,000 population
	 Healthy, balanced diet	5	Share of middle-aged population that feels him/herself is part of a community
	 No excessive alcohol consumption	6	Average number of times meeting up with friends per month
	 Never smoke	7	Loneliness score
	 No opioid use	8	Hours of sleep per day
 Outdoor space		9	Happiness score
 NCDs ²		10	Number of local farmers' markets with access to fresh food, per 100,000 population
		11	Obesity rates
		12	Share of population that excessively consumes alcohol
		13	Share of population that smokes
			Not included
		14	Average number of hours spent outdoors per week
		15	Share of the city's area allocated for green spaces
		16	Probability of dying between 30-70 years old from NCDs ²

1. Source: Nguyen et al. : Impact of 8 lifestyle factors on mortality and life expectancy among United States veterans: The Million Veteran Program.
2. NCDs: Noncommunicable disease (cardiovascular diseases, cancer, diabetes, or chronic respiratory diseases).

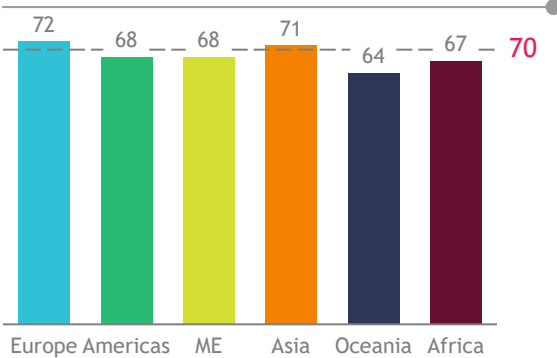
Leadership on longevity ranking for people 35 to 60 years old sits largely in Asia and Europe, but Japan falls behind the pack

Longevity for population 35-60 years old, subranking score (0-100)

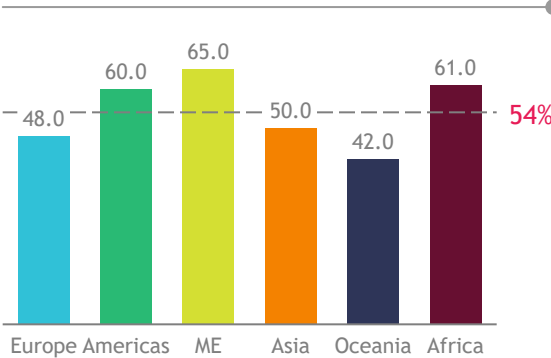


Details | Across survey-based indicators, Middle Eastern cities score above average on most, whereas Oceanian cities fall behind the average

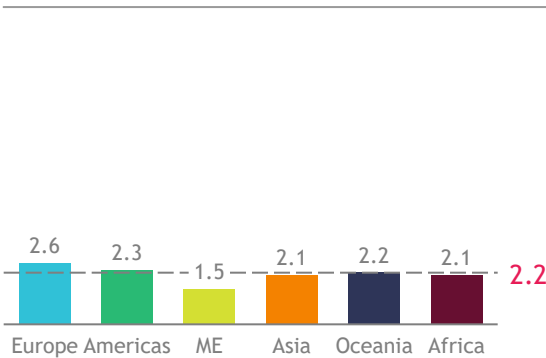
Residents who choose walk/run as primary method when going somewhere, score (0-100)



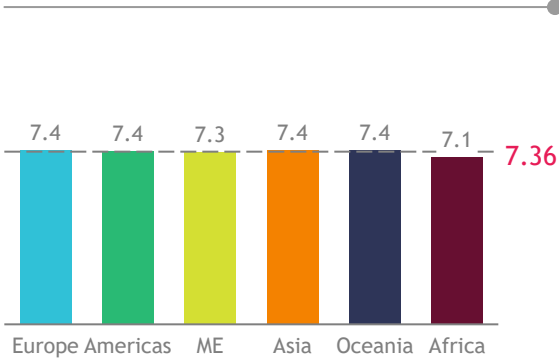
Residents who participated in healthy lifestyle program at least once in the past 12 months (%)



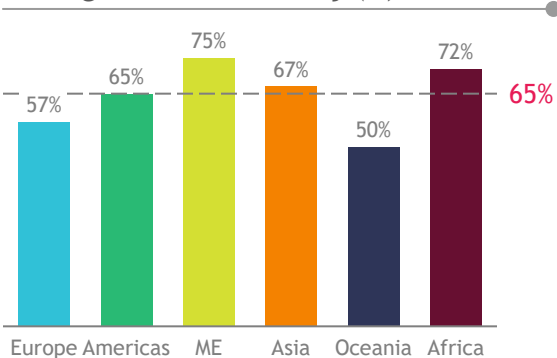
Number of hours spent outdoors every week



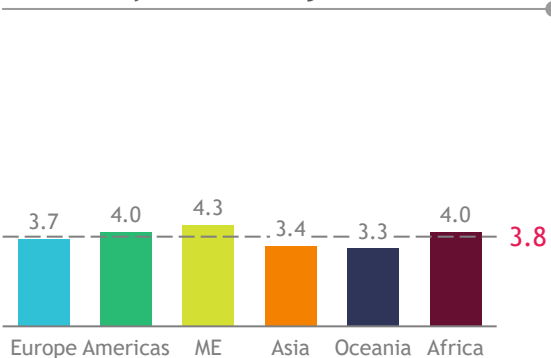
Number of hours of sleep per day



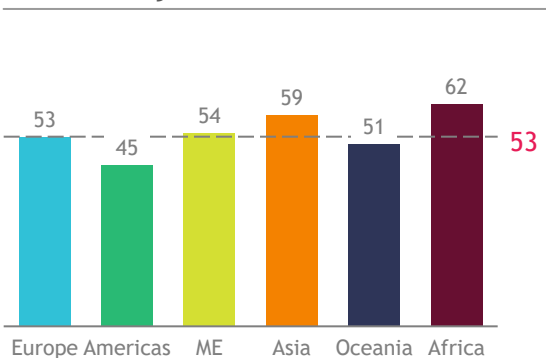
Residents who believe him/herself belongs to a community (%)



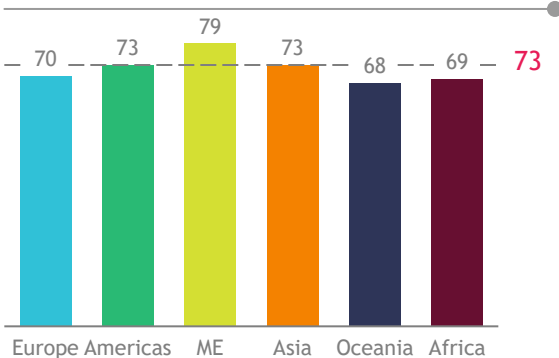
Number of times per month that respondent meets friends/colleagues outside of work/study



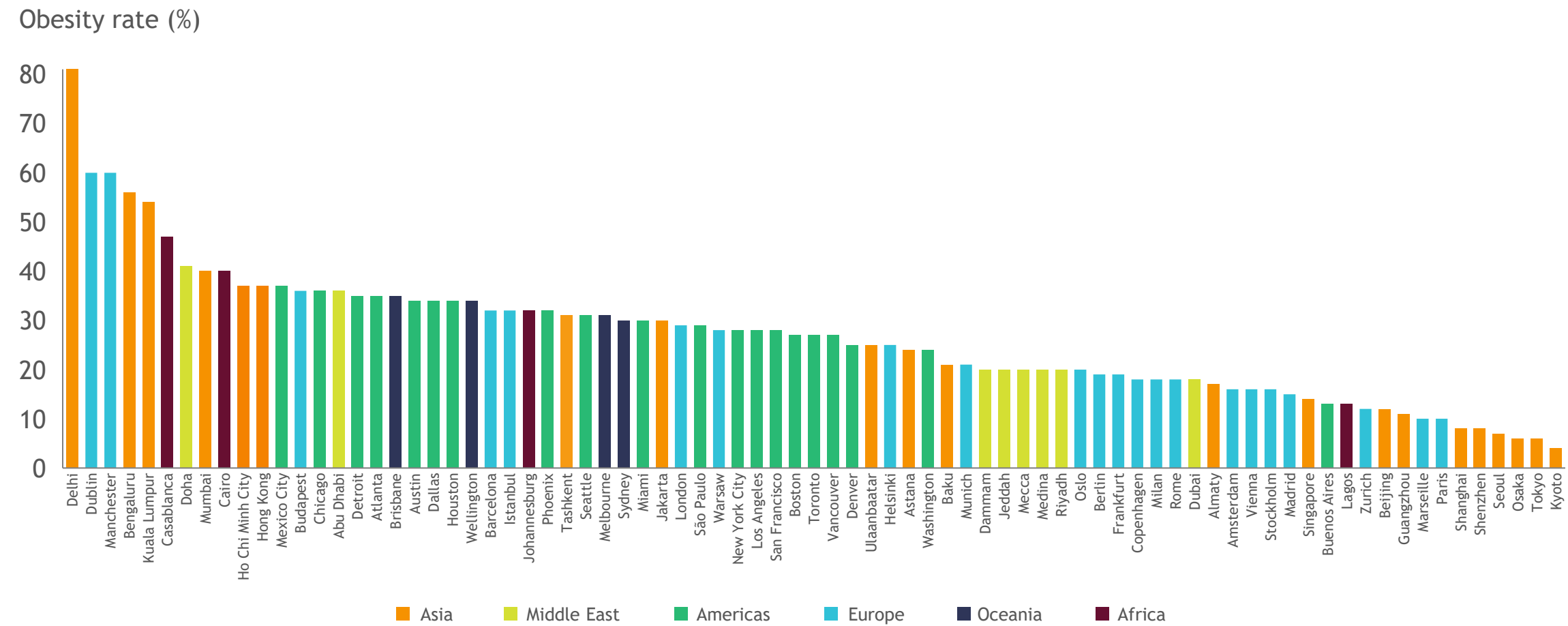
Loneliness index, survey, share of feeling lonely; 100 most connected, 0 most lonely



Happiness index, survey, share of feeling happy; 100 most happy, 0 most sad



Details | East Asian cities and Paris have the lowest obesity rates, whereas Delhi stands at 81%



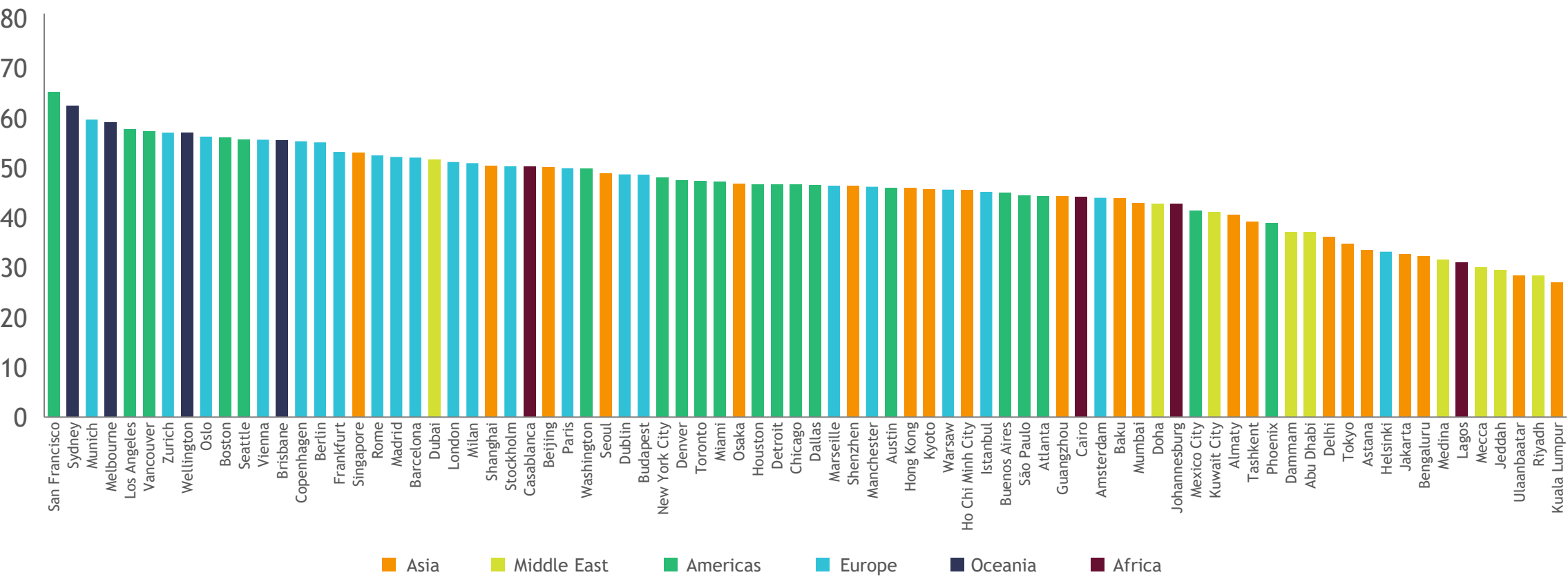
Cities of Choice 4.0 evaluates six dimensions to determine if a city enables residents to preserve health capital in healthy aging index

Group	Indicator	Group	Indicator
Climate 16.7%	1 Extreme temperatures score (Celsius degrees exceeding limits of extreme temperature)	Social connection 16.7%	17 Elderly loneliness score
	2 Average number of hours of sunshine per year		18 Share of elderlies that consider him/herself as part of a certain community
	3 Number of months with a comfortable daytime temperature	Longevity programs 16.7%	19 Existence of elderly-dedicated community centers
	4 The average annual temperature difference		20 Availability of outreach and regular check-in services for elderlies
Ecology 16.7%	5 Air quality: PM2.5 content		21 Provision of elderly-friendly infrastructure in public spaces and facilities
	6 Air quality: PM10 content		22 Survey: I am satisfied with the elderly-friendliness of infrastructure
	7 Air quality: NO ₂ content		23 Access to lifelong learning and digital inclusion programs for seniors
	8 Air quality: O ₃ content		24 Implementation of social inclusion initiatives to reduce isolation and loneliness for elders
	9 Commitment of city to sustainability actions	Affordability 16.7%	25 Nonfood price index
Health care 16.7%	10 Share of solid household waste that is recycled or recovered		26 Share of food expenses in total expenses
	11 Number of doctors per 100,000 population		27 Number of hours that a person needs to work to purchase 1 square meter of housing
	12 Number of hospital beds per 100,000 population		28 The share of the utilities costs in the average monthly disposable household income
	13 Number of ambulances per 100,000 population		29 The average cost of renting a one-room apartment outside the city's downtown area in relation to the average monthly disposable income for a household
	14 Days taken to receive a nonurgent medical appointment		30 My personal finances and income are sufficient to give me the lifestyle I expect (elders only)
	15 Share of elderlies who participated in healthy lifestyle programs during the last year		
	16 Share of elderlies who had a medical checkup in last year		
Weight assigned			

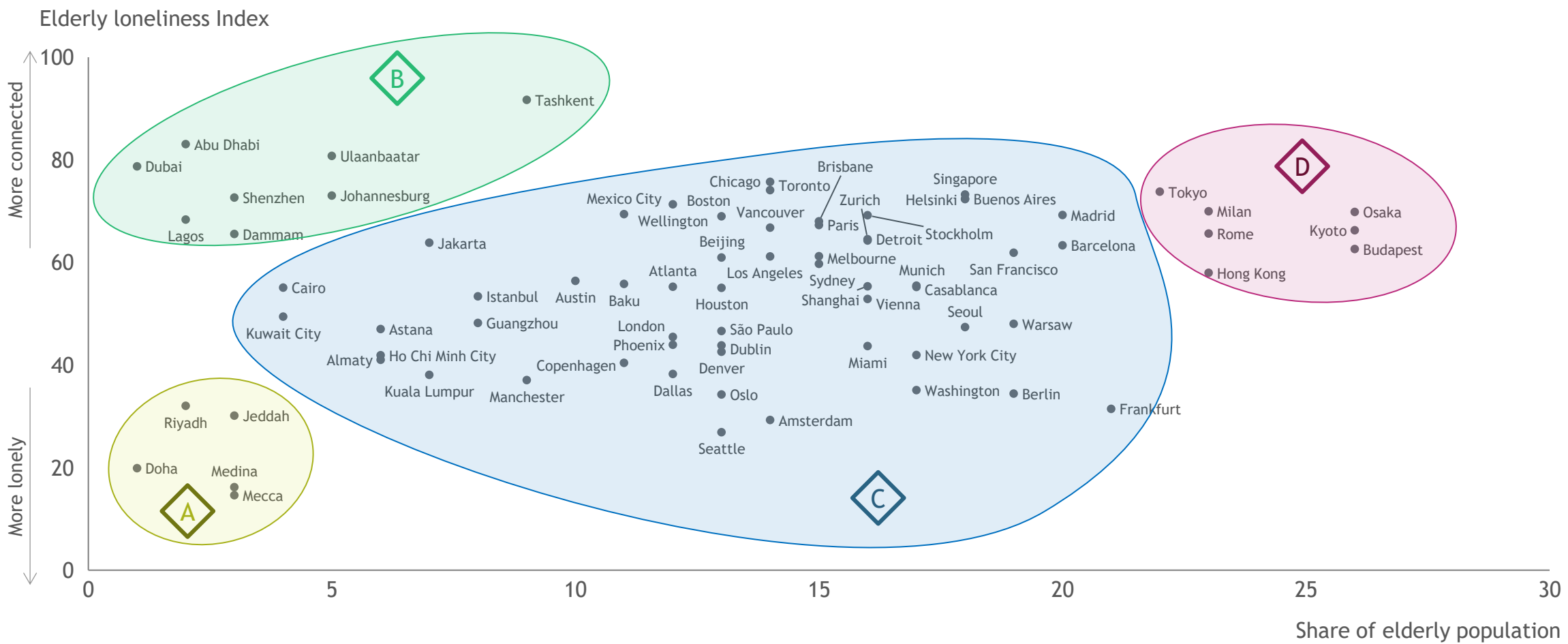
Note: O₃ = ozone.

While American, Oceanian, and European cities lead the healthy aging index, Asian and Middle Eastern cities lag behind

Healthy aging subranking score (0-100)

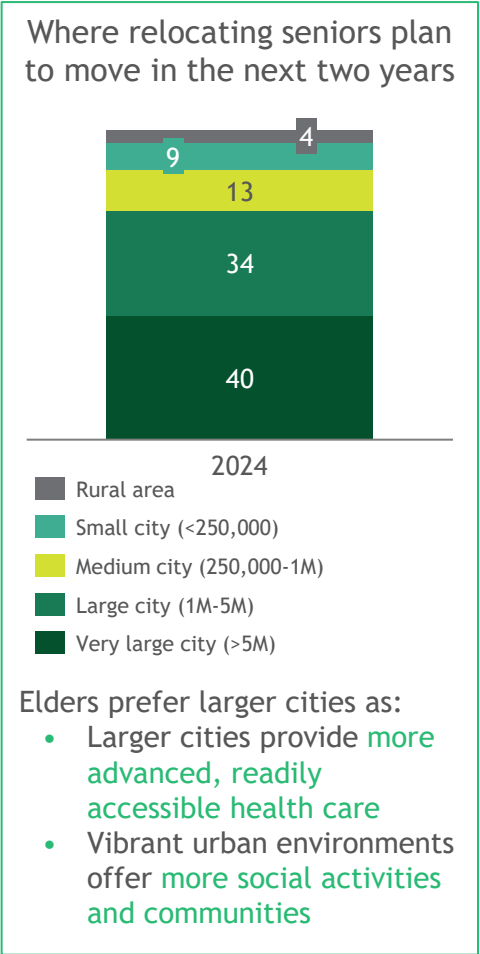
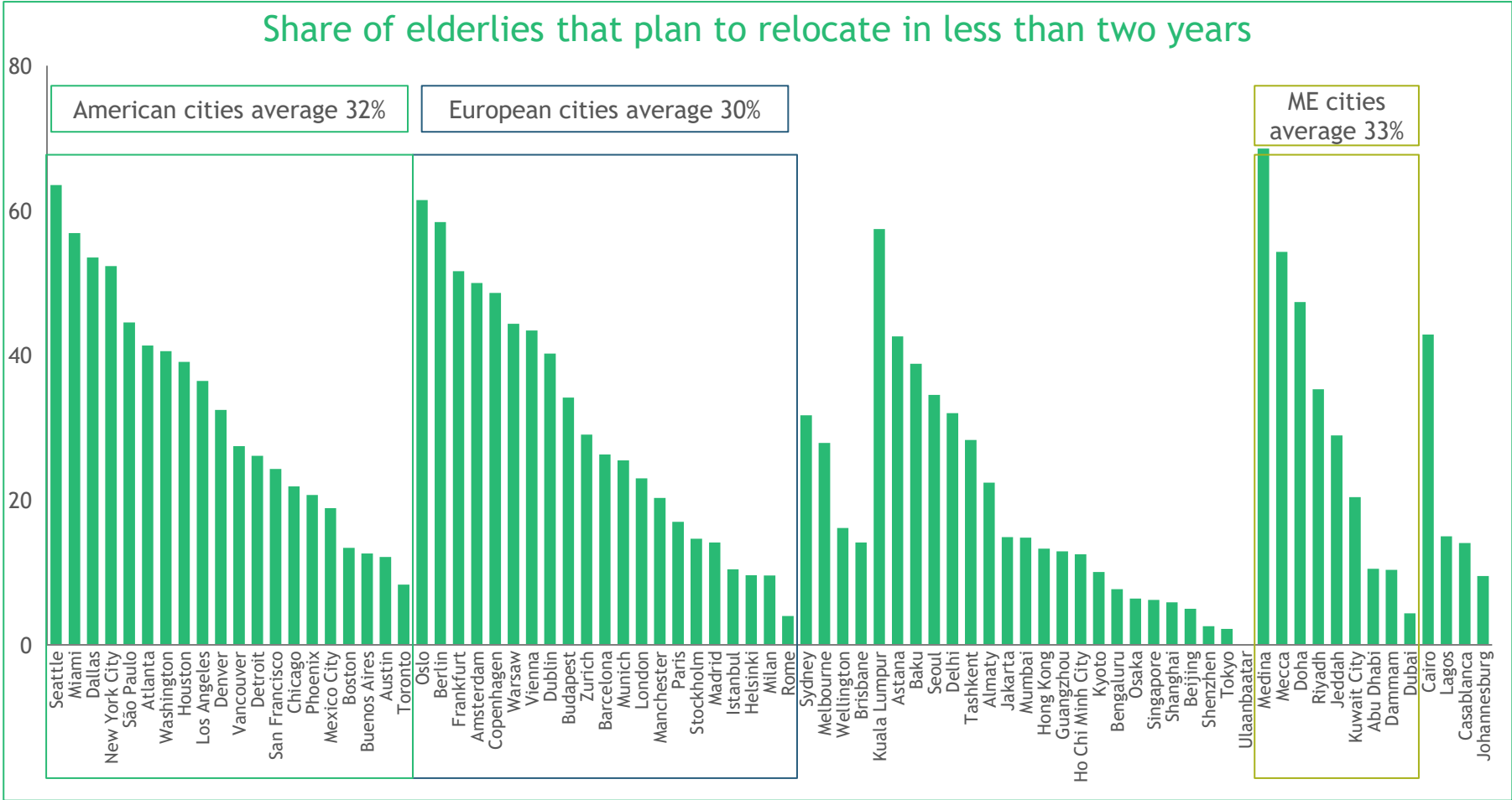


Cities predominantly sit in archetype C, with a moderate elderly share and a medium loneliness index

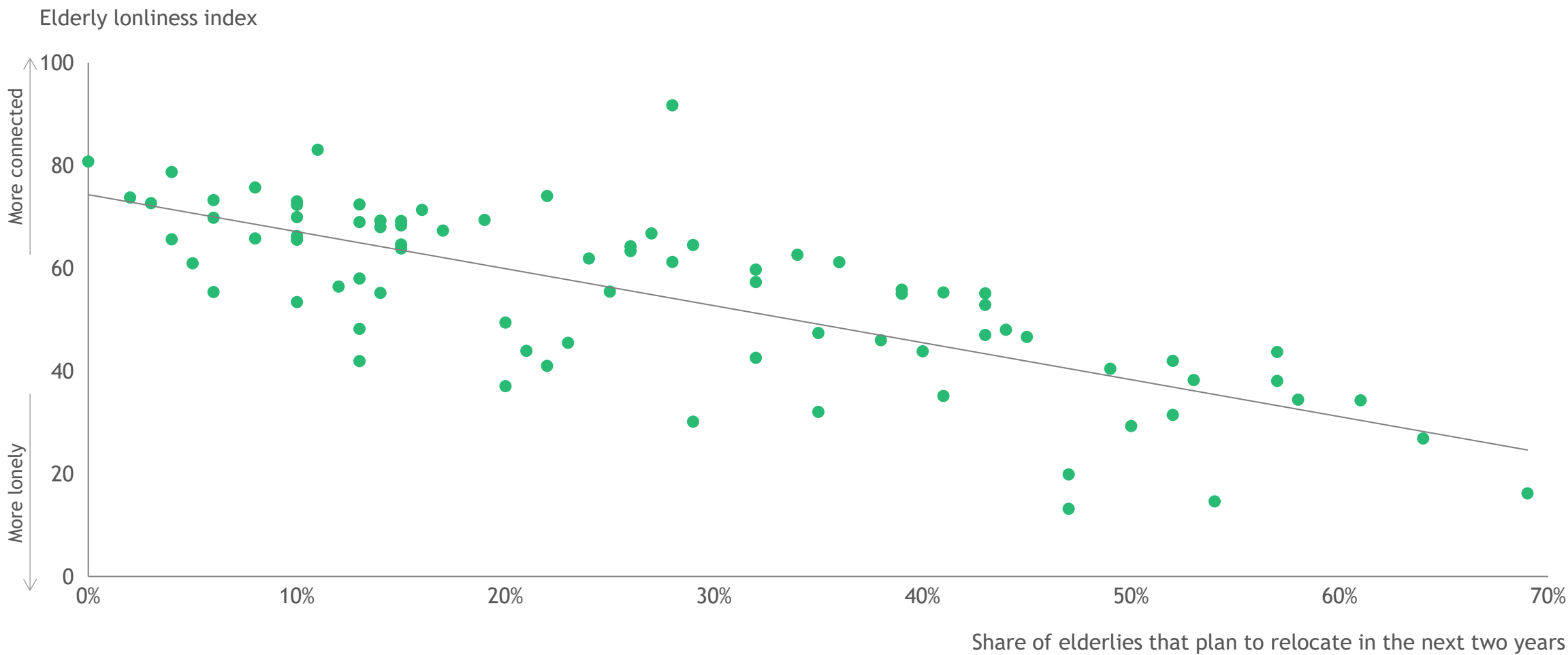


Twenty-seven percent of respondents aged 60 or older want to move to other large cities

Largest share was recorded in cities where elderly feel more lonely



Higher loneliness among seniors corresponds to a greater share of those planning to leave their city



All cities should prepare for aging populations by designing for connection, access, and care

				
	Less elderly, more lonely	Less elderly, less lonely	Moderately elderly, moderately lonely	More elderly, moderately lonely
Implication	- Consider improving mobility and access so older adults can reach people and places easily - Invest in programs that create frequent, low-friction social contact for seniors	- Protect what already works by funding community hubs and intergenerational activities - Prepare for demographic shift by planning age-friendly infrastructure	Remove participation barriers to community activities so moderate engagement becomes habitual - Grow the supply and diversity of connection opportunities	- Leverage the large senior population to seed and scale neighborhood-based communities - Invest in citywide age-friendly infrastructure so participation becomes effortless
Examples	Riyadh, Doha, Mecca	Dubai, Shenzhen, Ulaanbaatar	Sydney, London, Zurich, Shanghai	Hong Kong, Osaka, Rome

Longevity | Ensure age-friendly infrastructure, community care, and accessible services for seniors



Upgrading existing residential neighborhoods to better accommodate elderly residents



Beijing installs elevators in older walk-up apartment buildings across various districts and incorporates accessibility upgrades like handrails and nonslip walkways



Kyoto offers subsidies for retrofitting traditional wooden houses (*machiya*) with senior-friendly amenities



Barrier-free public transit ensuring full accessibility for elderly passengers



Japan implements a nationwide policy requiring barrier-free public transportation; nearly all major train and subway stations in Japanese cities feature wheelchair access, elevators, ramps, and clear navigation systems



Seoul ensures all subway stations have elevators or escalators and that buses are fully wheelchair accessible



Designated elderly-friendly zones in urban areas with targeted safety measures



Singapore has created “Silver Zones,” specially marked residential areas with lower speed limits, narrower lanes, and extended pedestrian crossing times



New York City implements the “Safe Streets for Seniors” initiative, where intersections have been redesigned with pedestrian islands, extended crossing signals, and improved signage in these identified neighborhoods



Regular services delivered directly to elderly at home



Cities including Beijing, Seoul, and Shanghai provide extensive home-based caregiving services, with trained professionals or volunteers regularly visiting elderly residents for personal care, medical assistance, or social interaction



Longevity | Involve the elderly population in social and economic activities



Social activities and lifelong learning programs that allow elderlies to remain socially engaged, physically active, and mentally stimulated



Hong Kong operates the “Elder Academy,” enabling seniors to participate in educational courses at schools and universities, facilitating continuous learning and social integration



New York City provides extensive senior center programs, including wellness activities, arts and technology classes, and social clubs, promoting an active, connected lifestyle for elderly residents



Intergenerational support programs that reduce isolation and foster mutual aid



Tokyo operates innovative home-sharing programs where university students that need affordable housing live with elderly residents, offering companionship while addressing housing need



Elderly-focused neighborhoods providing essentials within close proximity



Shanghai has created “15-minute Elderly Care Service Circles,” ensuring seniors can access essential health care, social services, and community activities within a short walking distance from their homes



Singapore developed “Kampung Admiralty,” an integrated residential complex that combines senior-friendly housing with health care facilities, retail spaces, parks, and community services



Policies providing financial or service support to individuals caring for elderly family members



Singapore provides the “Caregiver Support Grant,” offering financial assistance directly to families caring for elderly relatives with moderate to severe disabilities



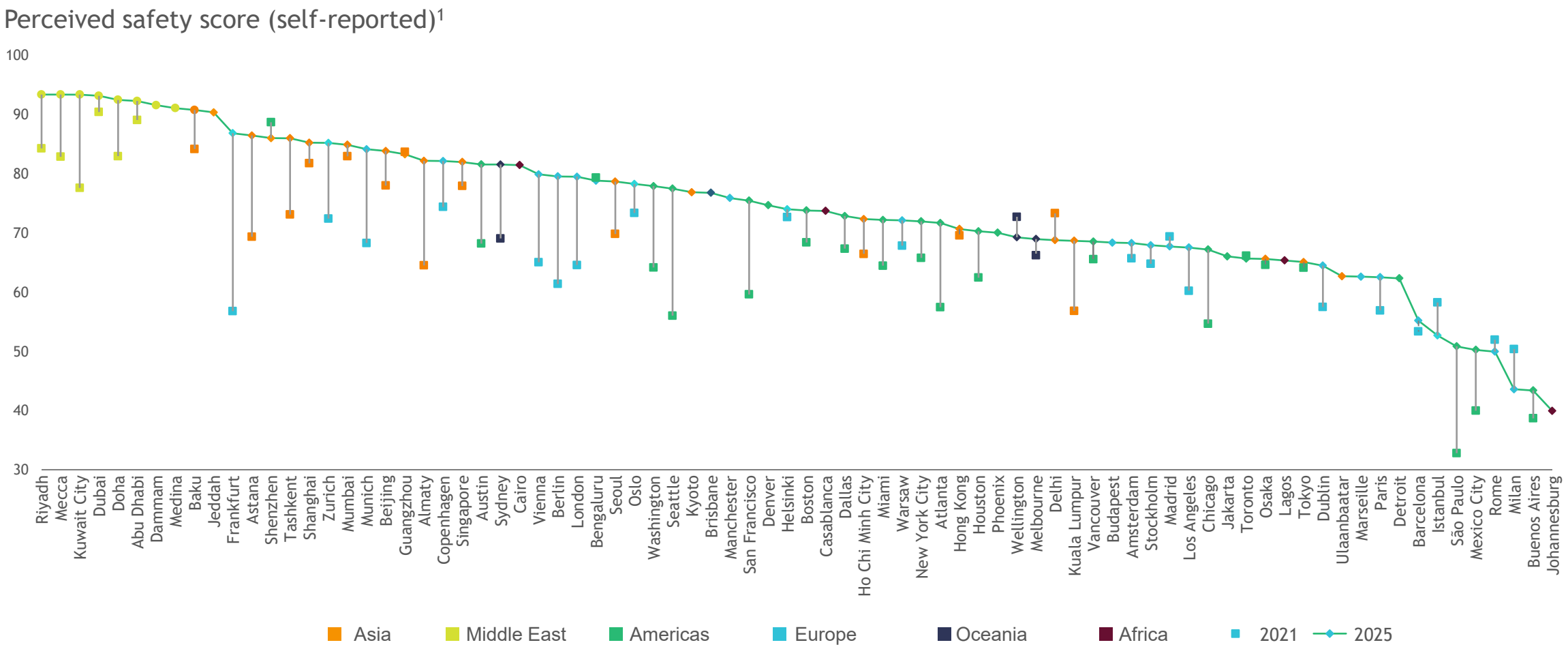
Tokyo offers tax deductions and subsidies for families employing professional caregivers

Theme 6

Safety and resilience

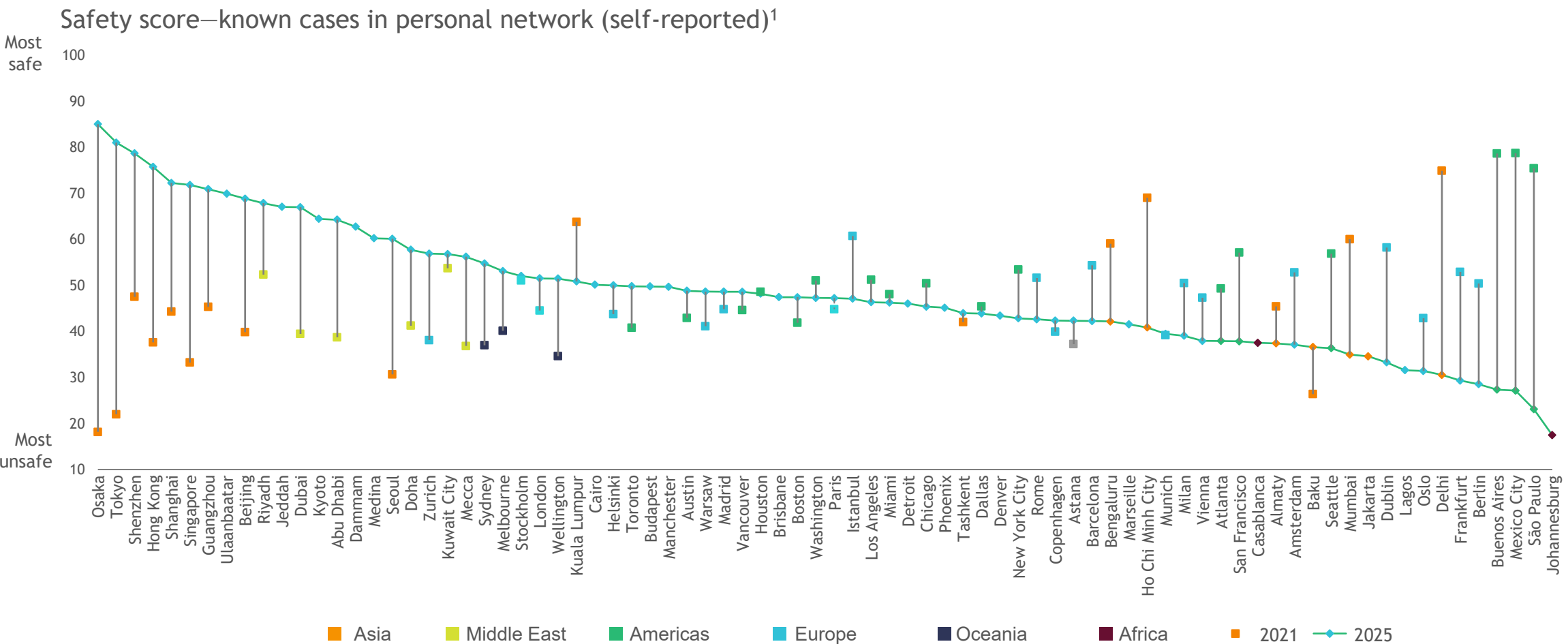
Lower societal trust, climate disruptions, and high-profile acts of terror are increasing resilience and safety concerns in cities

Overall, residents report feeling safer than they did in 2021, with ME and Asian cities continuing to lead in perceived safety



1. Based on survey question: To what extent do you agree with the statement “I feel safe in the city”?

Known crime cases show mixed trends—Asian and ME cities remain the safest, while South American cities have worsened notably



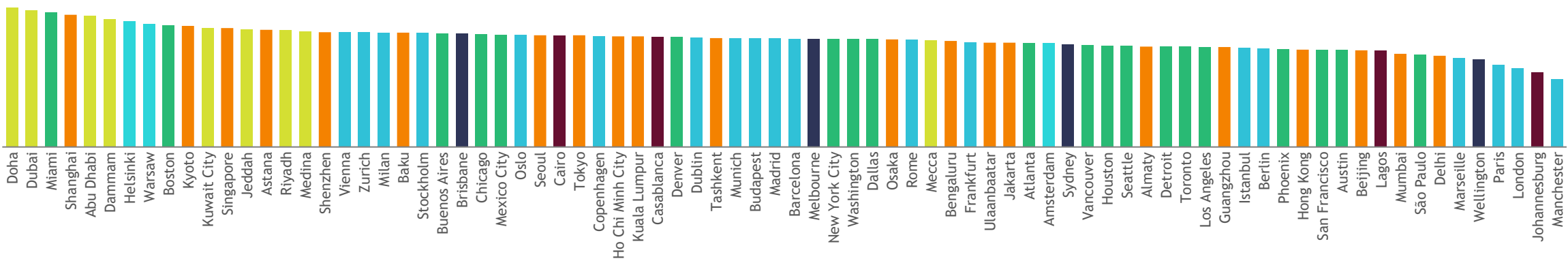
1. Based on survey question: Do you know of any cases when you or anyone you know personally got physically attacked or robbed, insulted or pestered while in the public space or at home?

Safety and resilience indicators organized by objective and subjective metrics

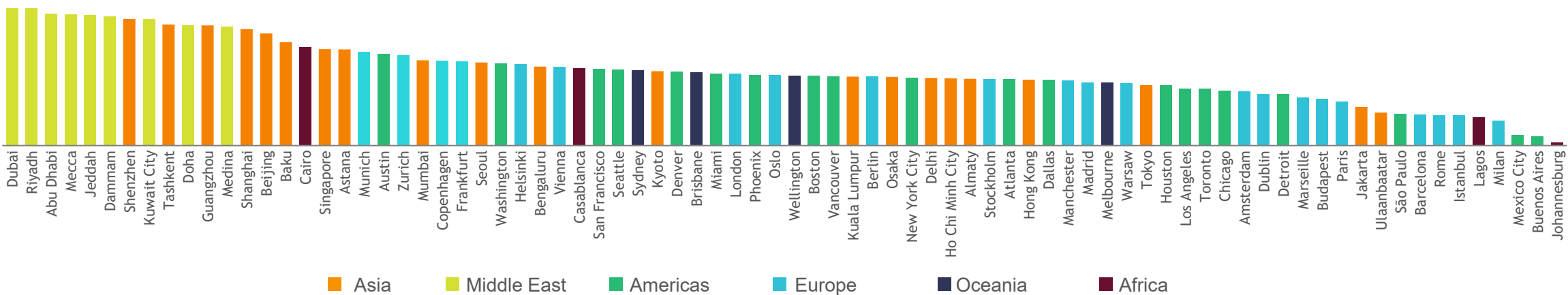
Layer 1	Group	Indicator	Layer 2	Group	Indicator
 Objective indicators	Safety	1 Murders per year per 100,000 population	 Subjective indicators	Safety	14 Do you know of situation when someone whom you know personally was physically assaulted or robbed, insulted or molested in a public place or at home?
		2 Violent crimes - kidnapping per 100,000			
		3 Violent crimes - serious assault per 100,000			15 Generally, I feel safe in the city
		4 Street lighting			
		5 Number of CCTV cameras within city area			16 How much you worry about being physically attacked or robbed while in a public space
	Resilience	6 Number of victims of terrorist attacks in the last 10 years per 100,000 population			17 How much you worry about being insulted or pestered while in a public space
		7 Number of deaths from terrorist attacks in the last 10 years per 100,000 population			18 How much you worry about your personal belongings being stolen
		8 Number of deaths from natural disasters in the last 10 years per 100,000 population			
		9 Level of exposure to natural disasters and estimated potential impact of natural disasters (index)		Resilience	19 I trust the police in the city
		10 Number of intensive care beds per 100,000 population			20 I trust the courts of the city
		11 Resilience strategy (incl. sustainability, to extreme natural disasters, terrorism/war) in place			21 I trust the city mayor and his/her team
		12 Number of emergency service personnel per 100,000 population			22 I trust the leader of country and his/her team

While subjective and objective measures show some variation, ME and Asian cities maintain leading positions in safety and resilience

Objective safety and resilience city subranking score (0-100)

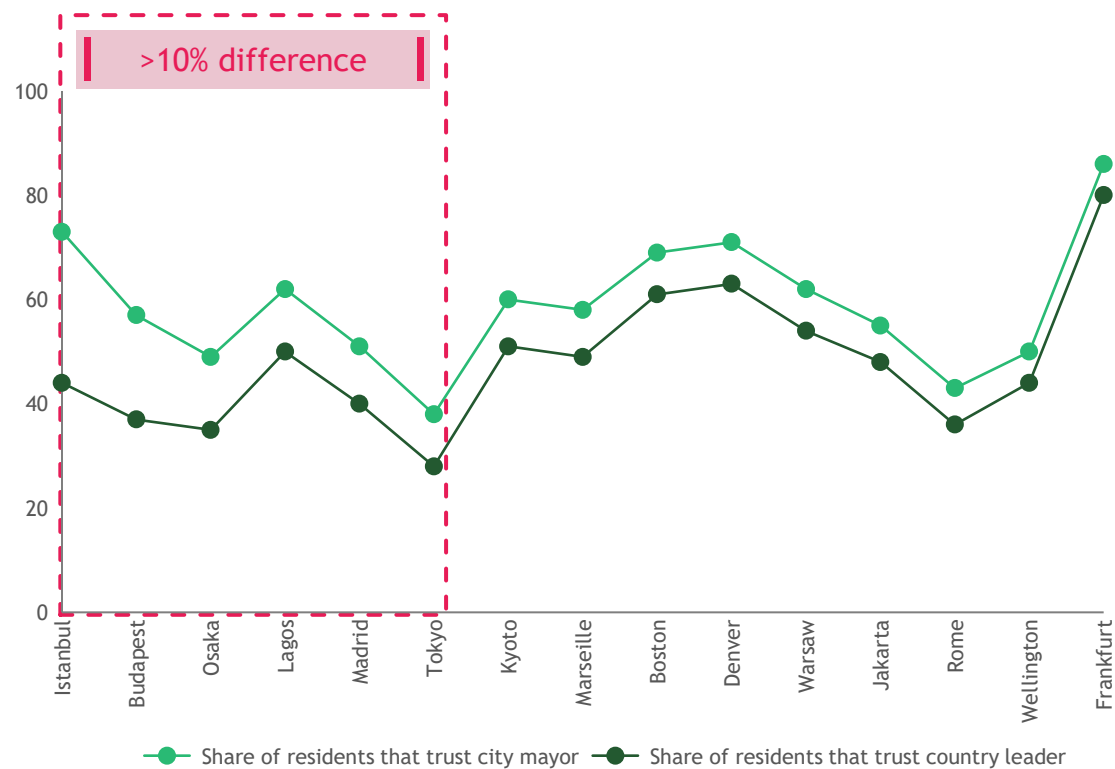


Subjective safety and resilience city subranking score (0-100)



In some cities, residents trust city leaders more than national ones, stemming from underperforming national authorities or more responsive local leadership

Top 15 cities with the largest positive gap in trust for city mayor vs. country leader

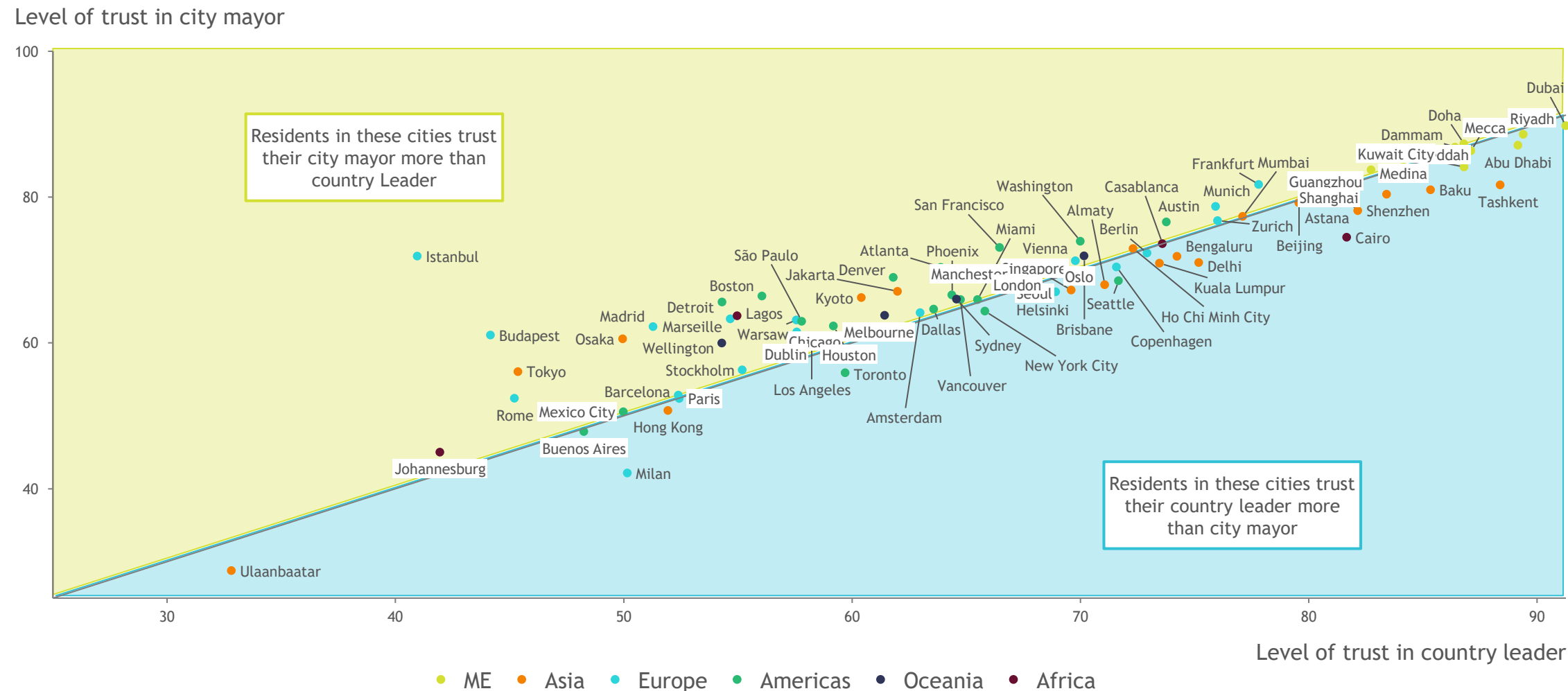


Note: The share of residents who trust the city mayor and the share of residents who trust the country leader are based on the Cities of Choice Survey. Residents who provided positive responses are counted as trusting.

Drivers behind higher trust in city leadership

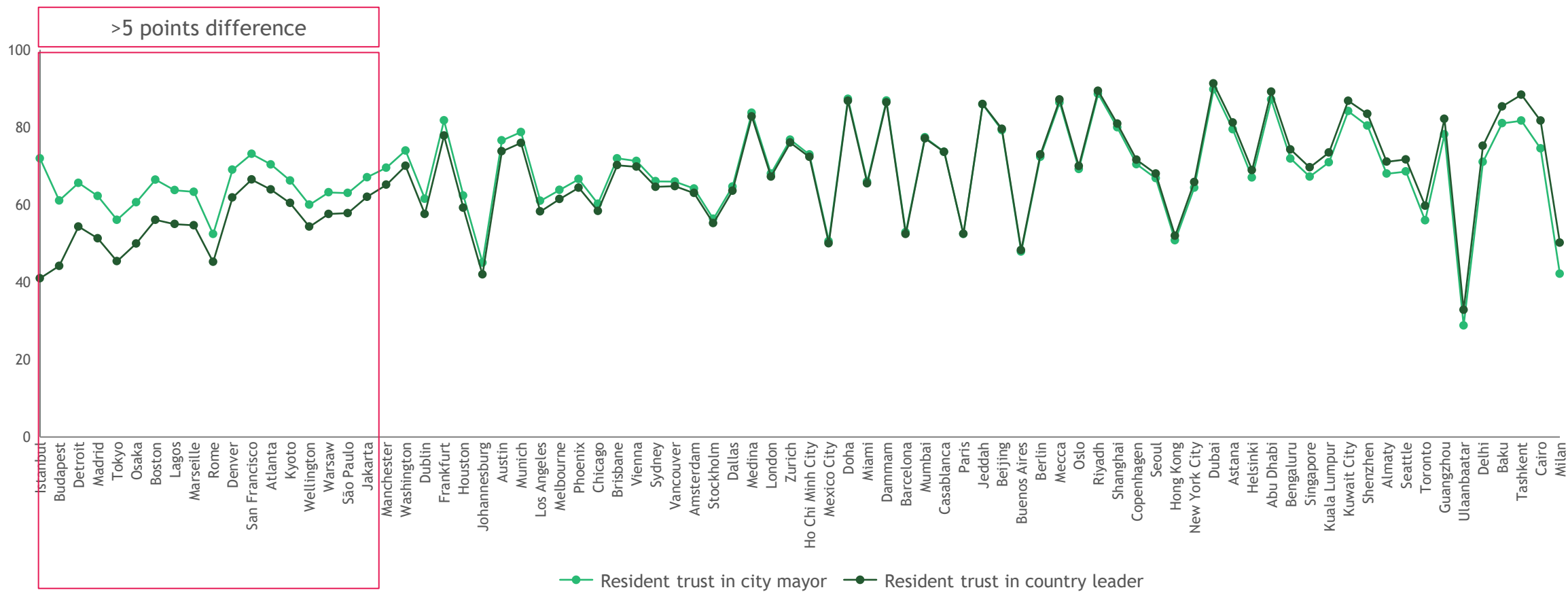
-  **Istanbul**
Istanbul's **local government is responsive and visible in addressing daily urban issues** (transport, infrastructure, etc.), while national government is perceived as distant
-  **Budapest**
Municipal leaders **remain close to residents' urban realities and service delivery**, whereas the **national government faces fiscal and political challenges** that weaken overall trust
-  **Japanese cities**
Local governments focus on improving public services, livability, and city branding, making them **more relevant to daily life**; national institutions, though stable, feel **less immediately connected to citizens**
-  **Lagos**
Widespread distrust in national institutions, politics, and governance elevates relative confidence in city leadership
-  **Madrid**
While **Spain's governance is rather decentralized**, Madrid has ongoing **citizen engagement platforms like Decide Madrid** that encourages engagement and reinforces trust in local authority

Across global cities, trust in city mayors tends to move in line with trust in national leaders, although ME and Asian cities exhibit higher overall trust



Residents in Istanbul, Budapest, and Detroit trust their city mayor significantly more than their country leader

Japanese cities and a number of US cities also demonstrate stronger trust in city mayor compared with country leader



Note: Resident trust in city mayor and resident trust in country leader are measured through Cities of Choice Survey. The results are converted to a score (0-100), where 100 indicates the highest level of trust.

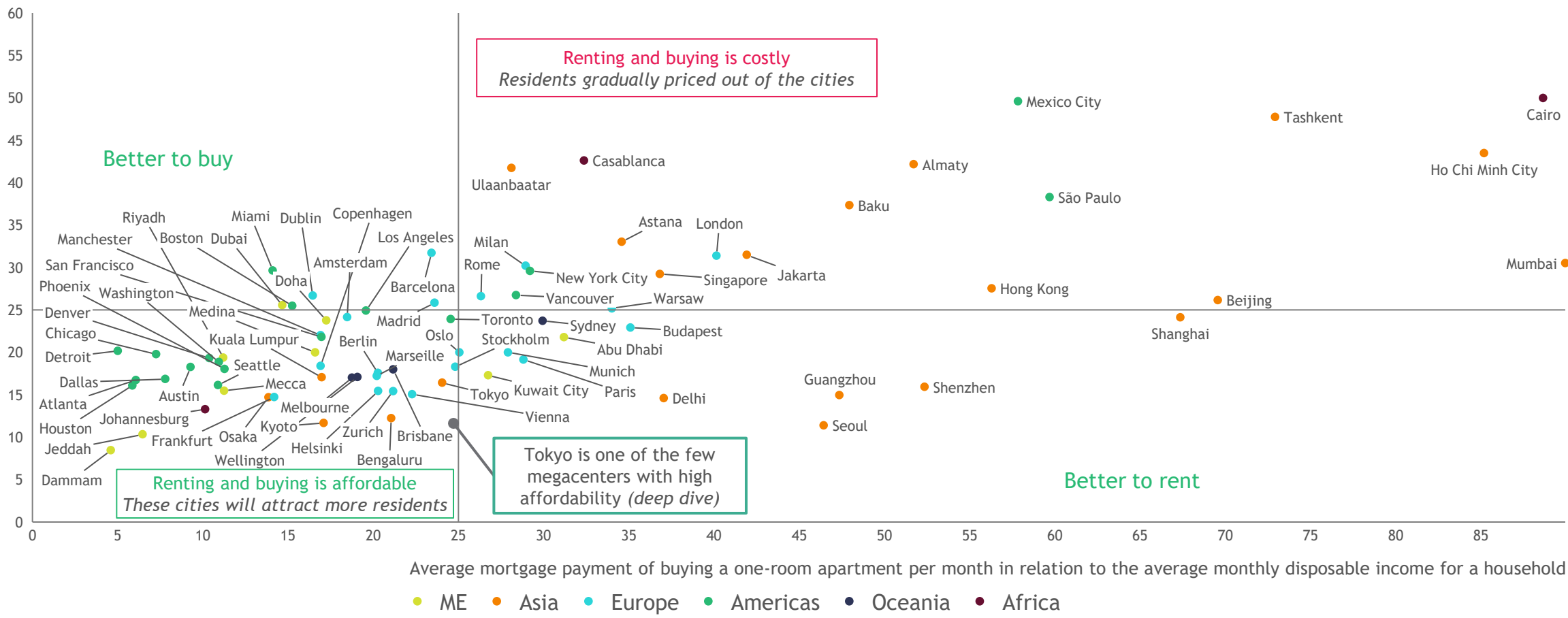
Theme 7

Housing affordability

Housing markets have become deeply unaffordable, largely because supply has not kept up with demand

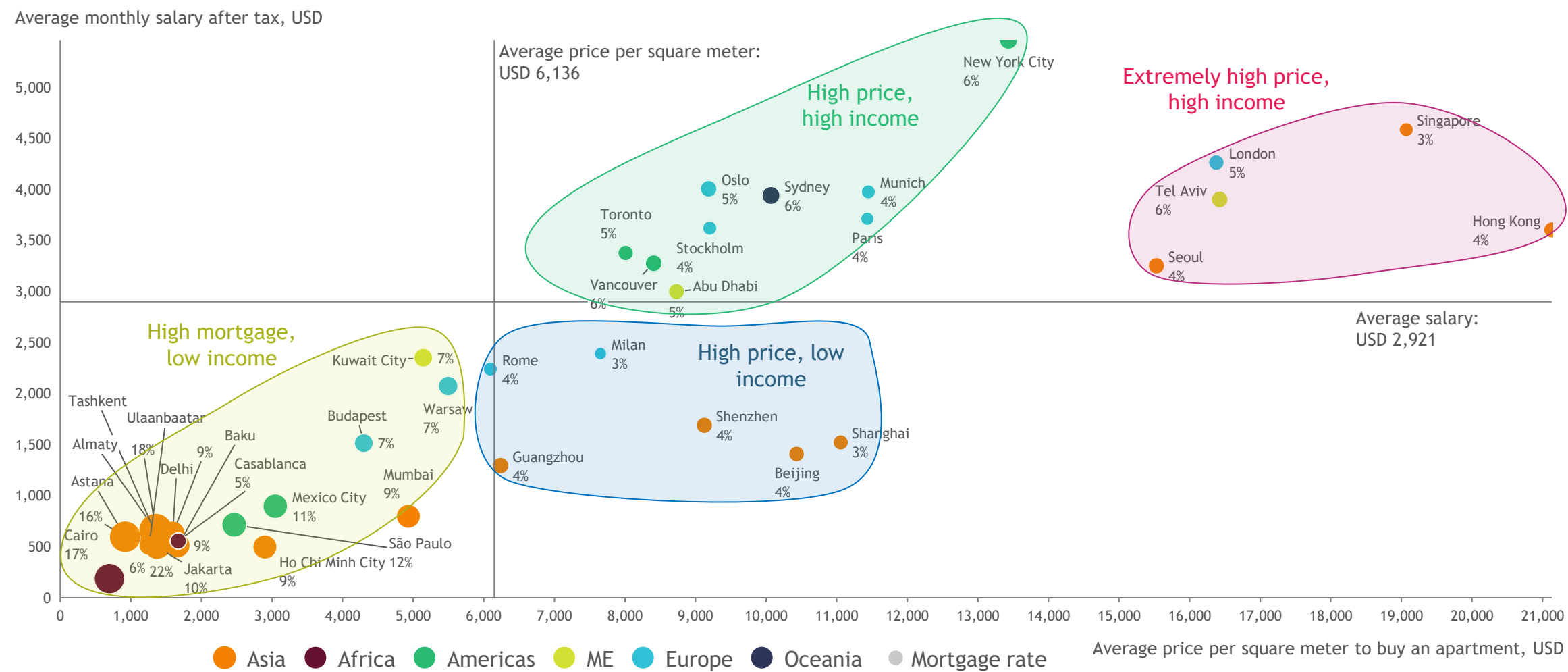
Renting is more affordable in many major Asian cities, while Middle Eastern and many American cities show higher overall housing affordability

The average cost of renting a one-room apartment in relation to the average monthly disposable income for a household



Note: One-room apartment assumed at 40 square meters; monthly disposable income proxied as 2x average after-tax salary. Source: Numbeo, BCG analysis.

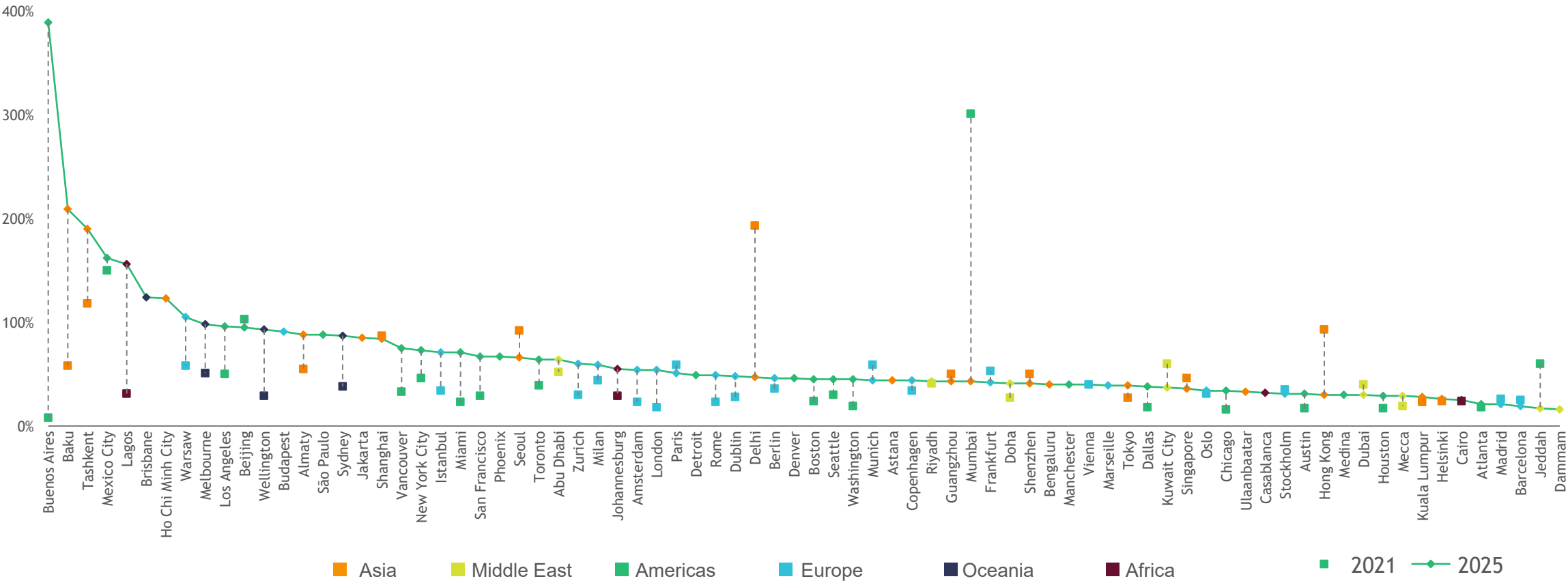
For the 36 cities with mortgages above 25% of salary, we classified them into four groups based on salary, home prices, and mortgage rates



Note: The average price per square meter and average salary are calculated using our data set of 80 cities. Source: Numbeo, BCG analysis.

The average share of mortgage payments relative to household disposable income increased from 48% in 2021 to 64% in 2025

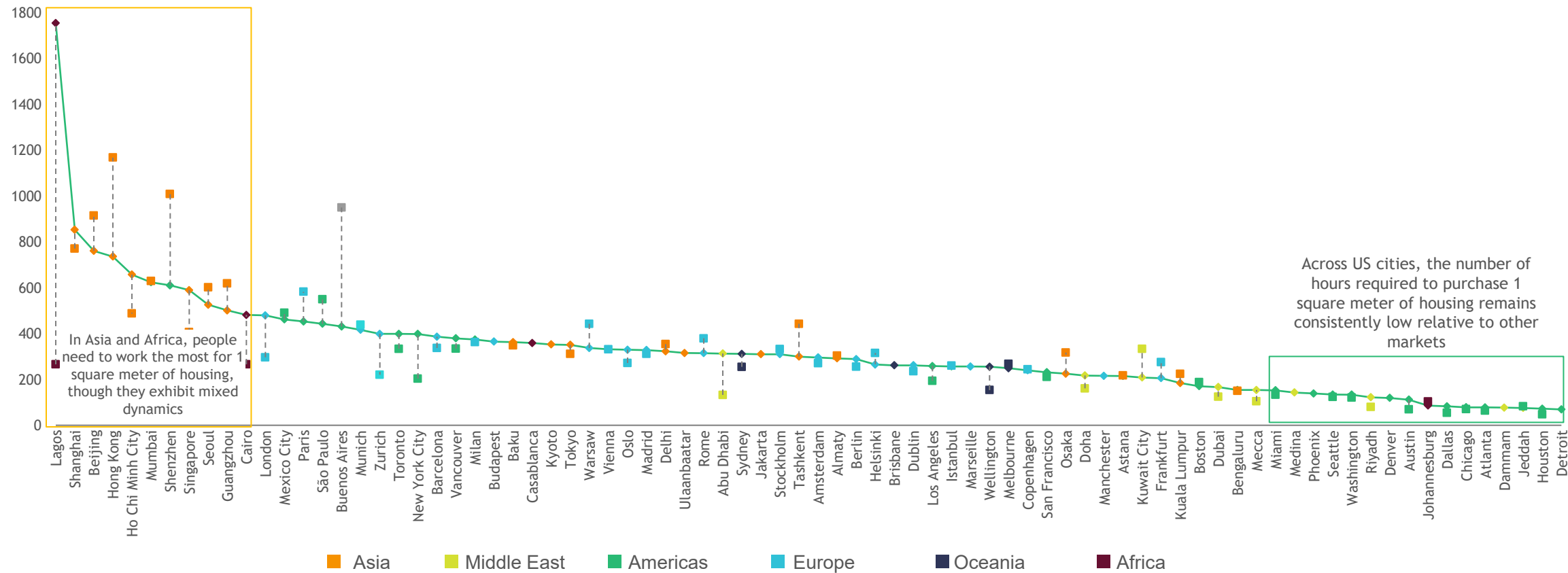
Average mortgage payment relative to average monthly household disposable income¹



1. Monthly mortgage payment estimated using average price per square meter, assumed square meter per person and average household size, prevailing mortgage rate, 20% down payment, and a 20-year mortgage term. The resulting monthly payment is divided by average monthly household disposable income to derive the percentage. Source: Numbeo, BCG analysis.

The average number of hours that a person needs to work to purchase 1 square meter of housing increased from 326 hours in 2021 to 342 hours in 2025

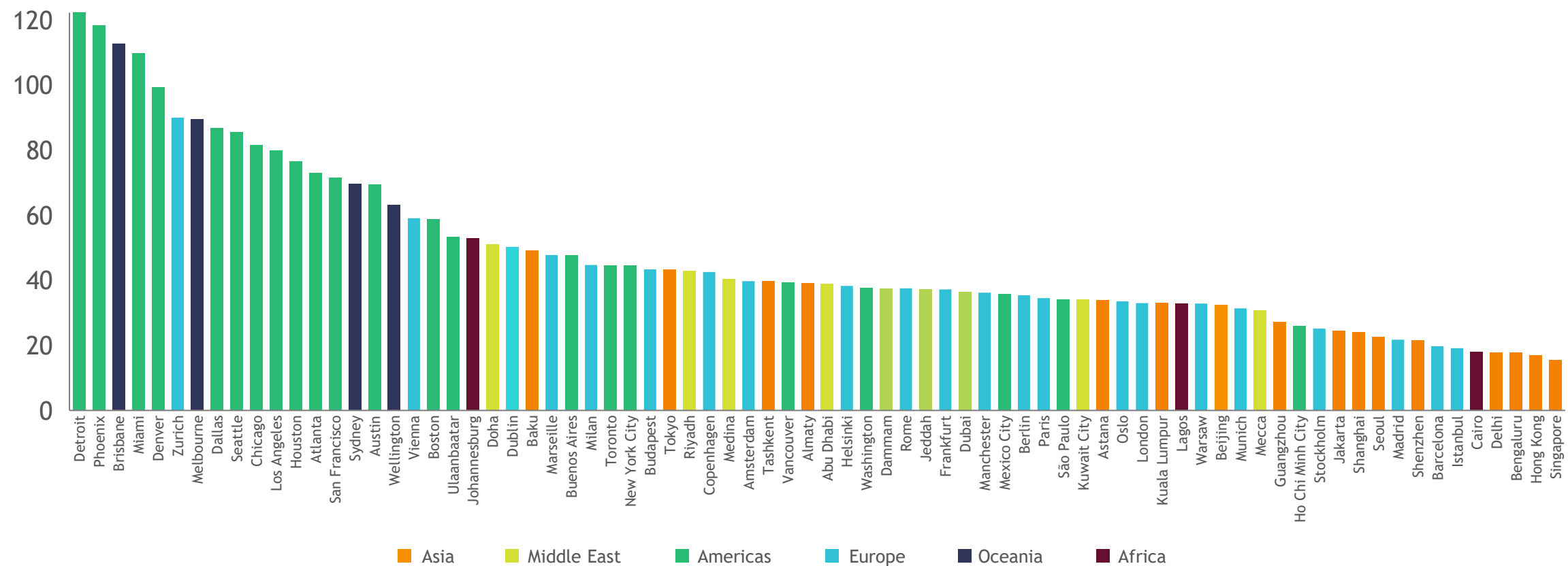
The number of hours that a person needs to work to purchase of 1 square meter of housing¹



1. Indicator calculated by dividing the average price per square meter of housing by the implied hourly wage, derived from average monthly income assuming eight working hours per day and 21 working days per month.
Source: Numbeo, BCG calculation.

Cities in North America and Oceania exhibit the highest average square meter of housing per person, whereas Asian cities consistently rank lower

Average square meter of housing per person

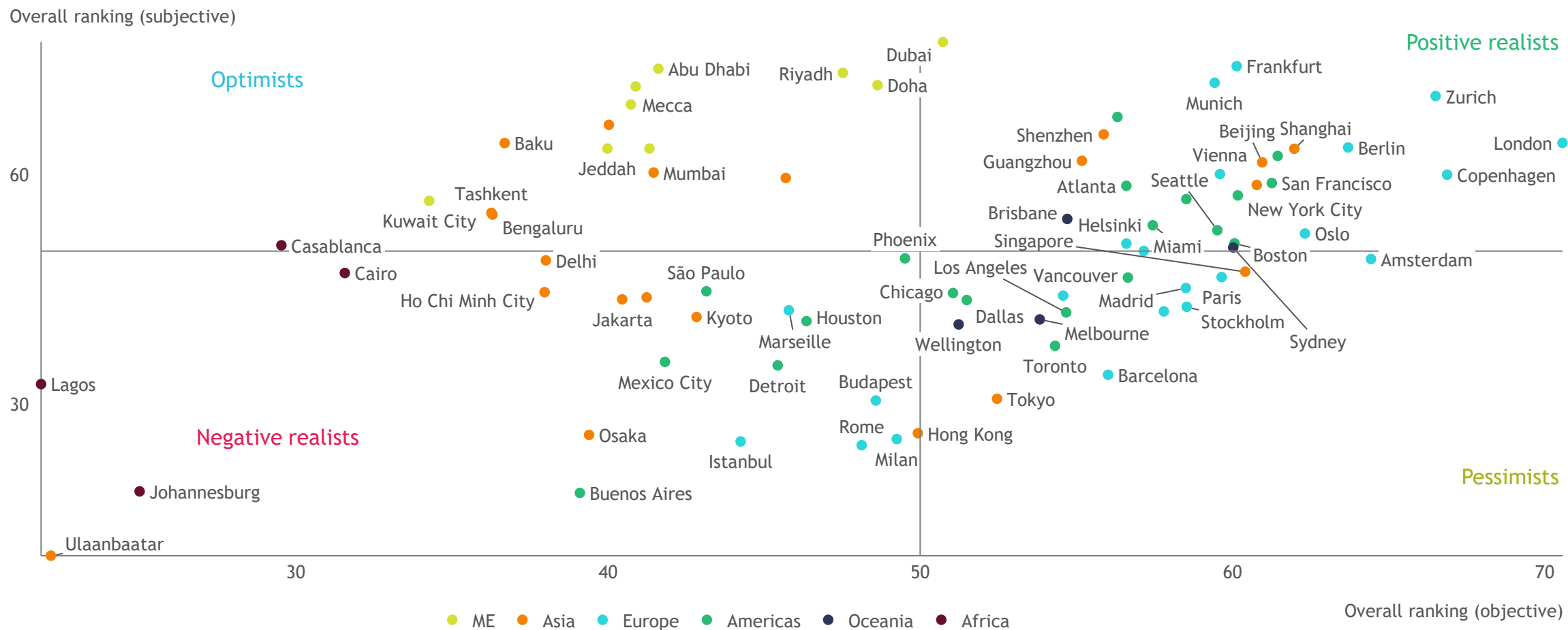


Theme 8

Subjective and objective in cities

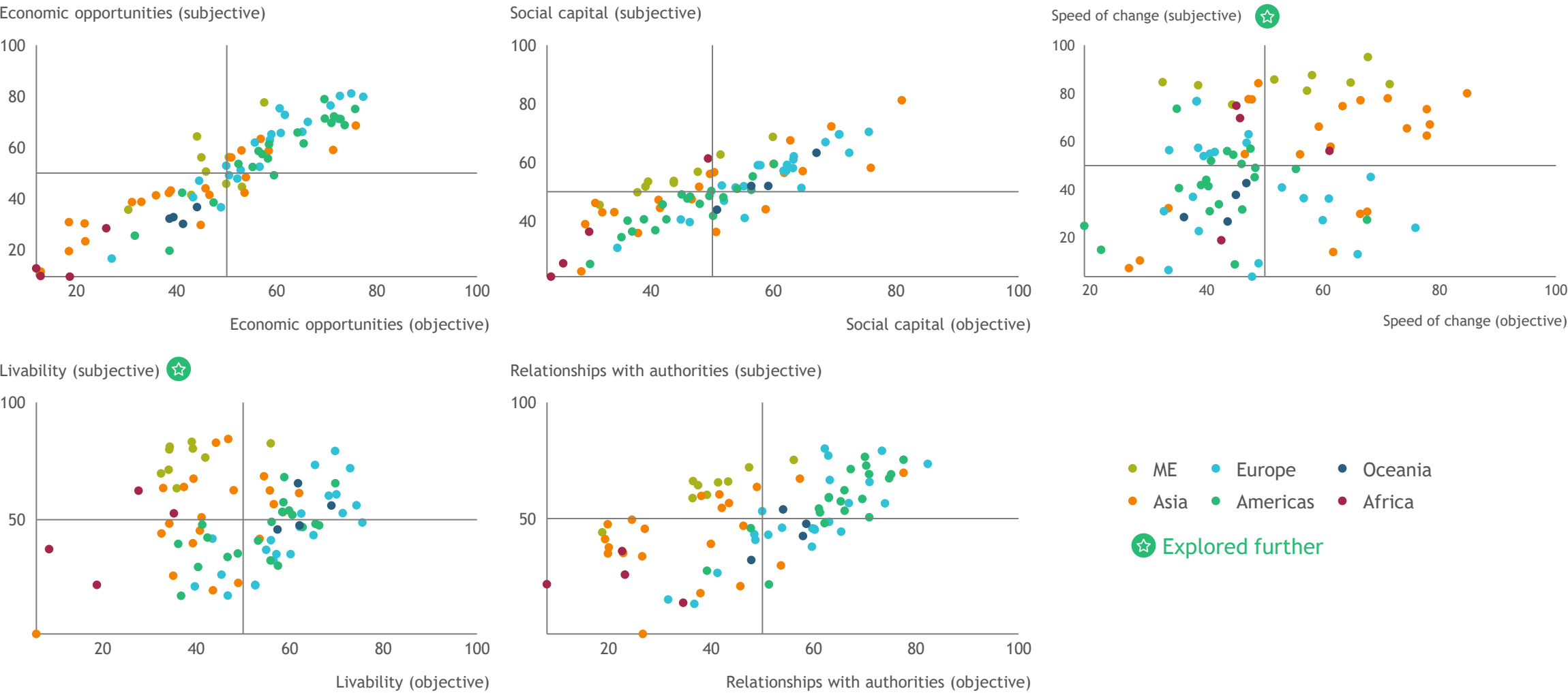
Objective reality in cities and subjective perceptions of residents do not always match

Overall ranking | Middle East and part of Asia is more optimistic, while parts of Europe is more pessimistic across the overall ranking

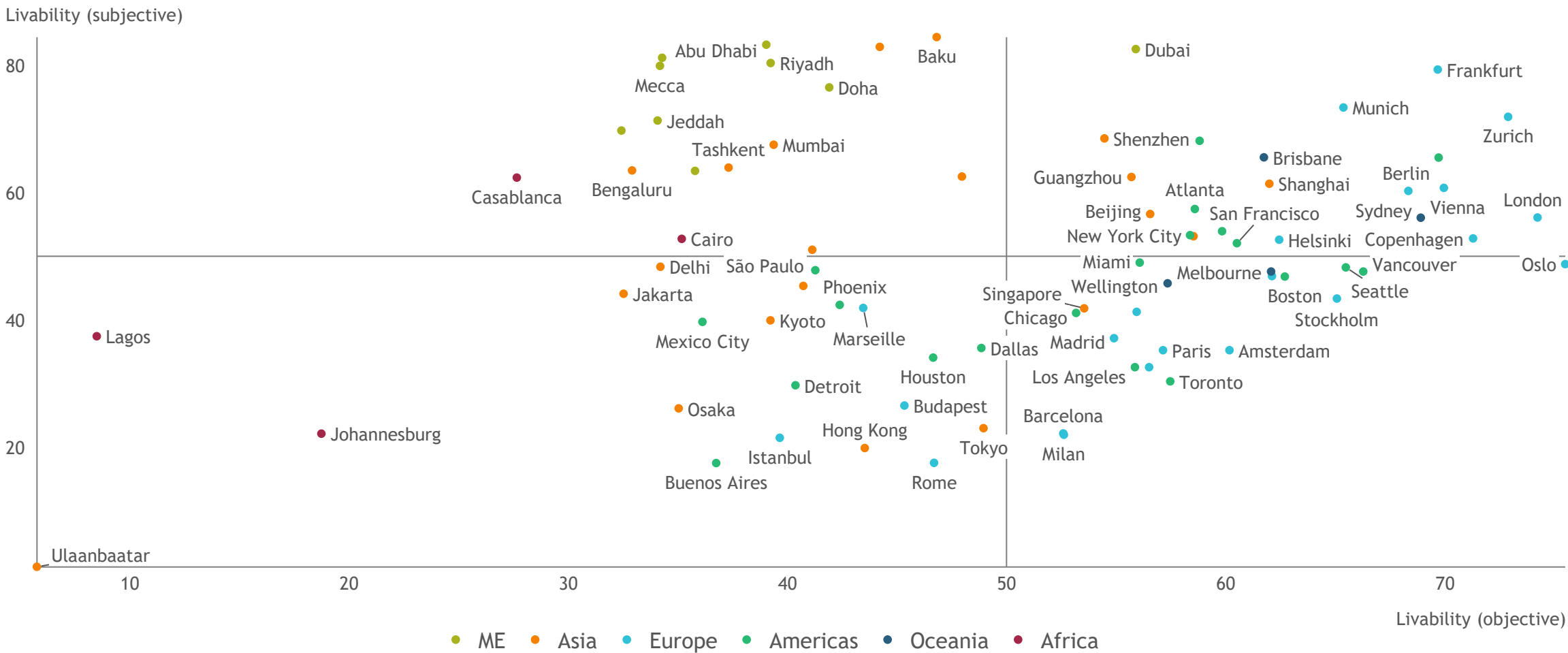


Note: Objective-data-based indicators or self-reported behavioral survey questions; subjective-opinion-based survey questions.

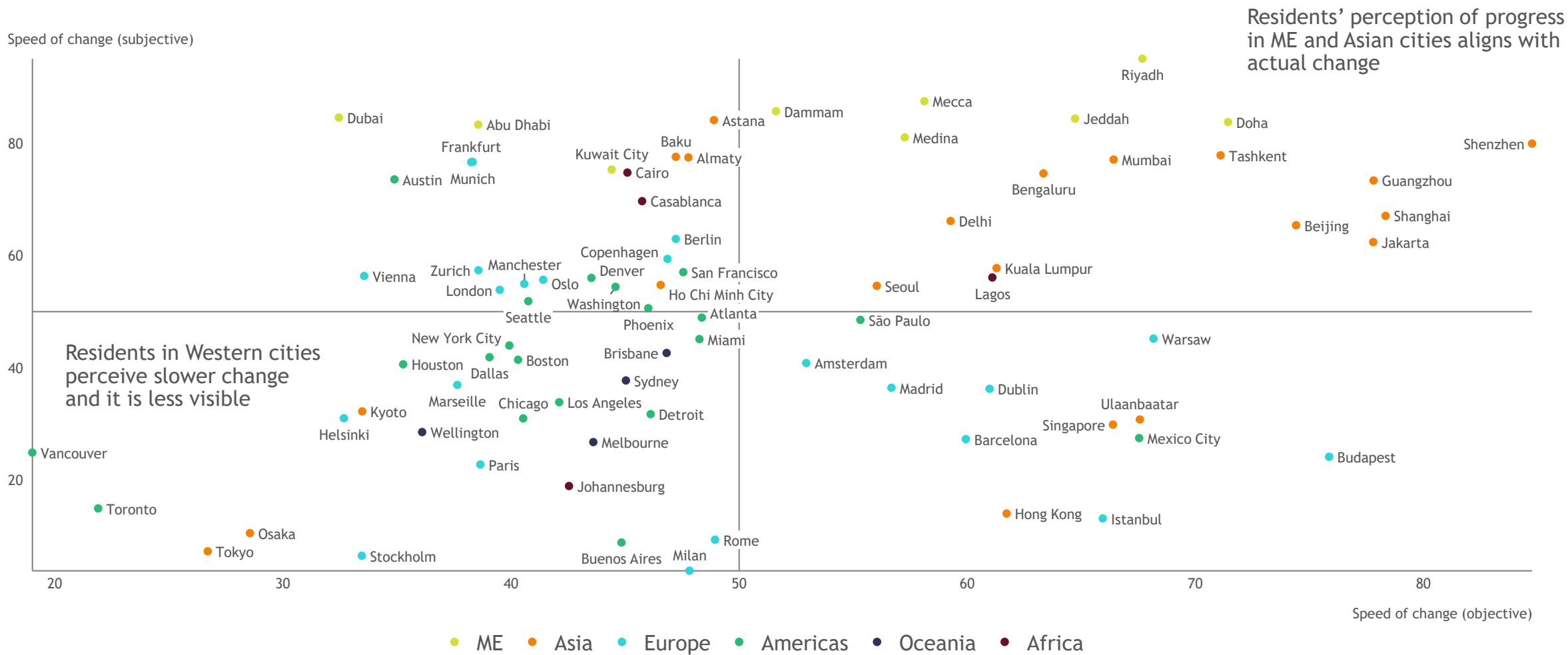
Dimensions | Overall sentiment differs from the objective reality mainly in livability and speed of change



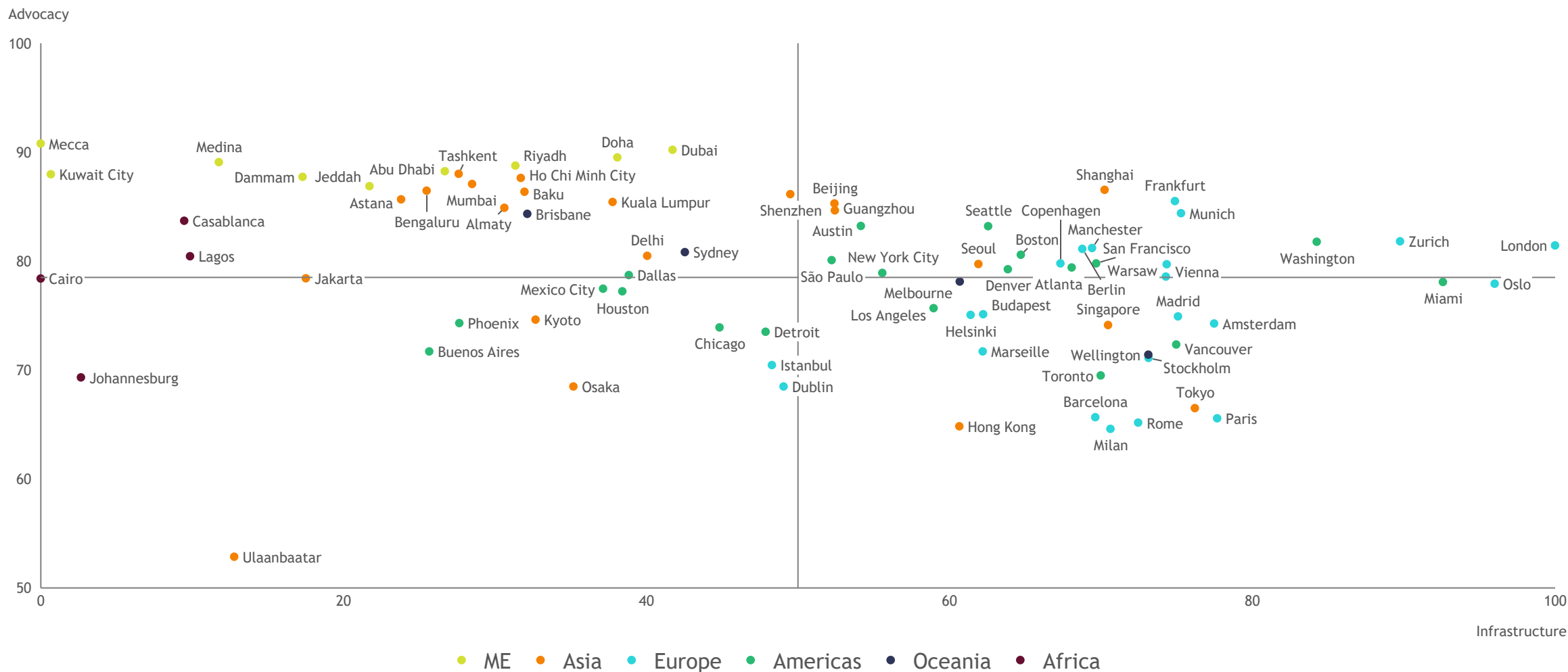
Livability | Residents are generally satisfied in the Middle East and parts of Asia, although objective metrics perform lower



Speed of change | Perceived vs. actual speed of change diverges by region—ME and Asian cities show aligned momentum



Infrastructure and advocacy | Developed cities excel in infrastructure but not pride, while emerging cities inspire pride despite weaker systems

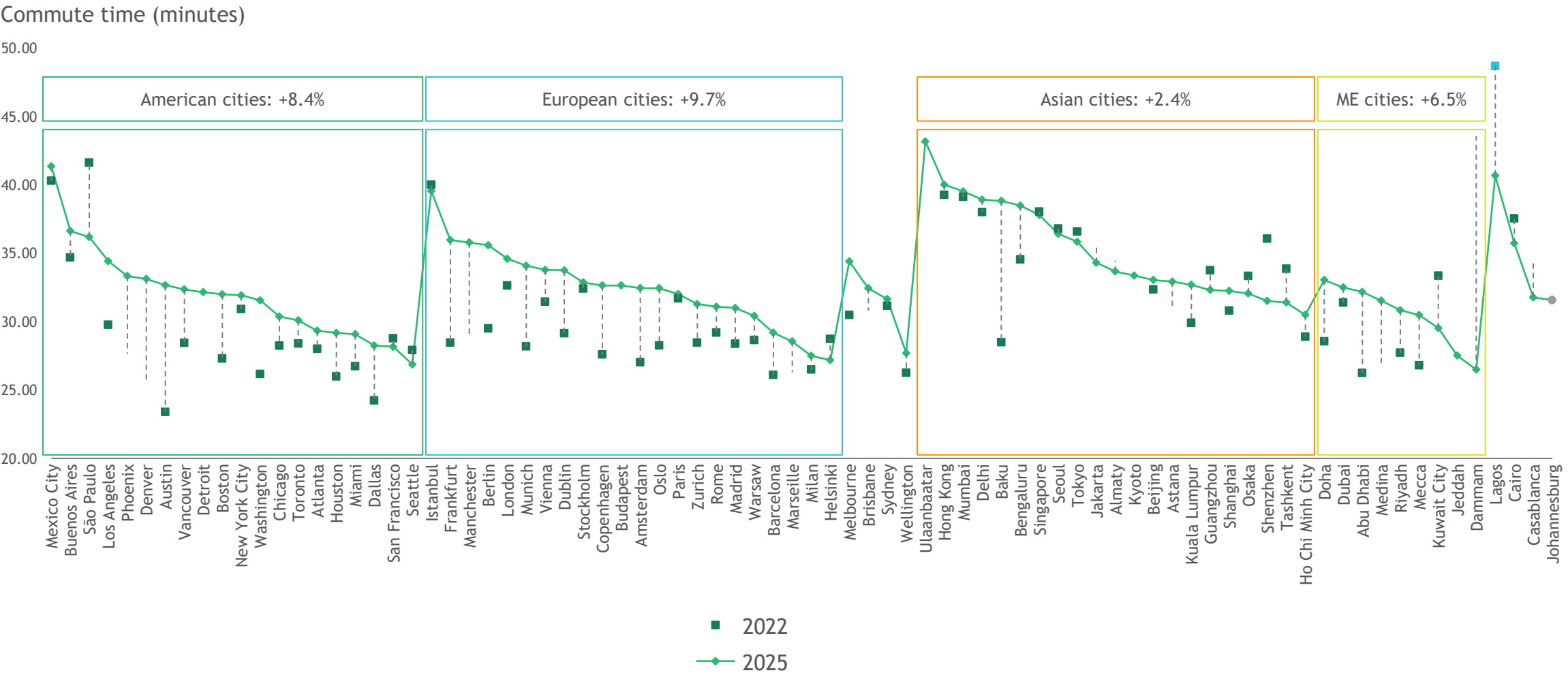


Theme 9

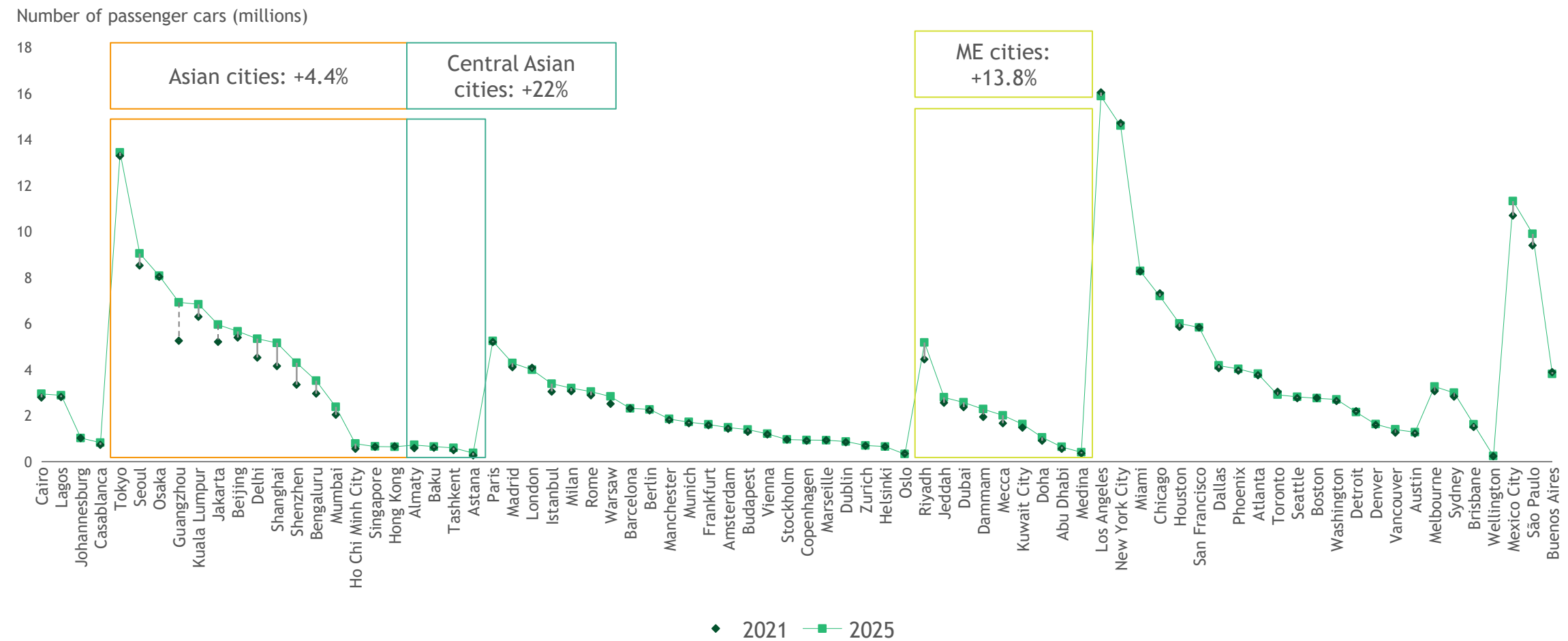
Congestion and commuting time

Congestion and long commute times are rising steadily in large cities

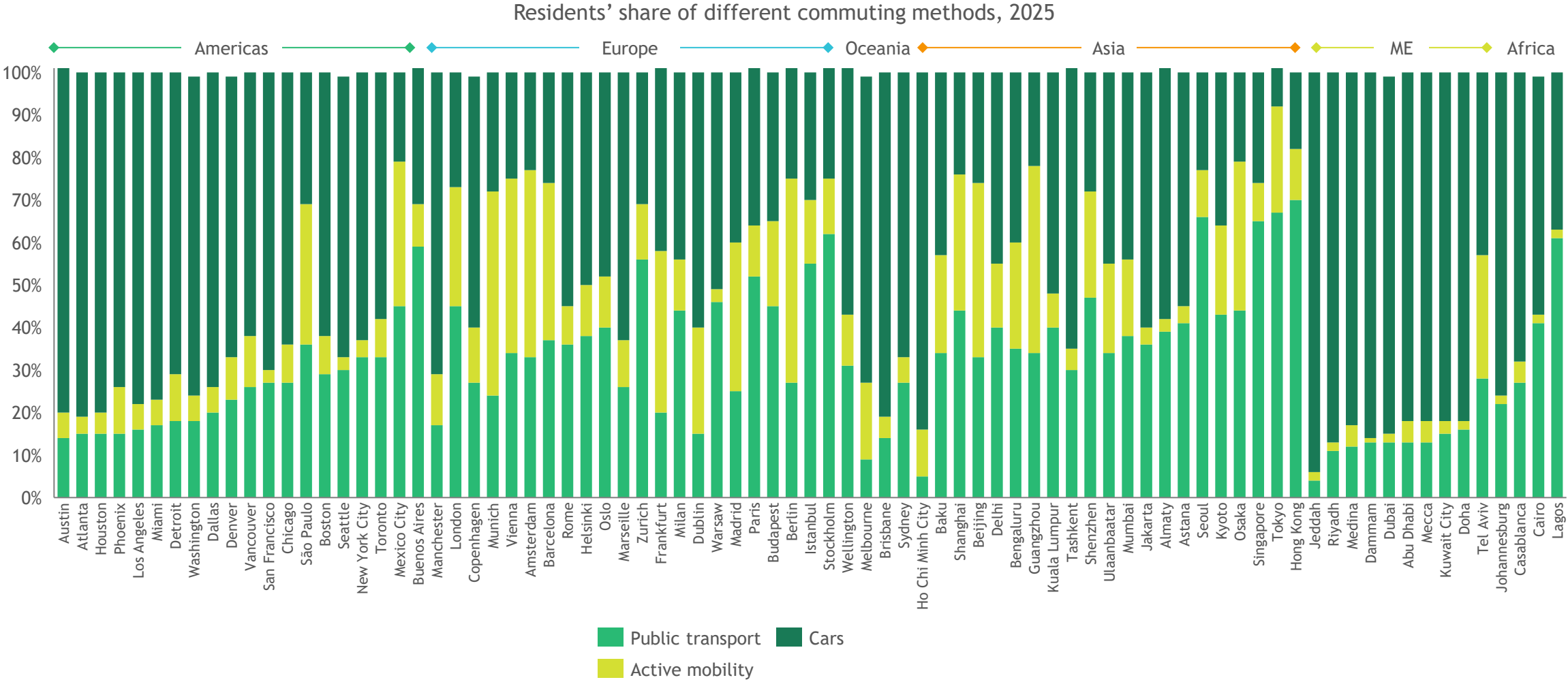
Average commute time has risen by 6% since the last edition, possibly because of slower commuting speeds on public transport and more cars coming to cities



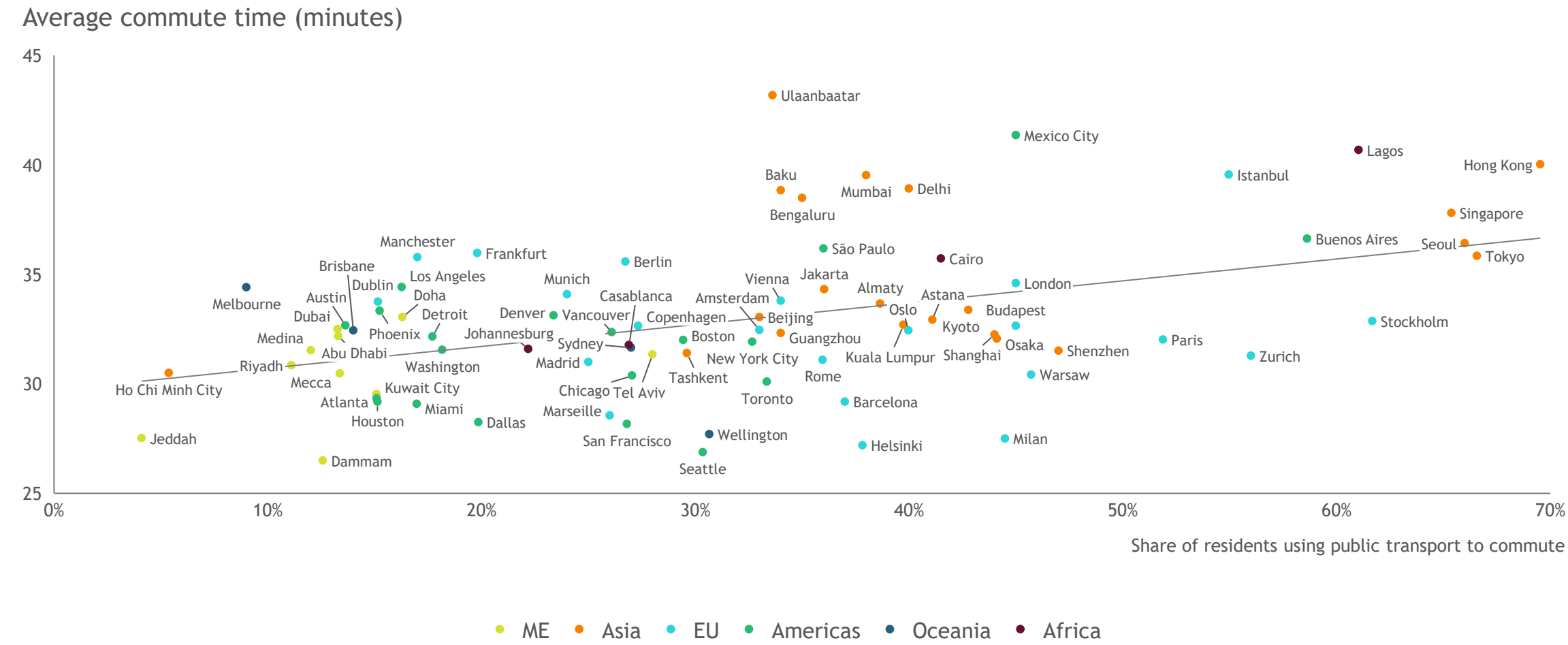
The number of cars has increased by 7.5%, on average, since 2021, driven by Asian and ME cities, with Central Asian cities showing the biggest growth of 22%



Residents of Middle Eastern and American cities still rely primarily on private cars for commuting



Residents' usage of public transport correlates with the increased time to commute



Theme 10

The connected city

The 15-minute city index is emerging as a key driver of urban livability and competitiveness

Our connected-city index was inspired by the 15-minute city concept, which was reinterpreted by various other cities using different approaches

20-minute city	 ☆ Dubai  ☆ Singapore	“Within the distance of a 15-minute walk or bike ride, people should be able to live the essence of what constitutes the urban experience.” — Carlos Moreno, advisor to Paris’s 15-minute city plan
15-minute city	 • Paris	“The 20-minute neighborhood concept is all about creating walkable, healthy, cohesive, sustainable communities with strong local economies.” — Richard Wynne (former Minister for Planning and Housing, Australia)
10-minute city	 ☆ Melbourne	“So our idea is you need to be able to access everything within five minutes, walk, get out of your front door, go walk around the corner and you find everything.” — Expert interview
5-minute city	 • Vienna	
1-minute city	 ☆ Stockholm	

Key takeaways

- Concept typically applied at the neighborhood level
- Proximity (e.g., five minutes) to essential services is defined by walking distance
- Accessibility to services are enhanced by micromobility (e.g., bikes)

☆ Planning or early implementation stage

Cities that embrace the 15-minute city have already achieved measurable improvements in livability

Outcomes		Global examples	
	Reduced car use and traffic	 Paris halved car mode share to ~6% of trips; traffic volumes fell ~50% in 20 years	 Vienna reduced car trips to ~25% of journeys, with a target of 20% by 2025
	Growth in sustainable travel	 Paris now records ~1 million bike trips daily (+166% since 2018)	 Vienna: 75% of trips made by sustainable modes (public transit, walking, cycling)
	Reclaimed public space	 Paris converted 3.3 kilometers of Seine expressway into a car-free park; 200+ school streets pedestrianized	
	Cleaner environment	 Paris air pollution improved: NO ₂ declined 50%, PM _{2.5} declined 55% (2005-2024)	
	Resident satisfaction	 97% of Viennese express satisfaction with city life; transit satisfaction among the highest in Europe	

We employed a three-layer approach to evaluate the connected-city index

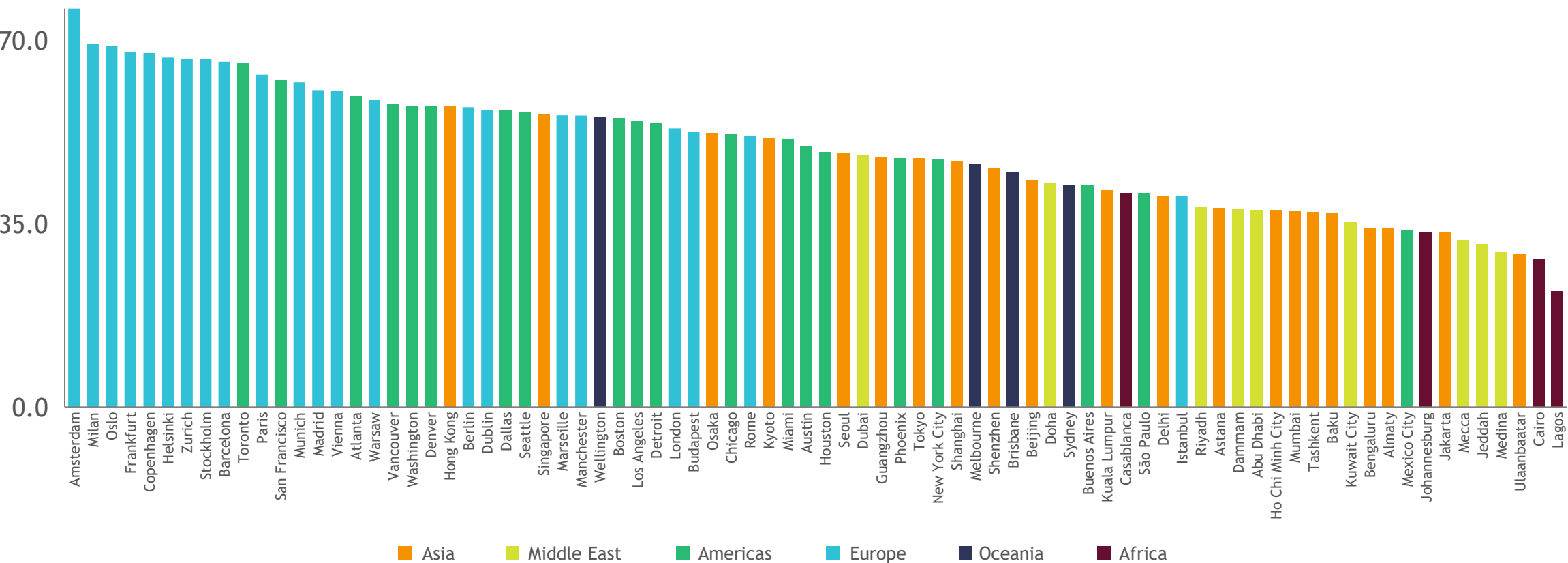
Layer 1 - Availability of assets		Layer 2 - Accessibility	
	Are the essential services and amenities dense to create a basis for 15-minute city? We assessed the number of services and amenities present in the city, grouped by frequency of use		How easily can residents reach and use these amenities? Beyond presence, we evaluated how easily residents can reach and use these assets
	Weight 40%		Weight 40%
50%	Daily needs (e.g., groceries)	95%	Accessibility and walkability Accounting for elements such as micromobility, convenient access to work
25%	Weekly needs (e.g., retail space)	5%	Comfort climate Accounting for climate conditions that shape outdoor accessibility
25%	Less frequent needs (e.g., hospitals)		
Layer 3 - Underlying conditions			
	Does the land use support connectivity? Share of economic land use		
	Weight 20%		

The connected-city indicators' classification and weighting

Layer 1	Group	Indicator - 40%		Layer 2	Group	Indicator - 40%	
 Availability of asset	Group 1 (daily) 50%	1	Number of children's playgrounds per 100,000 population	 Accessibility	Walkability 95%	14	Average time (minutes) lost in traffic jams per resident
	Group 2 (weekly) 25%	2	Number restaurants per 100,000 population			15	Time to commute from home to place of work or study (survey)
		3	Number of fitness centers and swimming pools per 100,000 population			16	Share of population that has convenient access to public transport
		4	Number of coworking spaces per 100,000 population			17	Presence of infrastructure for velo transport
		5	Density of metro stations			18	Frequency of micromobility trips per person
		6	Square meters of retail space per 100,000 population			19	Share of residents using bicycle, e-bike, scooter, skateboard for commuting from home to work or study
	Group 3 (less frequently than weekly) 25%	7	Number of points of sale per 100,000 population			20	Share of residents walking for commuting from home to work or study
		8	Number of local farmers' markets with the opportunity to buy fresh food, per 100,000 population			21	Share of population living within convenient walking distance to open public space
		9	Number of museums per 100,000 population		Comfort climate 5%	22	Walkability score
		10	Number of theaters per 100,000 population			23	Number of months with a comfortable daytime temperature
		11	Number of cinemas per 100,000 population				
		12	Number of libraries per 100,000 population				
		13	Number of hospitals per 100,000 population				
Layer 3 20%	24 Economic land use score						

Amsterdam ranks top among 80 cities, whereas Ulaanbaatar, Cairo, and Lagos are lagging behind

Connected-city subranking score (0-100)



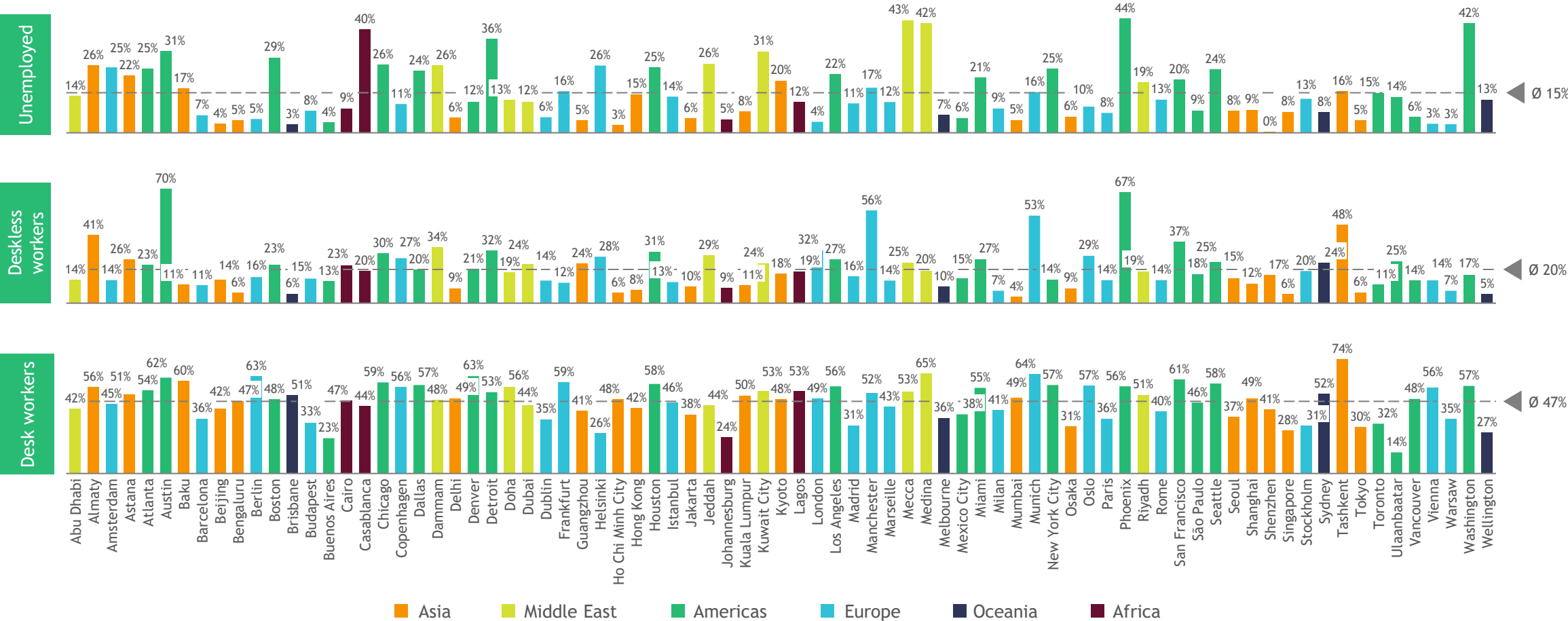
Theme 11

Downtowns

Downtowns are strained since the pandemic because of remote and hybrid working, with lower footfall and retail spending

Desk workers drive downtown vitality and economic activity, visiting leisure spots more often (47%) than deskless workers (20%) or the unemployed (15%)

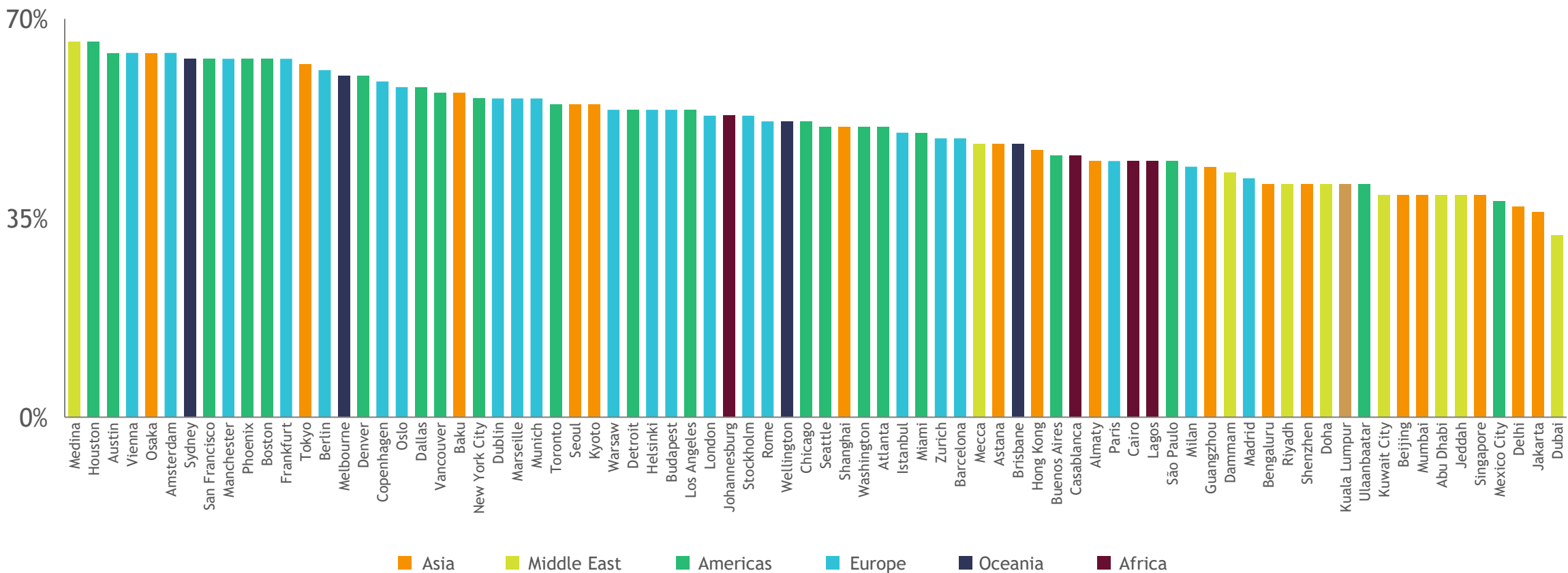
Respondents visiting leisure locations at least a few times per weak by employment category (%)



Note: Survey question, “How frequently do you visit the following social and leisure locations within your city: restaurants, markets, bars, entertainment?”
Sample: All respondents, n=300/city.

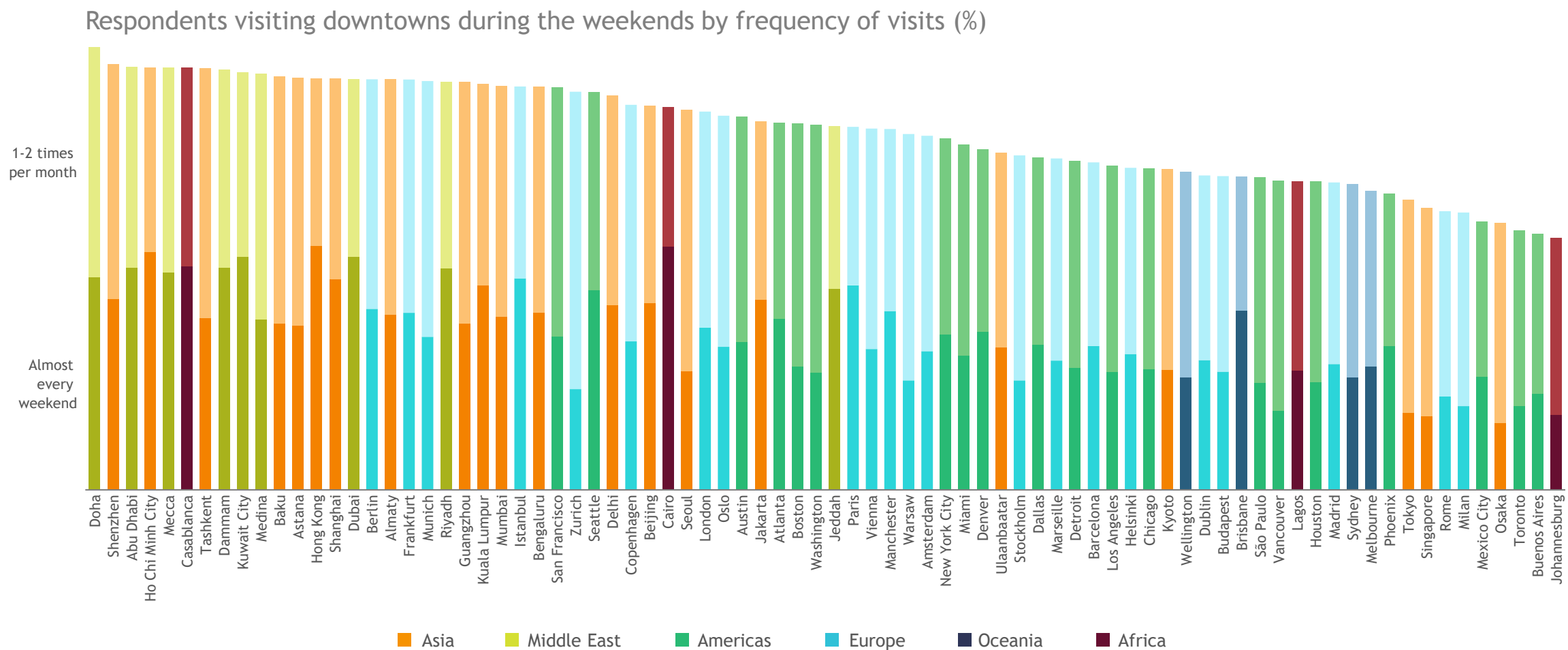
Downtowns in Europe and North America continue to see a post-COVID outflow of office workers, with hybrid or home-based work exceeding 40% in major cities

People who work or study fully or partially from home (%)



Note: Survey question, “How often do you work/study in location outside of your home?” Sample: Employed respondents, entrepreneurs, and students, n=200-300/city.

European and North American downtowns are also less frequented for weekend entertainment compared with those in the Middle East and Asia



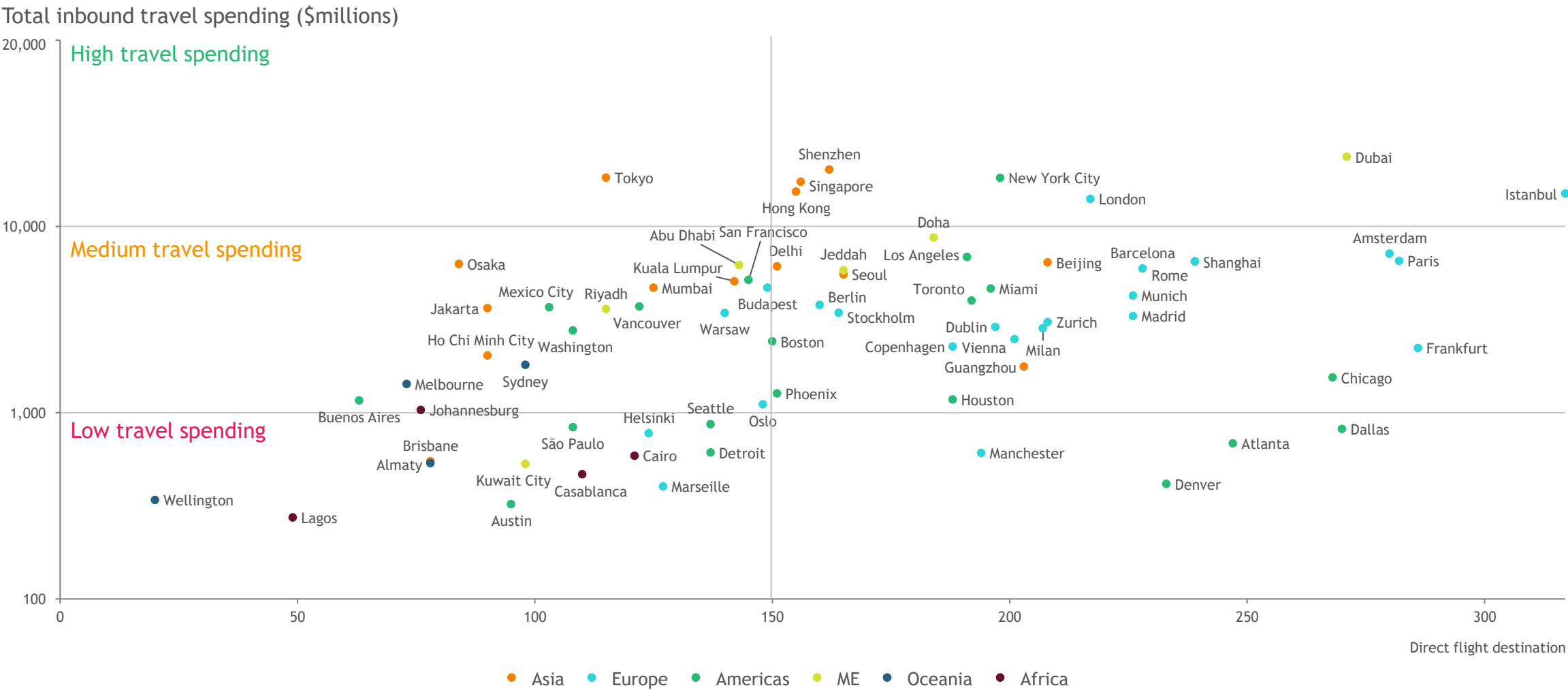
Note: Survey question, “How often do you visit a downtown/city center on weekends?” Sample: All respondents, n=300/city.

Theme 12

Tourism and business leisure

Cities are becoming more popular destinations for tourists, with business travelers, for example, increasingly extending work trips for leisure, boosting footfall in well-connected cities

Expansive flight connectivity amplifies a city's travel economy, with global hubs such as Dubai and Istanbul far outperforming peers



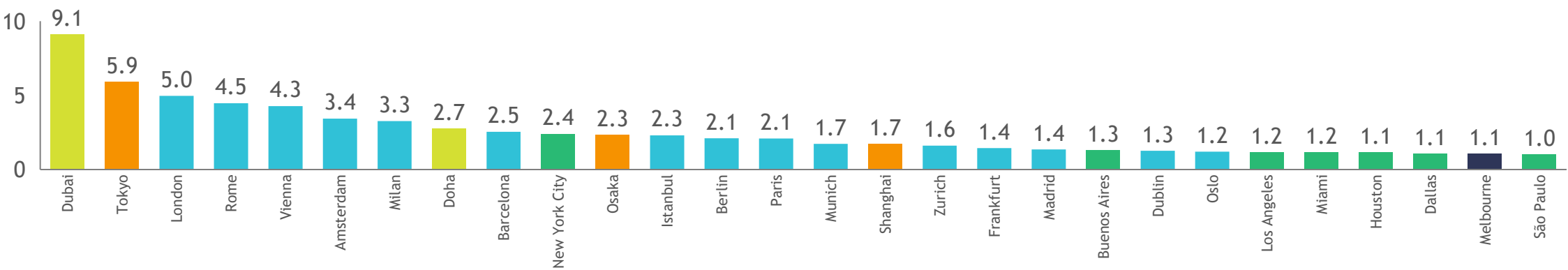
BCG's recent report, *Traveler of the Future*,¹ provides insights on urban tourism

- **Cities are in the top share of travel**, with 15%-20% of all trips booked during the last 12 months (vs. nature at 12%-24%)
- A new trend important for cities emerges—**B-leisure tourism**—a combination of business and leisure; at least one combined trip taken by 35% of UK travelers, 85% of Chinese travelers, 87% of Saudi travelers
- This means that business travelers more and more combine business trips with leisure, **extending their business trips to experience the cities**
- This provides a great opportunity for cities to **expand their share of economy related to tourism**
- We have modeled the **conversion of business travelers into leisure visitors** for a sample of *Cities of Choice* participants

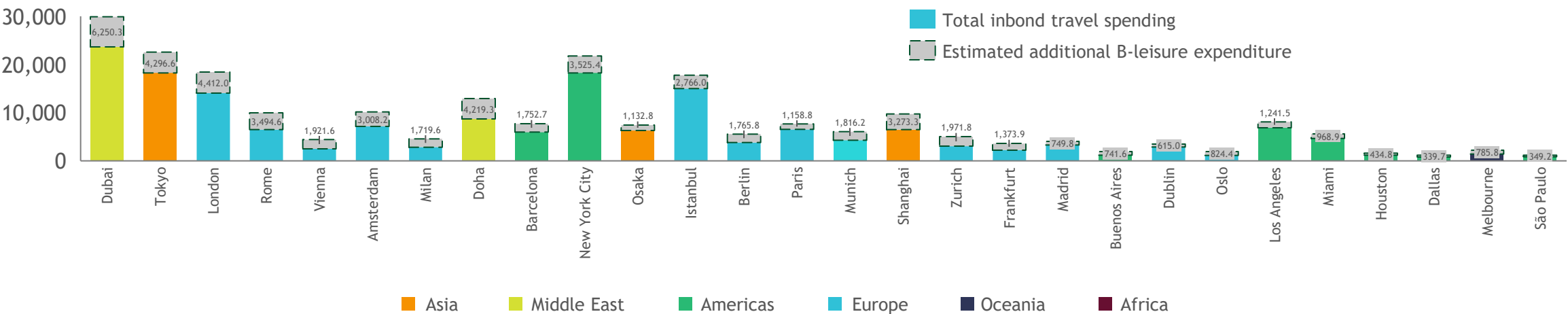


Encouraging business travelers to extend their stay for leisure could unlock substantial additional inbound travel revenue

Annual international overnight business visits, 2023 (millions)



Estimated annual total inbound travel expenditure with 100% business-leisure conversion¹ (\$millions)



1. Estimated as average spending per leisure visit times the number of overnight business trips.
Source: Tourist Economy, BCG analysis.

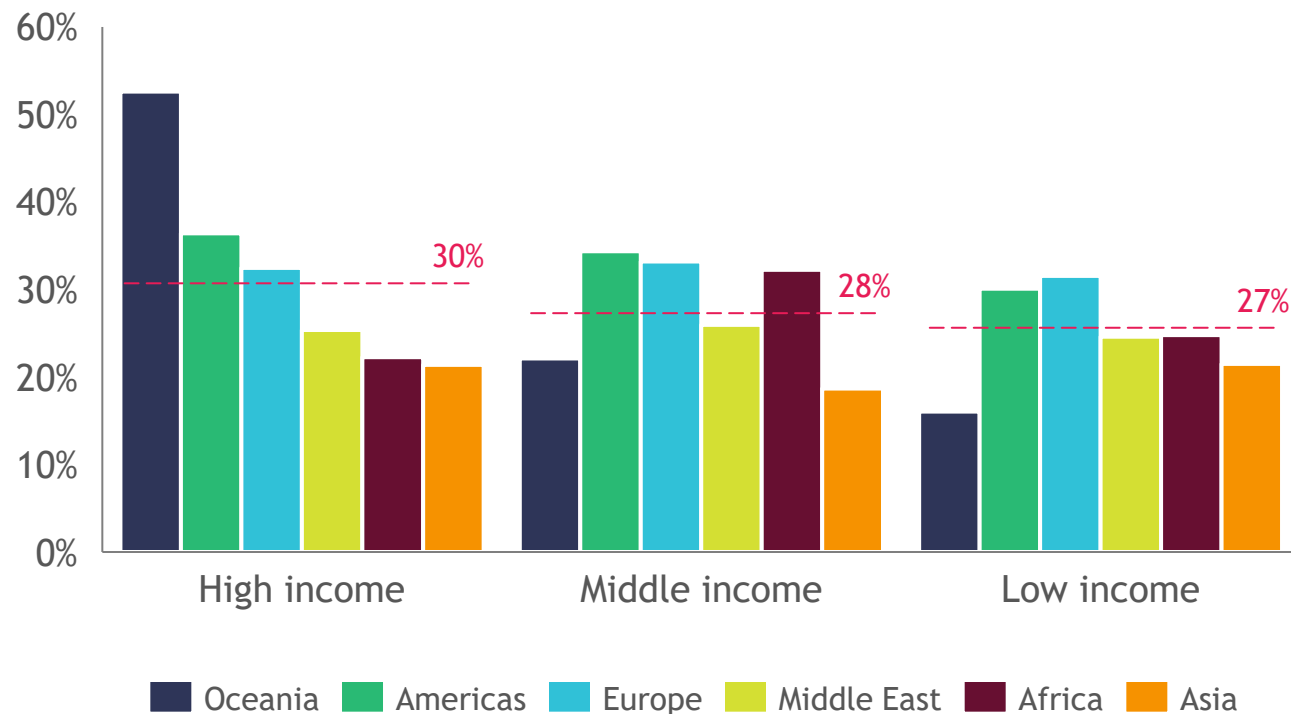
Theme 13

Affluent executives

Affluent executives are semipermanently on the move for enhanced economic opportunity and livability

The share of residents planning to move within two years is highest among high-income groups, indicating greater mobility intentions at higher income levels

Share of residents who plan to relocate within two years for different income levels¹



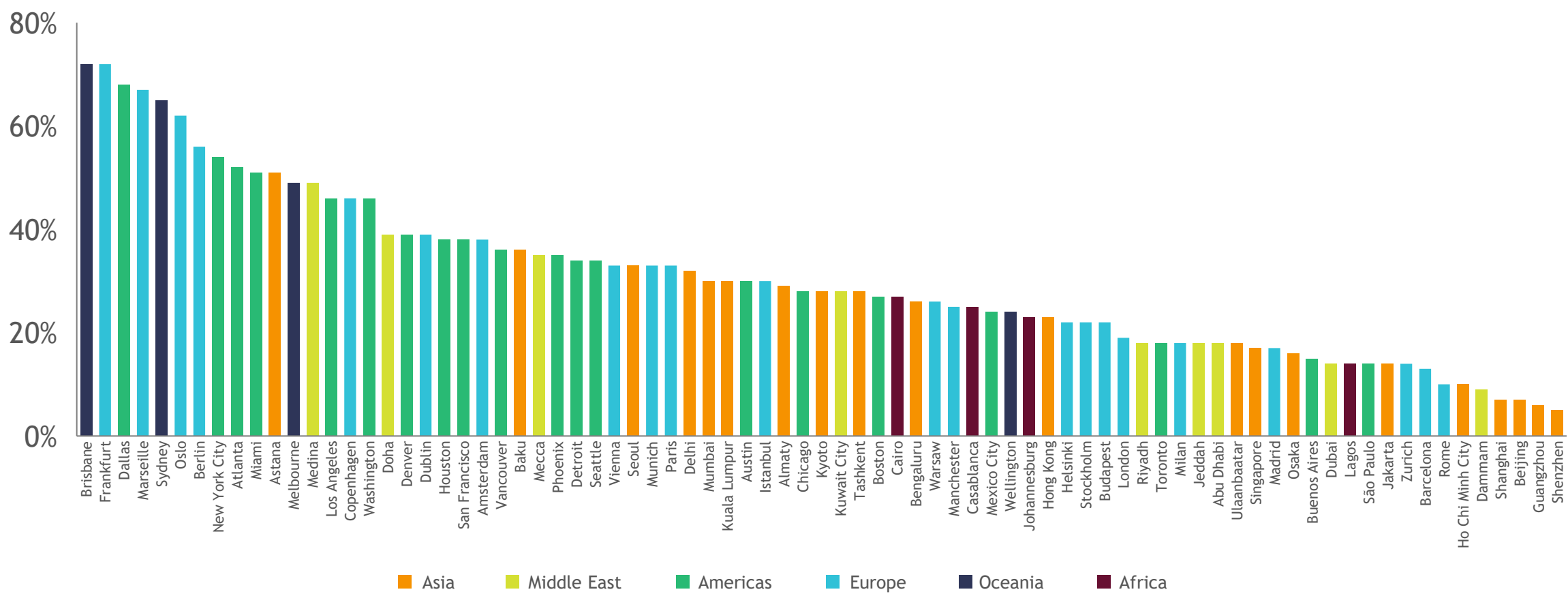
Key observations

- **Oceanian cities**, led by Brisbane and Sydney, show the **strongest relocation intent among high-income residents** (over 50%), contrasted by the lowest intent among low-income groups
- Across **Europe, Asia, and the Middle East**, relocation intent remains relatively stable across income brackets, suggesting that income has **limited influence** on residents' decisions to move
- The **Americas** follow the global pattern, with relocation intent decreasing alongside income levels (from 36% to 34% and to 30%), reflecting a balanced but income-sensitive trend
- In **Africa**, middle- and low-income residents express slightly higher intent to relocate, pointing to aspirations for upward mobility and improved opportunities as key motivators

1. Income classification is based on the Cities of Choice Survey. Respondents are grouped into five income tiers relative to their city's average income: groups 4 and 5 represent high income, group 3 represents middle income, and groups 1 and 2 represent low income.

Among high-income residents, cities such as Brisbane, Frankfurt, and Dallas show the strongest intent to relocate, while Chinese cities record the lowest

Share of high income population¹ that is planning to relocate within two years



1. Income classification is based on the Cities of Choice Survey. Respondents are grouped into five income tiers relative to their city's average income: groups 4 and 5 represent high income, group 3 represents middle income, and groups 1 and 2 represent low income.

A low-angle, upward-looking photograph of several modern skyscrapers with glass facades. The buildings are silhouetted against a dark, twilight sky. The perspective creates a sense of height and architectural scale. The glass reflects the ambient light, and some windows are illuminated from within.

Section 5

Appendix: ranking methodology

Weightings are defined individually for each of the 26 subdimensions for each city based on the residents' survey results



Indicators are standardized and combined through weighted aggregation to produce the final index score



Step 1: Normalize indicators and convert to score



Each indicator is standardized across 80 cities and transformed onto a 0-100 scale



The average city scores 50; top and bottom performers anchor the scale (100/0)

Cities who score the average gets 50

Bottom 2%-3% performing cities gets 0

Top 2%-3% performing cities gets 100



Step 2: Weight and aggregate



Indicators are combined into subdimensions using predefined weights



Subdimensions are weighted to calculate the final index score



Cities are clustered into five predefined groups and displayed as color-coded quintile rankings within each group

Cities of Choice 4.0 indicators (I/IV)

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Economic opportunities	Opportunities for work, career, and income	The ratio of employed to residents of a working age, %
		Unemployment rate, according to the ILO methodology, %
		Presence of city infrastructure for remote work, score 0-2
		Internet Speed, mbps
		Average yearly household income, price adjusted, USD per year
		Food expenses as a share of total expenses, %
		GDP PPP per employed, USD per year
		Number of international business conferences hosted annually
		Number of Fortune Global 500 company offices in the city
		Survey ¹ : Opportunities for professional self-realization, score
	Survey: Availability of attractive employment opportunities, score	
	Survey: Share of respondents working from home at least 2 days/week, %	
	Opportunities for business	Airport connectivity and passenger flow index
		Total early-stage Entrepreneurial Activity Rate, %
		Share of Service sector in the economy, %
		Number of startups per 100,000 population
		# of patents filed over last 3 years
		VC investment in 2024, million USD
Vacancy rate of retail space, %		
Survey: Perceived opportunities for starting a business, score		
Livability	Economic land use score	
	Equality of income	Gini coefficient
	Availability of personal loans	Average rate of retail loan, %
		Survey: Accessibility of commercial loans, score
	Cleanliness and hygiene	Number of public toilets available per 100,000 population
		Share of houses equipped with water supply, %
Survey: Satisfaction with garbage collection and disposal services, score		
Comfortable climate	Survey: Perceived cleanliness of streets and public spaces, score	
	Extreme temperatures score (Celsius degrees exceeding limits of extreme temperature)	
	Average number of hours of sunshine per year	

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Livability	Comfortable climate	Number of months with a comfortable daytime temperature
		The average annual temperature difference, degree Celsius
	Consumption of goods and services	Square meters of retail space per 100,000 population
		Number of points of sale per 100,000 population
		Working hours of main shops, score
		Number of local farmers' markets with the opportunity to buy fresh food, per 100,000 population
		Penetration rate of non-cash payments, %
		Share of the population using Internet sales channels, %
		The presence and variety of the most well-known luxury goods shops, score
		Non-Food Price Index
		Survey: Availability of grocery stores within walking distance, score
		Survey: Frequency of using food delivery apps or websites, score
	Ecology	Survey: Share of respondents working from home at least 2 days/week, %
		Share of solid household waste that is recycled or recovered
		Air quality: PM2.5 content
		Air quality: PM10 content
		Air quality: NO2 content
		Air quality: O3 content
		Commitment of city to sustainability actions
		Share of children aged 4 attending kindergartens, %
	Education and development	Literacy rate among residents over the age of 15, %
		Number of students per teacher
		PIRLS test results
		PISA test results
		International Olympiad results across 8 disciplines
		Share of population aged 5-18 that attends public school, %
		Share of population with tertiary education, %
		Number of universities in top 200 of international rankings
		Survey: Accessibility and affordability of pre-school education, score
		Survey: Children's participation in sports activities, score
		Survey: Children's participation in after-school activities, score

1. All survey questions, unless otherwise indicated, are measured on a 0-100 scale, with 0 denoting the lowest score and 100 the highest. All survey results have been normalized to this scale for comparability.

Cities of Choice 4.0 indicators (II/IV)

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Livability	Entertainment and recreation	Number of cinemas per 100,000 population Number restaurants per 100,000 population Number of fitness centers and swimming pools per 100,000 population Number of libraries per 100,000 population Number of museums per 100,000 population Number of theaters per 100,000 population Number of world highest-grossing concert tours held in the city in 10 years Number of Michelin-rated restaurants The presence of significant events in popular sports (football, hockey, tennis, formula-1), units Number of museums in the top 100 most visited art museums in the world according to The Art Newspaper Number of exhibitions hosted by the city's museums ranked among the world's most visited art exhibitions by The Art Newspaper Presence in the ranking of the best cities according to Time Out, 0-1 Survey: Availability of leisure and entertainment opportunities, score Survey: Frequency of using apps or websites to find cultural and entertainment activities, score Survey: Population regularly engaged in sports, %
	Health care	Number of hospital beds per 100,000 population Number of doctors per 100,000 population Number of ambulances per 100,000 population Life expectancy at birth, years Average healthy life expectancy, years Number of nurses per 100,000 population Obesity rate, % Availability of a unified appointment system for medical health (both private and public systems), score 0-2 Survey: Perceived politeness and competence of medical personnel, score Survey: Average waiting time for non-urgent medical appointments, days Survey: Participation in healthy lifestyle programs during the past year, %

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Livability	Health care	Survey: Share of respondents who had a medical check-up in the past year, % Survey: Frequency of using apps or websites for managing personal health, score
	Housing	Number of square meters of housing space per person, sq m Presence of measures/government schemes supporting affordability of residential property, 0-2 (no program - city level program) Number of hours that a person needs to work to purchase 1 m2 of housing Average mortgage payment relative to average monthly household disposable income, % Number of offerings of rental housing per city population The average cost of renting a one-room apartment outside the city's downtown area in relation to the average monthly disposable income for a household, % Extreme or insufficient population density for urban area, people/km2 The share of the utility costs in the average monthly disposable household income, % Level of domestic comfort (the share of housing equipped with washing and dishwasher machines and Internet access), % Survey: Availability of suitable housing options, score Survey: Frequency of using smart home apps or websites, score Survey: Satisfaction with housing conditions, score Survey: Frequency of using apps or websites for utility management, score Survey: Satisfaction with quality of home utilities, score
Livability	Mobility	Length of subway lines / urban area of the city, km Number of passengers that use public transport per year per 1,000 urban city population Share of population that has convenient access to public transport, % Availability of dedicated lanes for Public transport, Yes/No Presence of infrastructure for velo transport, ranking Density of metro stations, #/km2 Average time lost in traffic jams, hour / year Avg length of the road network & driveways to the number of cars, km/100K cars Number of taxis per 100,000 population

Cities of Choice 4.0 indicators (III/IV)

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Livability	Mobility	Availability of public transport in night hours, score
		Cost of a monthly public transport ticket / monthly earnings, %
		Number of deaths by road accidents per 100,000 population per year
		Number of public transport modes under one fare system
		Walkability score
		Survey: Frequency of using smart parking apps or websites, score
		Survey: Frequency of using apps or websites to reserve e-bikes/e-scooters, score
		Survey: Average commuting time from home to work or school, minutes
		Survey: Frequency of micromobility trips per person, score
		Survey: Share of residents using bicycle/e-bike/scooter/skateboard for commuting from home to work/study, %
	Public spaces	Survey: Share of residents using public transportation for commuting from home to work/study,%
		Survey: Share of residents walking for commuting from home to work/study,%
		Share of the city's area allocated for green spaces, %
		Share of population living within convenient walking distance to open public space, %
		Number of children's playgrounds per 100,000 population
	Resilience to emergency situations	Survey: Availability of senior friendly infrastructure, score
		Survey: Average weekly time spent outdoors, hours
		Survey: Sidewalks are in good condition, convenient, not slippery or snowy, score
		Number of intensive care beds per 100,000 population
		Resilience strategy (incl. sustainability, to extreme natural disasters, terrorism/war) in place, score
		Number of emergency service personnel per 100,000 population
		Stability of the city's economic system in the event of economic instability, coefficient
		Level of development for the insurance system: ratio of gross written premium to GDP
		Availability of free city-level psychological support services, 0 -1

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Livability	Resilience to emergency situations	Level of exposure to natural disasters and estimated potential impact of natural disasters, score
		Mortality rate from infectious diseases, %
		Number of deaths from natural disasters in the last 10 years per 100,000 population
		Number of victims of terrorist attacks in the last 10 years per 100,000 population
	Inclusivity and equality	Number of deaths from terrorist attacks in the last 10 years per 100,000 population
		Share of disabled people of working age who are employed,%
	Identity with culture and history	Inclusiveness Index
		The share of public transport accessible to people with disabilities,%
		The number of UNESCO cultural heritage sites, units
		Number of nominations for prestigious international contemporary architecture awards over the past 10 years
Social capital	Safety	The number of films from the IMDb list of top 250, which take place in the city
		Survey: Pride in the city's history and culture, score
		Number of CCTV cameras within city area
		Murders per year per 100,000 population
		Street lighting, Watt/(cm2*steradian)
		Survey: Awareness of incidents of physical assault, robbery, or harassment among acquaintances, score
		Survey: Respondents sentiment of safety in the city, score
		Survey: Residents concern about being physically attacked or robbed while in a public space, score
	Social connections	Survey: Residents concern about personal belongings being stolen, score
		Helping a stranger, %
		Share of people participating in donating money, %
		Survey: Share of population considering oneself part of a certain community, %
		Survey: Share of population that participated in local community activities at least once during the past year, %
		Survey: Number of neighbors trusted to look after children

Cities of Choice 4.0 indicators (IV/IV)

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Social capital	Social connections	Survey: Number of neighbors personally known
		Survey: Number of times of meet-ups with friends/colleagues outside of work per month
		Survey: Level of trust in people within the city, score
		Survey: Availability of longevity programs, score
		Survey: Share of population feeling lonely the day before, %
Engagement with governments	Ability to influence events	Ability to vote for the city head, score
		Ability to solve most popular problems using online tools, score
		Availability of a special mobile app for citizens to influence the features of the city development, score
		Survey: Perceived ability to influence things in the city, score
	Government services	E-Government Development Index (EGDI)
		Survey: Easiness and effectiveness of obtaining public services, score
	Business environment	Number of coworkings per 100,000 population
		Number of business incubators & accelerators per 100,000 population
		Cost of business start-up procedures, % of GNI per capita
		Time required to start a business, days
		Survey: Availability of support for starting a business, score
		Survey: Efficiency of the business startup process, score
Speed of change	Speed of change in economic opportunities	Survey: Favorability of regulatory, tax, and law enforcement systems for business operations, score
		Real household income: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		GINI coefficient: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Survey: Job opportunities & cost of living have improved over past five years, score
	Speed of change in engagement with governments	Survey: Financial situation has improved over the past three years, score
		Average annual change in unemployment (2014-2024)
		E-Government Development Index (EGDI): change in score over the last 10 years (2014 - 2024)
		Survey: Government services have improved over the past five years, score
		Survey: I trust the city authorities more today than I did three years ago, score

Dimension	Subdimension	Indicator name
Speed of change	Speed of change in livability	Average mortgage payment relative to average monthly household disposable income (2024 / 2014)
		Average cost of renting an apartment versus the average monthly income: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Number square meters of living space per person: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Number of new subway stations built within the last 10 years (2014 - 2024)
		Average life expectancy at birth: average growth rate (2014 - 2024)
	Speed of change in social capital	Students' results in the PISA test: change over 10 years
		Number of retail outlets per 100,000 population: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Air quality: PM2.5 content, average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Survey: In general, over the past three years, the city has become better as a place to live, score
		Number of crimes per year per 100,000 population: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Number of murders per year per 100,000 population: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Helping a stranger: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Share of people participating in donating money: average annual growth rate (2014 - 2024)
		Survey: Safety has improved over the past five years, score
		Survey: Over the past three years, people in the city have become more open to communication and tolerant, score

Disclaimer

The services and materials provided by Boston Consulting Group (BCG) are subject to BCG's Standard Terms (a copy of which is available upon request) or such other agreement as may have been previously executed by BCG. BCG does not provide legal, accounting, or tax advice. The Client is responsible for obtaining independent advice concerning these matters. This advice may affect the guidance given by BCG. Further, BCG has made no undertaking to update these materials after the date hereof, notwithstanding that such information may become outdated or inaccurate.

The materials contained in this presentation are designed for the sole use by the board of directors or senior management of the Client and solely for the limited purposes described in the presentation. The materials shall not be copied or given to any person or entity other than the Client ("Third Party") without the prior written consent of BCG. These materials serve only as the focus for discussion; they are incomplete without the accompanying oral commentary and may not be relied on as a stand-alone document. Further, Third Parties may not, and it is unreasonable for any Third Party to, rely on these materials for any purpose whatsoever. To the fullest extent permitted by law (and except to the extent otherwise agreed in a signed writing by BCG), BCG shall have no liability whatsoever to any Third Party, and any Third Party hereby waives any rights and claims it may have at any time against BCG with regard to the services, this presentation, or other materials, including the accuracy or completeness thereof. Receipt and review of this document shall be deemed agreement with and consideration for the foregoing.

BCG does not provide fairness opinions or valuations of market transactions, and these materials should not be relied on or construed as such. Further, the financial evaluations, projected market and financial information, and conclusions contained in these materials are based upon standard valuation methodologies, are not definitive forecasts, and are not guaranteed by BCG. BCG has used public and/or confidential data and assumptions provided to BCG by the Client. BCG has not independently verified the data and assumptions used in these analyses. Changes in the underlying data or operating assumptions will clearly impact the analyses and conclusions.



bcg.com